Rostas

Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

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Fair, automatic, kind rostering for churches and volunteer organisations.

What is Rostas?

Rostas is your organisation's volunteer roster assistant. It handles the time-consuming, people-sensitive work of building rosters, collecting availability, and finding replacements when someone can't make it — automatically, fairly, and kindly.

Once set up, Rostas runs most of the roster cycle on its own. Your job shifts from juggling spreadsheets and chasing people by text to simply reviewing what Rostas has prepared and pressing go.

How Rostas Works — The Big Picture

Rostas works in a rhythm that repeats every few weeks. The six-step Roster Wizard guides you through each stage in order:



The six-step roster lifecycle. The Roster Wizard guides you through each step — each stage is triggered by a single button.

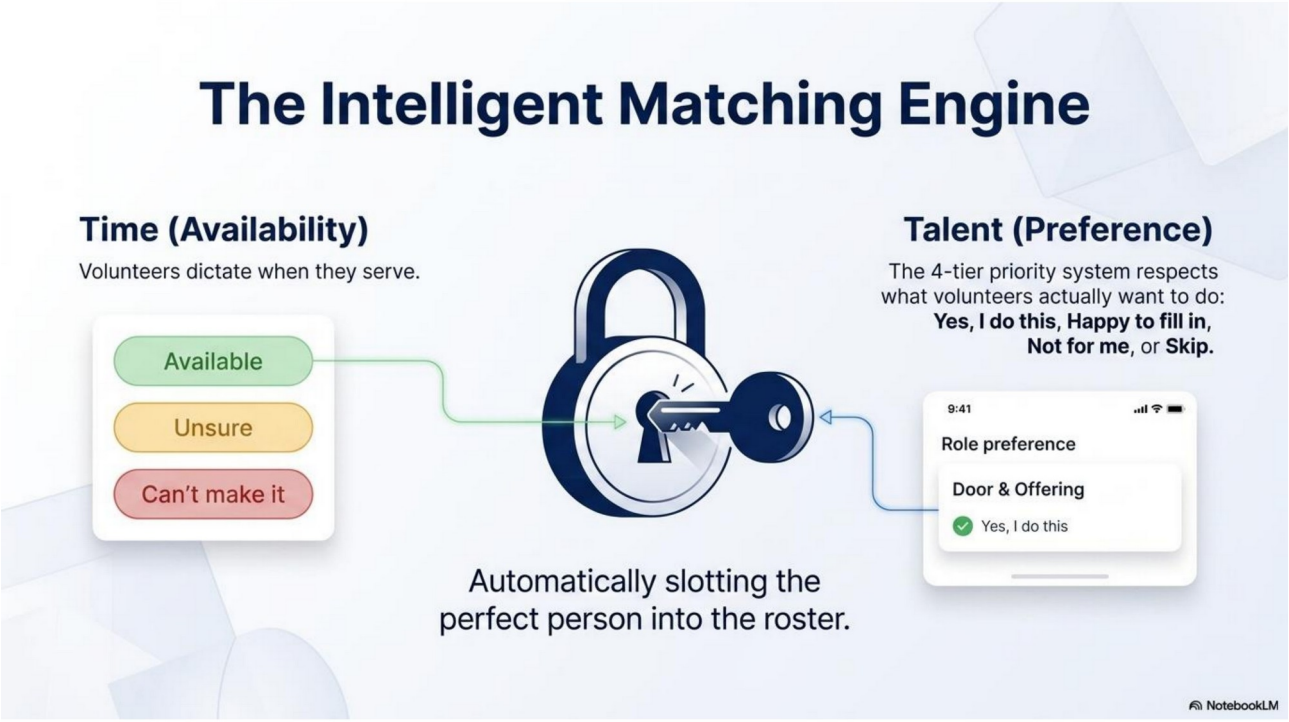


The Builds dashboard — your starting point for each roster cycle. Each roster type is a full-width row showing its current state, recent and upcoming dates, and a menu of actions. Click a row's state button to open its wizard.

Key Concepts

Availability — Simple for Volunteers

Before each build, Rostas can email your volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available for. Volunteers receive a personalised link and see a simple calendar of dates. Everything starts as **Available** — volunteers only change the dates they can't make.

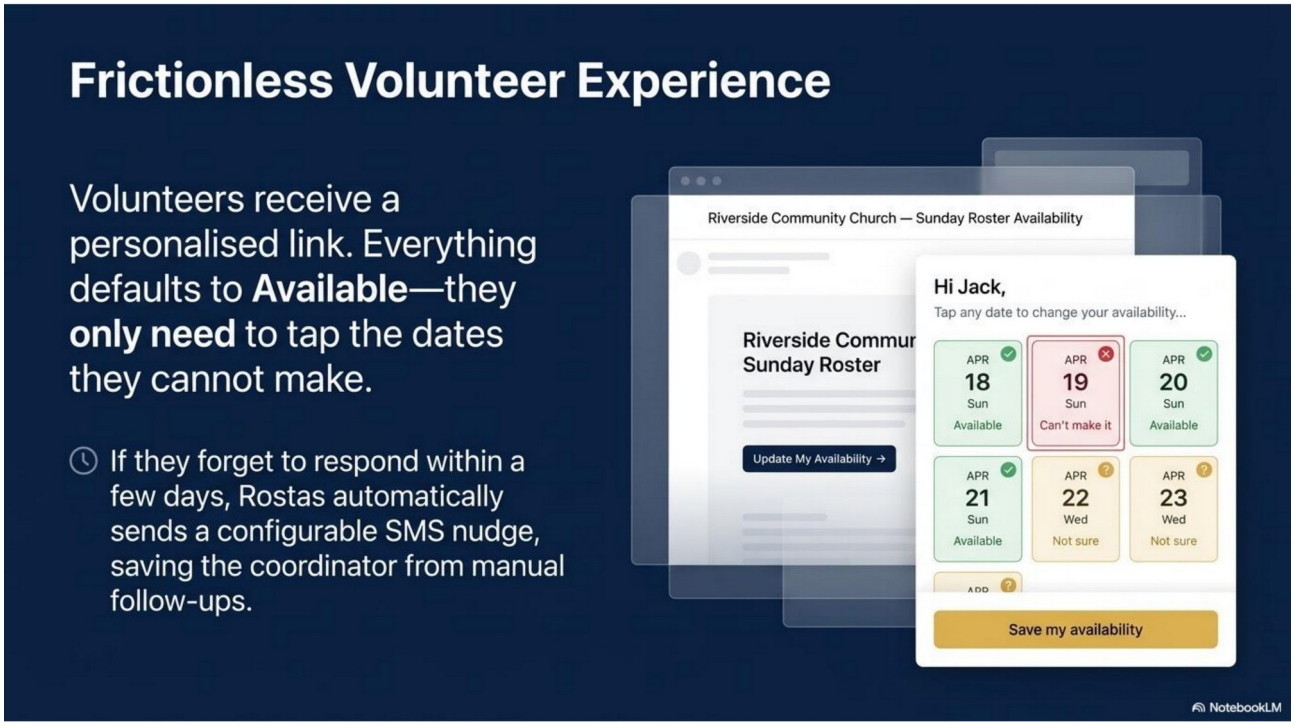


Volunteers tap their dates on a simple form. Everything defaults to Available — they only mark the dates they can't make.

> **If a volunteer doesn't respond**, Rostas can send an automatic SMS nudge after a configurable number of days. No manual chasing needed.

The Intelligent Matching Engine

The roster engine doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a four-tier priority system that respects both when volunteers can serve and what they actually want to do:

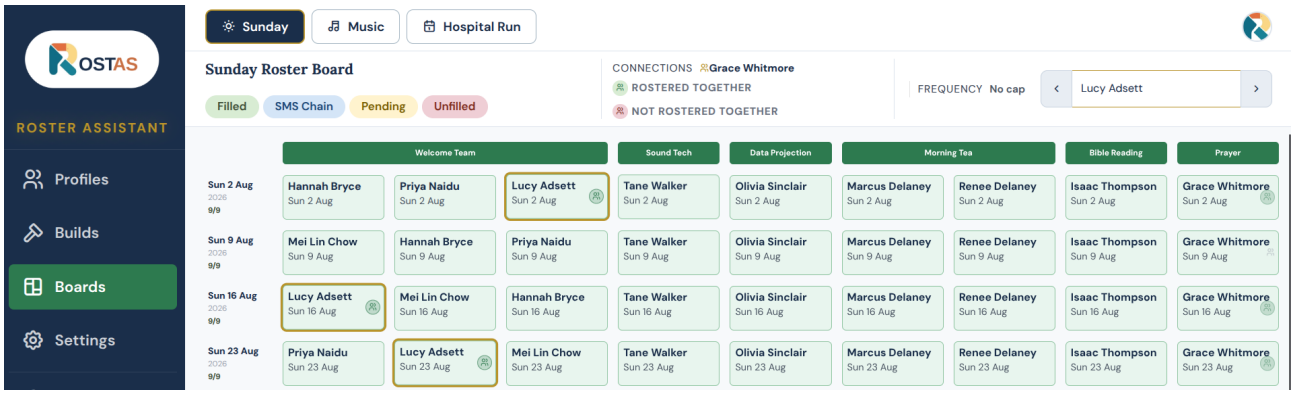


The engine combines availability (when volunteers can serve) with role preferences (what they want to do) to find the best person for every slot.

Within each tier, Rostas picks the volunteer who has served least in recent weeks (counting all their roles), then whoever did this particular role longest ago — keeping things fair automatically over time without any manual tracking.

The Roster Board

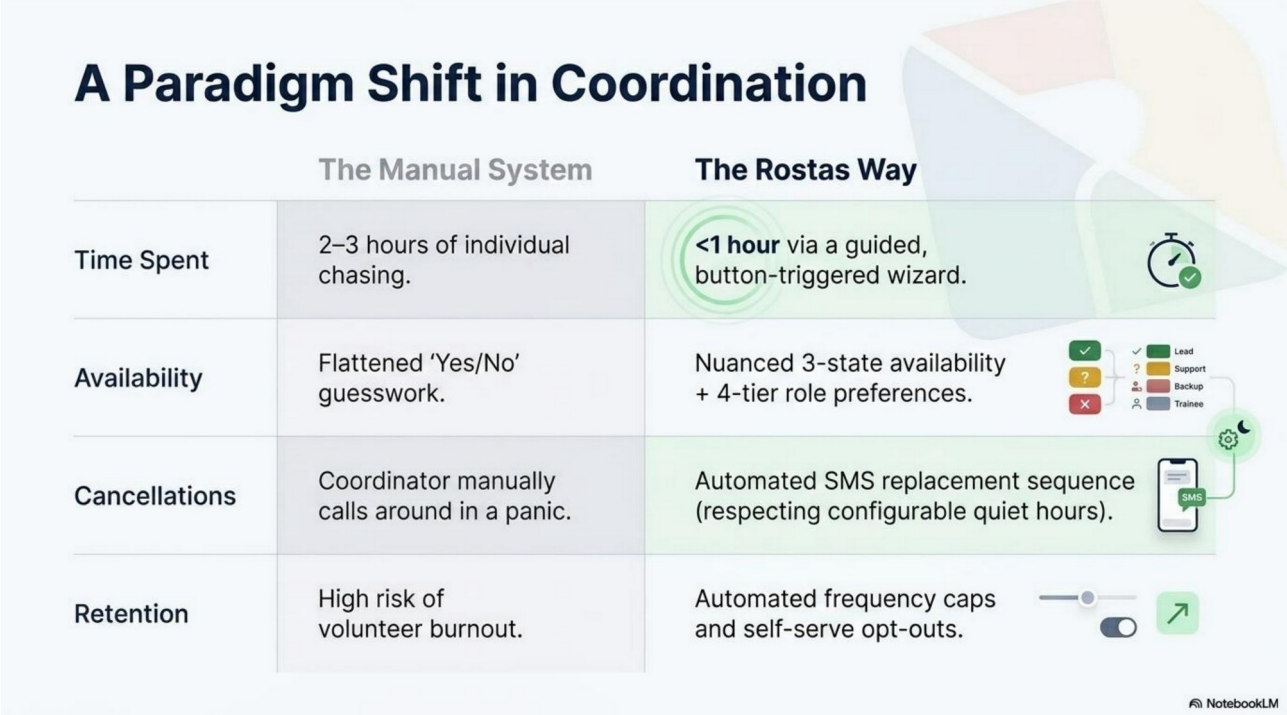
The Board is your day-to-day view of the current roster. It shows every slot, every date, and every volunteer assignment at a glance. A traffic light colour system tells you instantly what's filled, what's pending, and what needs attention.



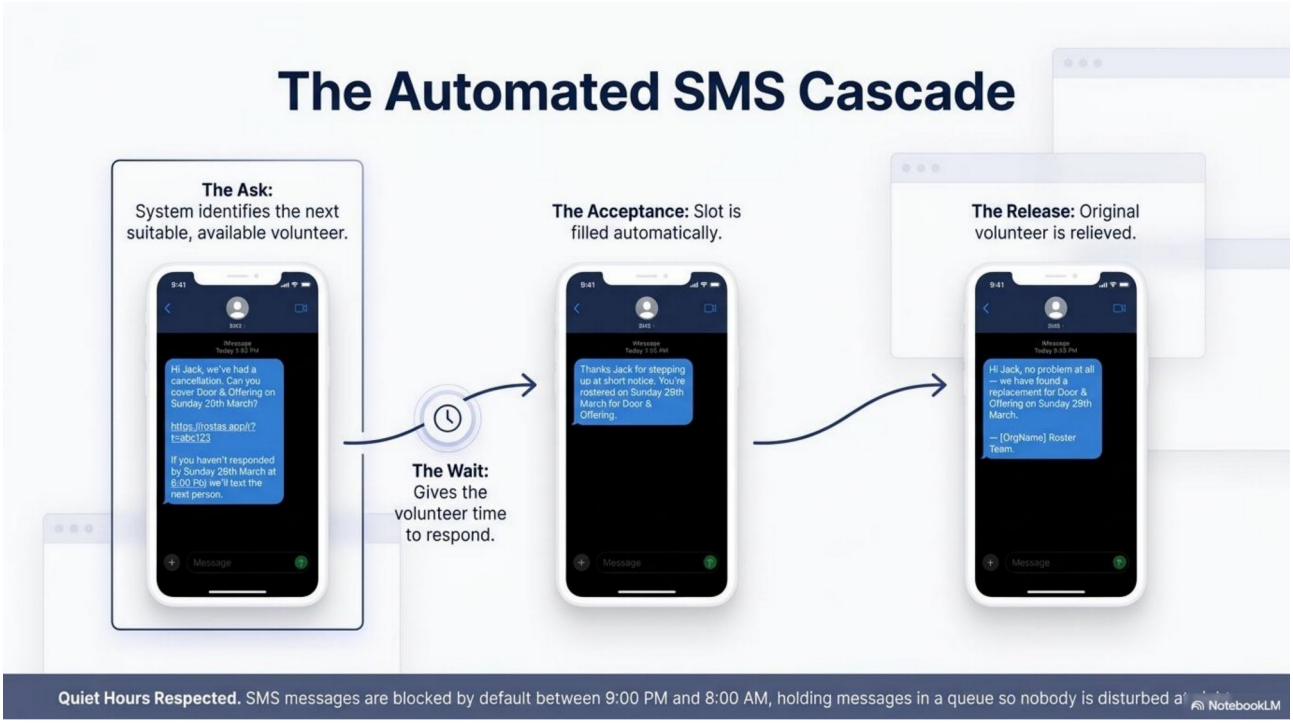
The Roster Board — dates run down the left, roles across the top. Click any cell to select it and take action. Use the roster type tabs at the top to switch between rosters.

The Automated SMS Replacement Chain

When a rostered volunteer can't make it, they tap a link in their notification email. Rostas immediately starts working through the backup list — no coordinator involvement needed.



Every notification includes a "Can't make it?" link. When tapped, the automated replacement engine starts — the coordinator's phone doesn't ring.



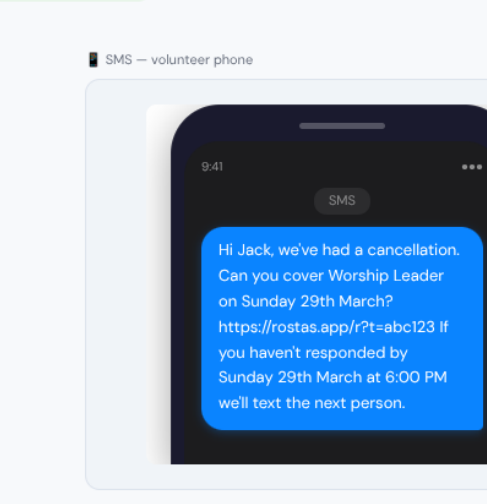
The SMS replacement chain: Rostas texts the next suitable volunteer, waits for a reply, and keeps going until the slot is filled. The original volunteer is automatically released once a replacement accepts.

Quiet hours are always respected. Rostas never sends automated SMS during your quiet hours. If the replacement chain reaches a volunteer during that window, it pauses and resumes automatically once quiet hours end. You set the start and end times in Settings → Timing & behaviour (the default is 9pm–8am).

Every reply-seeking message — the automated chain above, Manual Replacement, and a Cross-Roster Ask — decides how to reach the volunteer the same way, in this order:

> You can see and edit the wording for every tier — including the app-push text and the SMS — in Settings: text wording is under **SMS**, app-notification wording under **App**, and email wording under **Email wording**.

The Tier 2 message contains a **personalised link** straight to the volunteer's accept / decline page. There's nothing to type and no separate entry page to visit — they just tap the link in the text.



What a replacement request looks like on a volunteer's phone — a short message with a direct link to accept or decline.

Looking After Your Volunteers

Rostas is designed with your volunteers in mind, not just your roster.

Who Does What

Rostas is designed so that most of the routine work happens automatically. Here's how responsibilities divide between you, your volunteers, and Rostas:

> **Rostas doesn't replace your judgement.** There will be times when you want to override what Rostas has built — swap two people, add someone manually, or put a slot on hold. The Board makes all of this easy. Rostas handles the routine so you can focus on the exceptions.

Where to Start

The guide is organised into seven parts and an appendix. Jump to the section that matches where you are right now:

When you open Rostas for the first time, the setup wizard runs automatically. It takes about five minutes and covers the essentials — your organisation name, your contact details, and a quick SMS test to make sure everything is working before your first roster build.

The wizard runs once. After it's complete, Rostas opens directly to the Builds dashboard on every future visit.

> **Before you start:** have your Rostas licence key ready — it's in your Rostas welcome email. If someone else at your organisation has already set Rostas up, you don't need this wizard: ask them to forward you the coordinator link (see Your coordinator link).

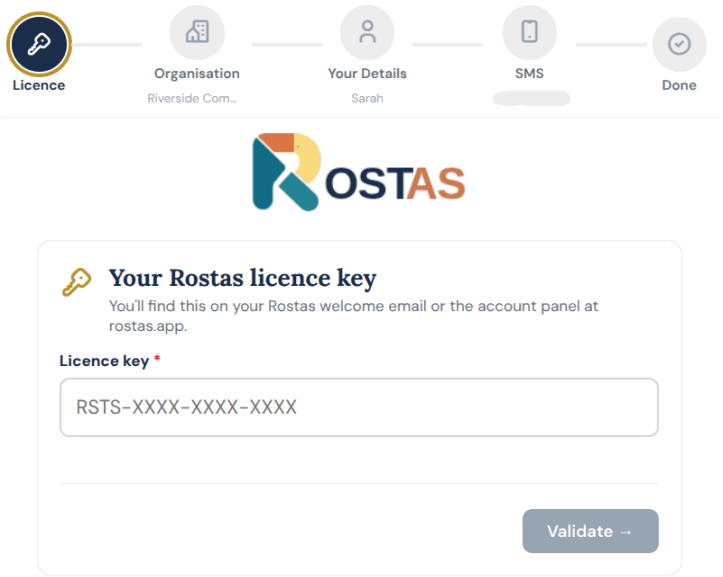
> **Signed in to more than one Google account?** If your browser is signed in to two Google accounts at once (for example your personal Gmail and the church account), the setup page won't open: you'll see **"Sorry, unable to open the file at this time"**. This is a Google limitation, not a fault in your copy. The simplest fix is to make a **Church** browser profile with only the church account in it, and do the setup there. It takes two minutes. See Put Rostas on your desktop. For a quick one-off, you can also open the setup link in a private window (Chrome: **Ctrl+Shift+N** on Windows, **⌘+Shift+N** on a Mac).

The Setup Wizard

The wizard has five steps — Licence, Organisation, Your Details, SMS and Done — shown across the top of the screen. You can see at a glance how far through you are and what's coming next.

Step 1 — Licence

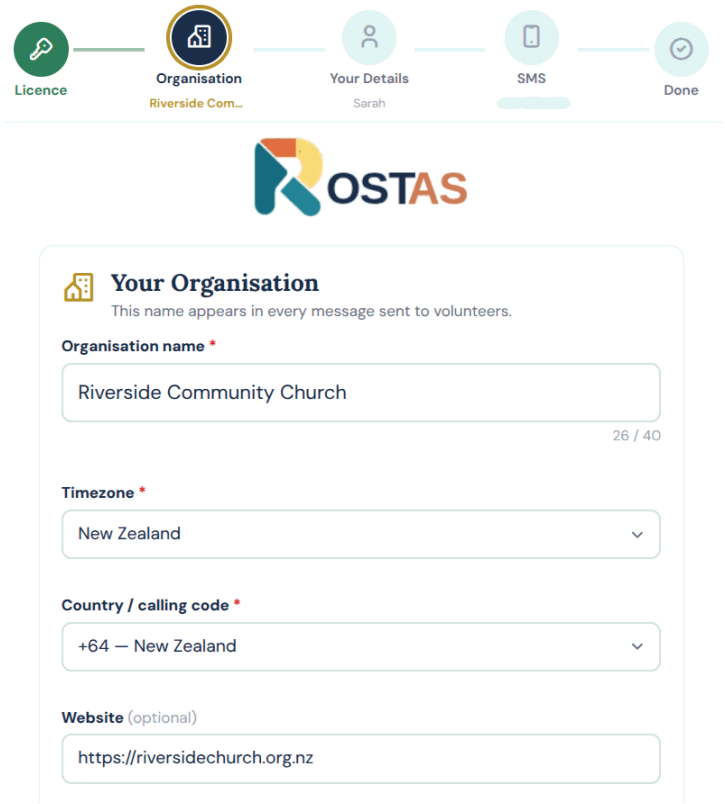
Enter the licence key from your Rostas welcome email (it looks like **RSTS-XXXX-XXXX-XXXX**; you can also find it in your account at rostas.app) and click **Validate →**. Rostas checks it and moves you on to your organisation's details. If the key isn't accepted, check it for typos, then contact support@rostas.app.



Step 1 — type or paste your licence key, then click Validate.

Step 2 — Your Organisation

The first step establishes your organisation's identity. The name you enter here appears in every message sent to volunteers — availability emails, roster notifications, and SMS reminders.

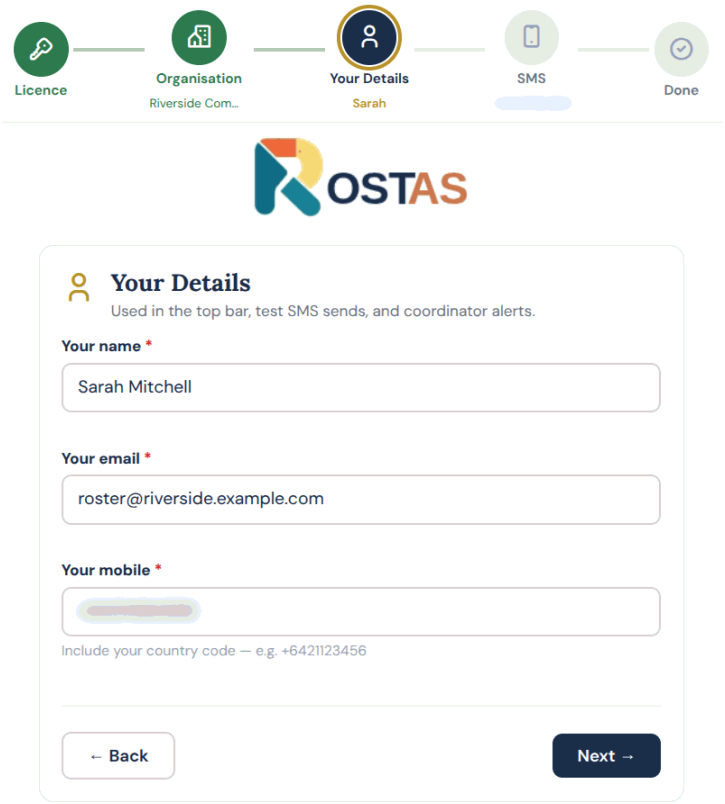


Step 2 — enter your organisation name, timezone, and country code. The name appears in every volunteer-facing message Rostas sends.

Click **Next →** when all required fields are filled. The button stays disabled until everything is valid.

Step 3 — Your Details

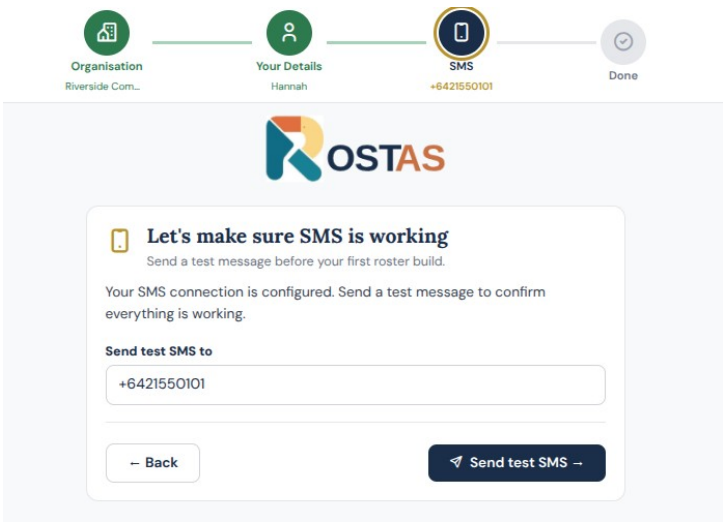
Step 3 captures the primary coordinator's contact details. These are used for the SMS test send, error alerts, and the bottom of the coordinator app sidebar.



Step 3 — enter your name, email address, and mobile number. Your mobile must include the country code.

Step 4 — SMS Test

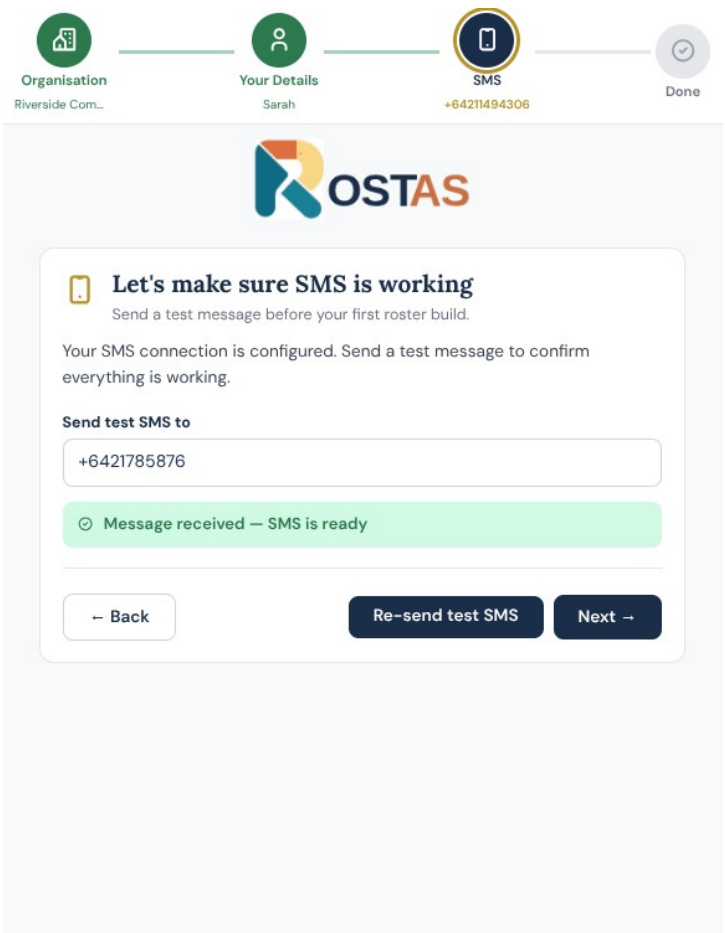
Before your first roster build, Rostas verifies that SMS is working. This step sends a real test message to your mobile so you can confirm everything is set up correctly.



Step 4 — your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 3. Tap "Send test SMS" to send a real test message to your phone.

How to complete Step 4

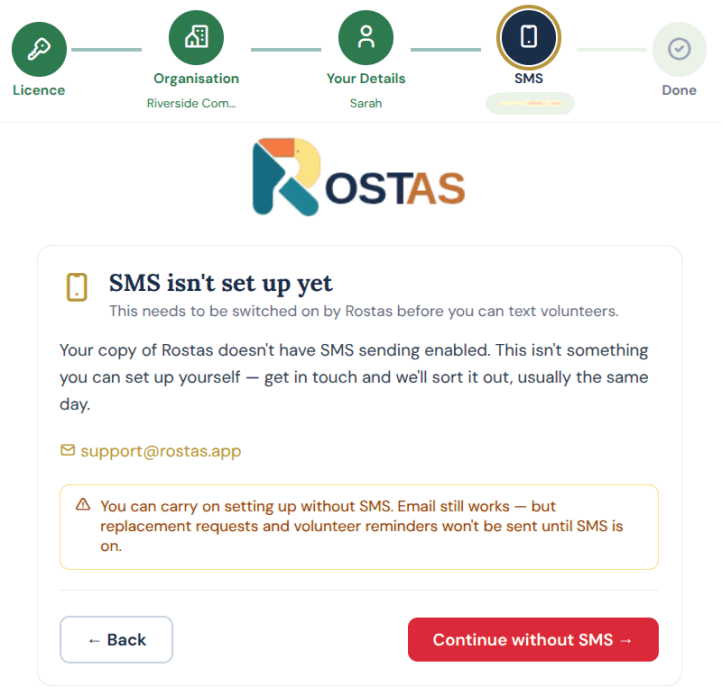
Your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 3. Tap **Send test SMS →** and wait for the message to arrive on your phone — usually within 30 seconds. Once received, a green confirmation appears and the Next button enables.



When the test message arrives, a green "Message received — SMS is ready" confirmation appears. Tap Next to continue.

If the test message doesn't arrive within a minute, check that your mobile number is correct. You can edit the number in the field and try again. If it still fails, email support@rostas.app — SMS sending is set up by Rostas, not something you configure yourself.

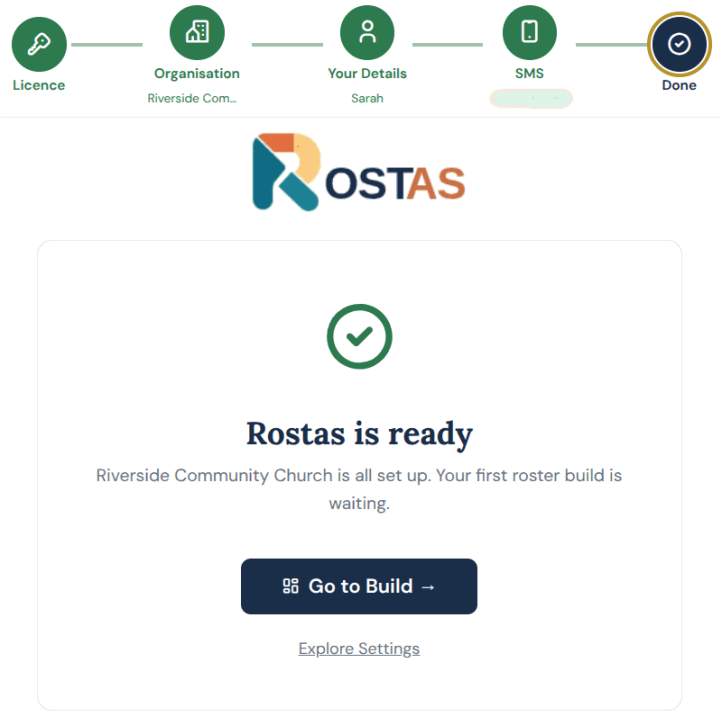
If SMS isn't set up on your copy yet, Step 4 shows a "SMS isn't set up yet" screen instead of the test send, with a link to support@rostas.app and a **Continue without SMS** button. You can finish setup and start using Rostas by email — SMS replacement requests and reminders begin working once SMS is switched on. Your first 20 SMS credits are free; after that, texts use prepaid credit packs (see SMS Credits).



If SMS isn't switched on for your copy yet, Step 4 looks like this. Email support@rostas.app, or click Continue without SMS and carry on.

Step 5 — Done

Once SMS is confirmed, the wizard completes and Rostas is ready to use.



"Rostas is ready" — setup is complete. Click "Go to Build" to open the Builds dashboard and start your first roster cycle.

From here you have two options:

- **Go to Build →** — takes you straight to the Builds dashboard, ready to start your first roster cycle. This is the right choice if your volunteers are already imported.
- **Explore Settings** — opens the Settings view if you want to review or customise anything before you import volunteers or do your first build.

Your coordinator link

When set-up finishes, Rostas emails you a **coordinator link** (to the Organisation email, or your own email if that's blank). This link is how you open Rostas from now on — **bookmark it** on every computer you use. It works like a password for the coordinator screens, so don't forward it to volunteers or post it anywhere.

If you open Rostas without it, you'll see a **Coordinator sign-in** box: paste your coordinator link there, or click **Email me the coordinator link** to have it sent again. A device you've signed in on remembers you, so this is usually only needed once per device.

Put Rostas on your desktop

Most coordinators use Rostas on a computer that's also signed in to their personal Google account. Google can't open Rostas when a browser has two Google accounts signed in, so the best setup is a separate **Church** profile in Chrome with only the church account in it, and a Rostas icon that always opens there. You do this once, and from then on you just click the icon.

Part 1 — Make a Church profile in Chrome

1. Open Chrome as normal.
2. Click your **profile picture** at the top right, just left of the three dots (if you have no picture, it's a small round person outline).
3. Click **Add** (some versions say **Add Chrome profile**).
4. In the new window, click **Sign in** and sign in with the **church Google account only**, the one that owns your copy of Rostas. Don't add any other accounts to this profile.
5. If Chrome asks **"Turn on sync?"**, either answer is fine.
6. Name the profile **Church** and pick a different colour, so you can tell its windows apart, then click **Done**.

Part 2 — Install Rostas as an app

7. In the **Church** window (check the name and colour at the top right), open your coordinator link and wait for Rostas to load.
8. Click the **three dots** (top right) → **Cast, save and share** → **Install page as app…**
9. Name it **Rostas** and click **Install**. Rostas opens in its own window, with the Rostas **R** as its icon.

Always open Rostas from the icon. It always opens in your Church profile, so it works even while your normal Chrome is signed in to other Google accounts, and it keeps working after a restart. If you ever click a Rostas link elsewhere and see "Sorry, unable to open the file", close that tab and use the icon

instead.

What's Next

Rostas is set up. Next, get your volunteers in: head to **Part C — Profiles** to import or add them and set up how each one serves. Once your profiles are in, **Part E — The Roster Cycle** walks you through building your first roster.

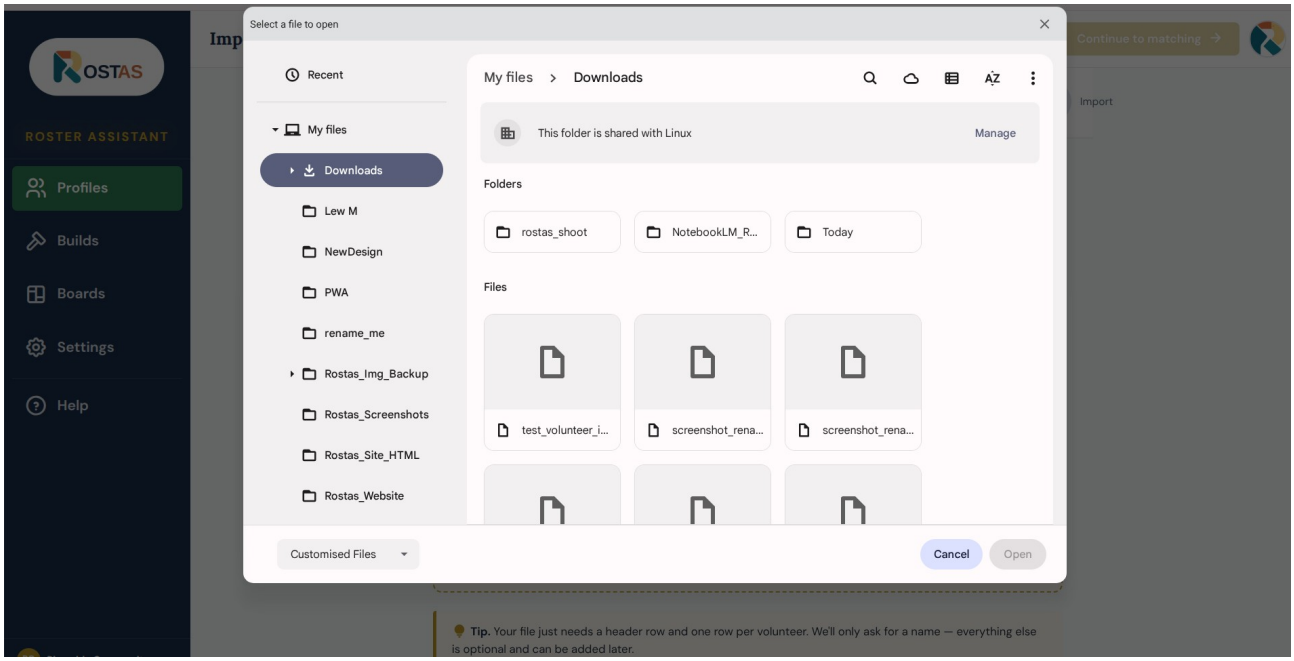
- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact details set
- ✓ SMS test confirmed working
- Volunteers imported or added
- Full profile set up for each volunteer in your first roster build

The Profiles section is where you manage everyone who serves in your organisation. Access it by clicking **Profiles** in the sidebar. From here you can view all volunteers, add new ones, edit details, view role lists, and manage per-roster settings like role preferences, frequency caps, and availability.

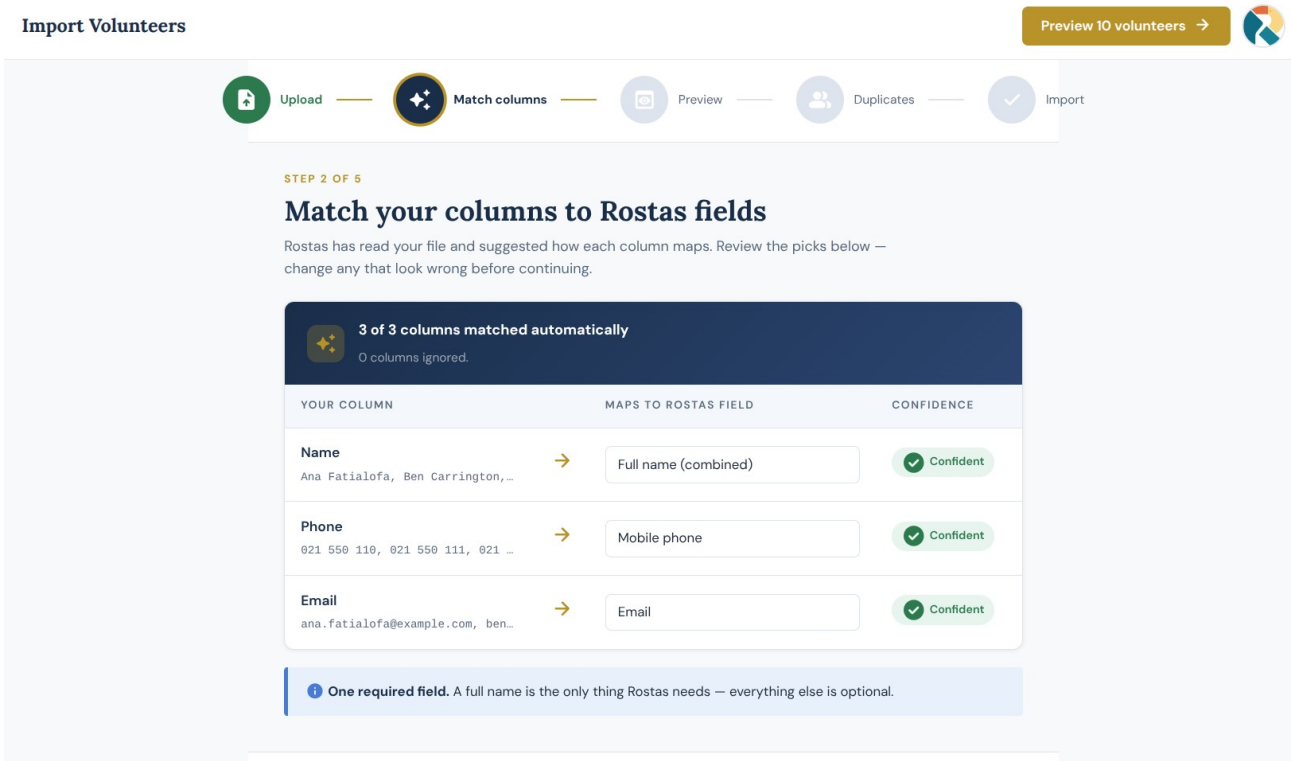
Importing your volunteers from CSV

The quickest way to get your volunteers into Rostas is to import a spreadsheet — from a previous roster system, a church database, or even a simple contact list. This is how most organisations start. If your volunteers already live in another system, you may be able to sync them automatically instead — see the Connector Appendix.

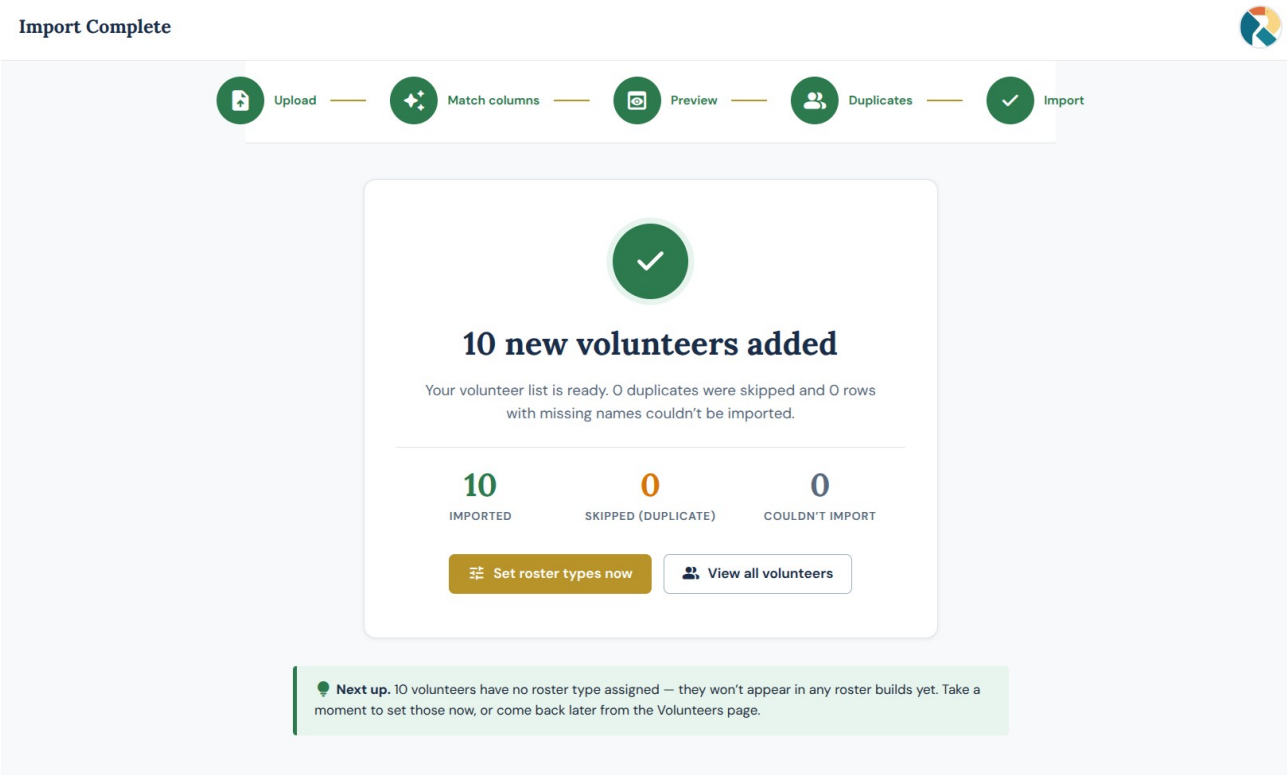
Open the **Profiles** list and click **Import Volunteer CSV** on the toolbar. The import runs in three steps.



Step 1 — choose the spreadsheet file to import.



Step 2 — Rostas matches the columns it recognises automatically; review the rest, map any it wasn't sure about, and check the preview before committing.

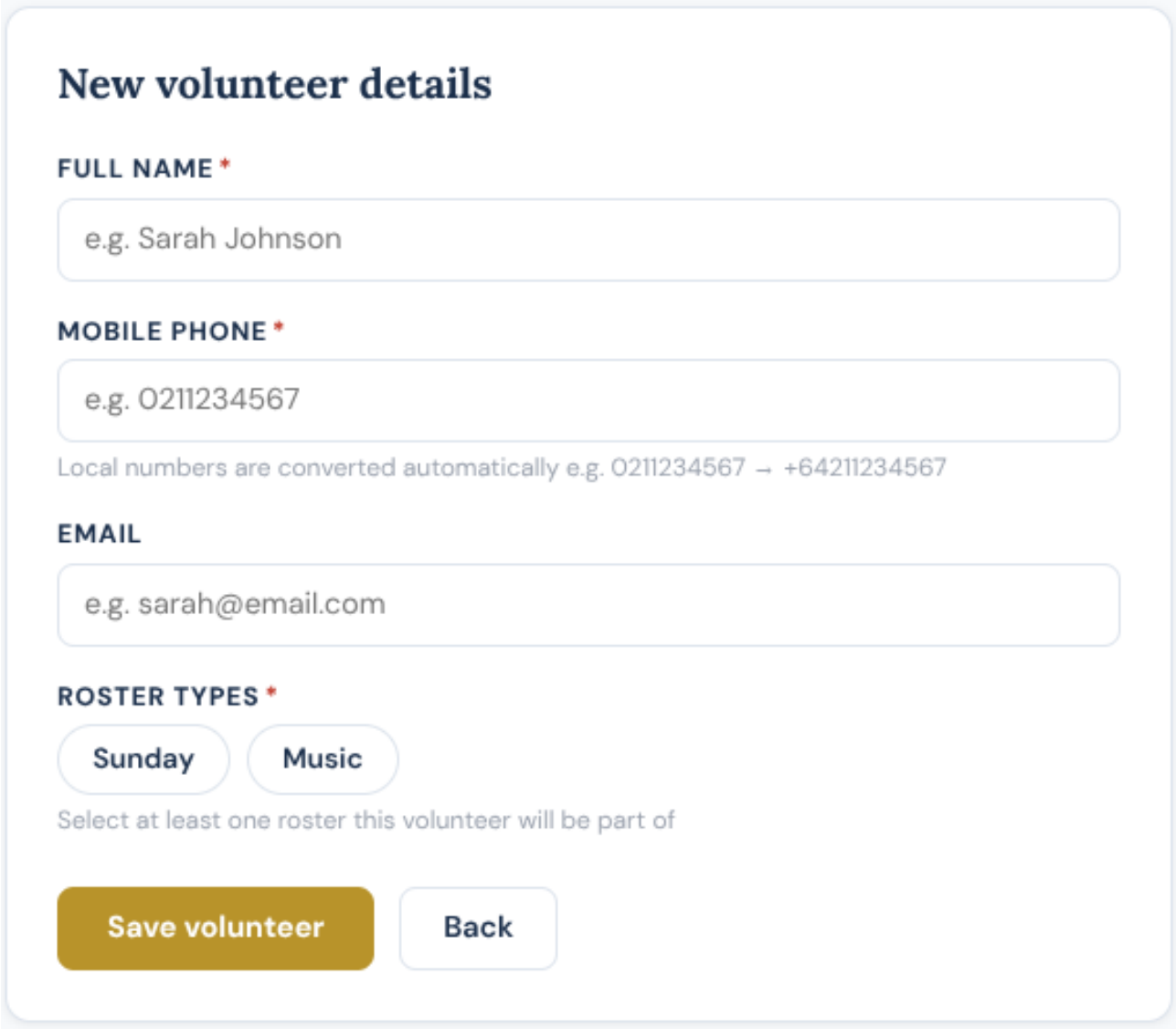


Step 3 — a confirmation of how many volunteers were imported. They appear in the Profiles list straight away.

Your CSV needs at minimum a name and a mobile number. Email is strongly recommended so volunteers can receive availability requests and notifications. If your spreadsheet has a column for roster type, map it during the import and volunteers are assigned to the right rosters automatically. Phone numbers missing a country code are corrected for you.

Adding a volunteer manually

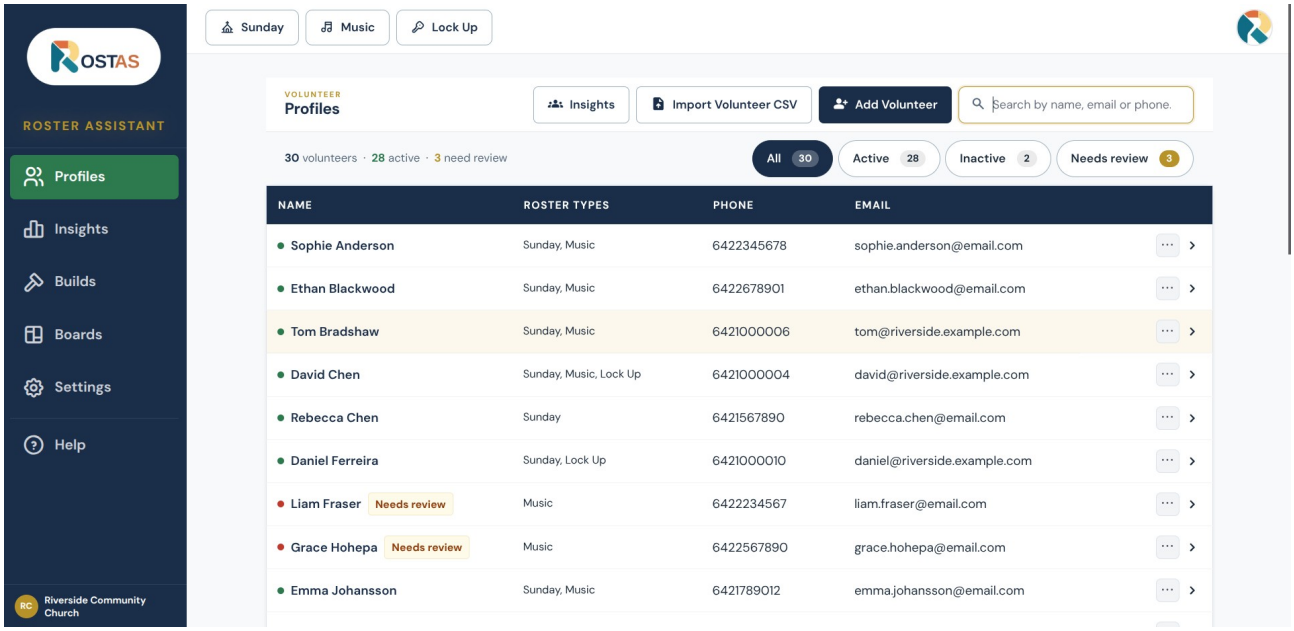
For one-offs — a single new volunteer between imports — click **Add Volunteer** on the Profiles toolbar. Fill in their details and save; they appear in the list immediately and can be included in your next build.



The Add Volunteer form — name, mobile, email, and which roster types they serve in.

The profiles list

Once your volunteers are in, the Profiles list shows everyone — name, roster types, phone, and email — in one place. Search by name, email, or phone, or filter by Roster Type at the top of the page, or Active, Inactive, or All using the chips below the search bar. Click any row to open that volunteer's profile.



The Profiles list — everyone in one place. The toolbar holds Import Volunteer CSV and Add Volunteer; click any row to open a profile.

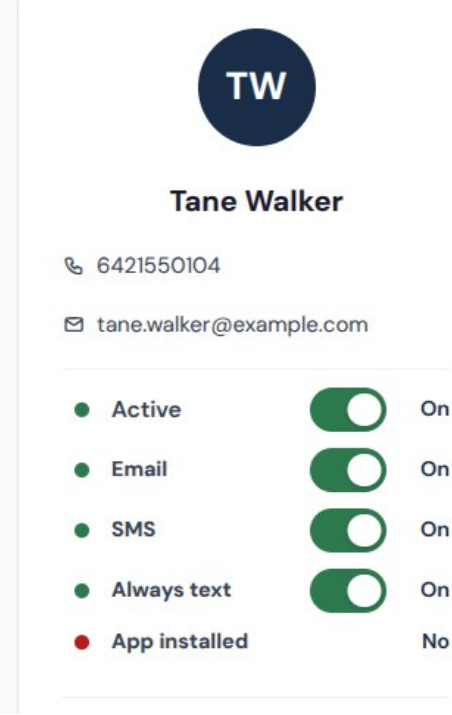
Click any row to open that volunteer's full profile — where you edit their details, set the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with, and view their availability.

The Profile Detail Page

Click any volunteer in the list to open their profile. This is where you manage everything about that person — their contact details, which rosters they serve in, the roles they do, how often they serve, who they serve alongside, and their availability. The left panel holds their contact details and a tab pill per roster type; the right panel holds the settings for whichever roster tab is selected, so each roster a volunteer serves in has its own independent setup.

Contact details & toggles

The left panel shows the volunteer's name, phone, email, and status, with four toggles that control how Rostas treats them, plus an automatic App Installed indicator described below:

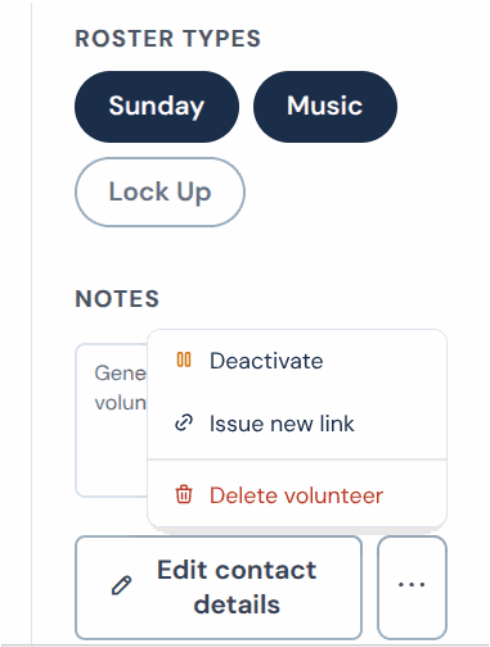


The left panel's toggles. "Always text" is the last — it opts a volunteer in to reminder texts even when they'd normally be reached by email.

> It's a handy way to spot who's worth encouraging toward the app: a red dot is your cue to mention it next time you see that volunteer, or to send them their app link straight away. Getting more volunteers onto the app pays off twice over — it makes it easier for them to check and adjust their own roster, and every reminder the app can deliver in place of a text is one less SMS your organisation pays for.

Issuing a volunteer a new link

Every volunteer's emails, texts and app carry a link that is private to them. Anyone holding that link can see their roster, reply for them and set up the app as them, so treat it like a key. If a link may have got into the wrong hands, give the volunteer a new one: open their profile, click the ⋯ button beside **Edit contact details**, and choose **Issue new link**.



The ⋯ button beside Edit contact details opens this menu. Issue new link is the middle option.

Use it when:

- A volunteer **forwarded** one of their emails or texts to someone else.
- Their phone was **lost, stolen, or sold** with the app still on it.
- They see **"This link has already set up the app on 3 devices"** when setting up the app. Each link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets.

Rostas asks you to confirm first. Straight away:

- Their **old links stop working**, including links in earlier emails and texts. Anyone who opens one sees "This link has been replaced — please use the link in your latest email or text."
- The **app signs out** on every phone it was set up on, and app notifications stop until they set it up again.
- Their **next email or text carries the new link**. They set the app up again from that link, just as the first time (see How volunteers install it).

> **Let the volunteer know.** Issuing a new link doesn't send anything, so the volunteer won't have their new link until their next Rostas email or text arrives. Tell them their app has signed out and that the new link is on its way.

Roles — what they do

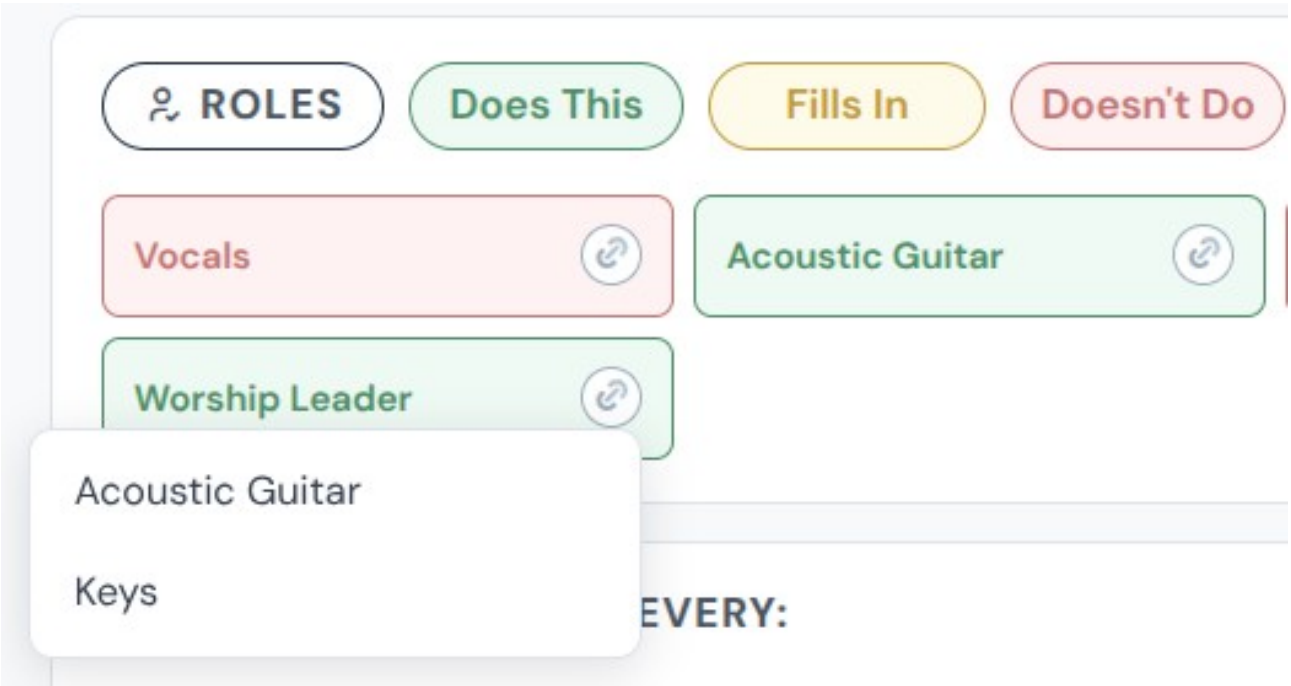
The Roles section on the right panel is where you set which roles this volunteer performs in this roster. Each role shows as **Does This**, **Fills In**, or **Doesn't Do**



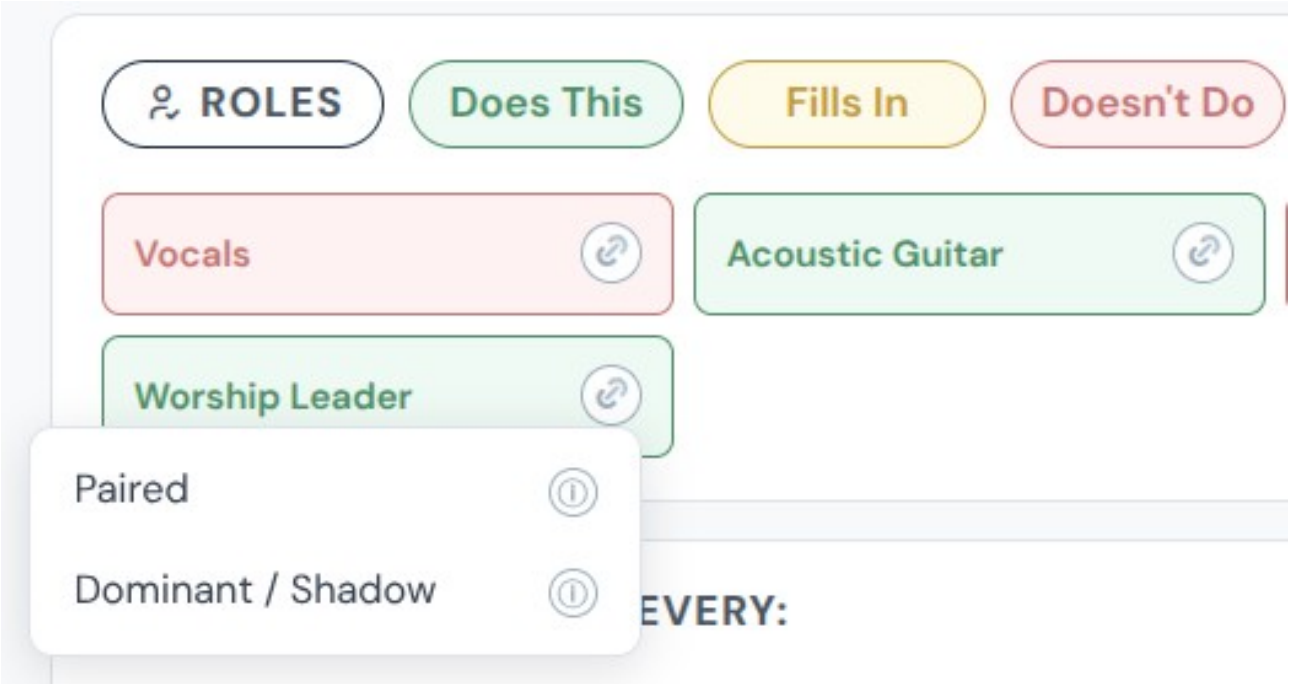
The Roles section. Set each role to Does This (a primary role they do regularly), Fills In (they'll cover it when needed), or Doesn't Do.

Linking roles together

Sometimes two roles should travel together — Say a worship leader always also plays an acoustic guitar. Role linking handles this. Both roles must be set to **Does This** first; then click the link icon (🔗) on a role card to open a dropdown of roles you can link it to, and choose the link type.



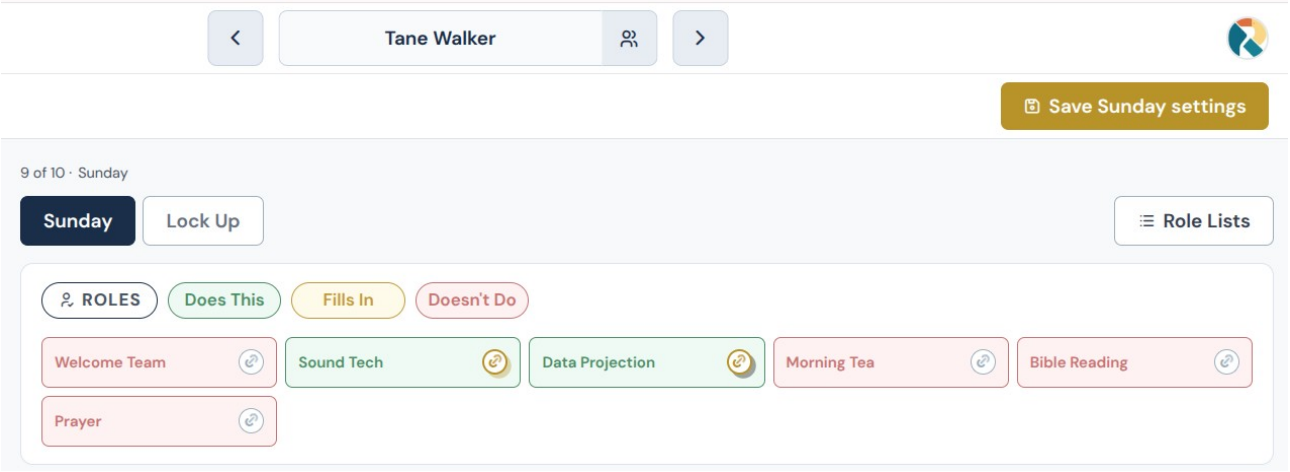
Clicking a role's link icon lists the other roles it can be linked to.



After picking a role, choose the link type — Equal Paired or Dominant—Shadow.

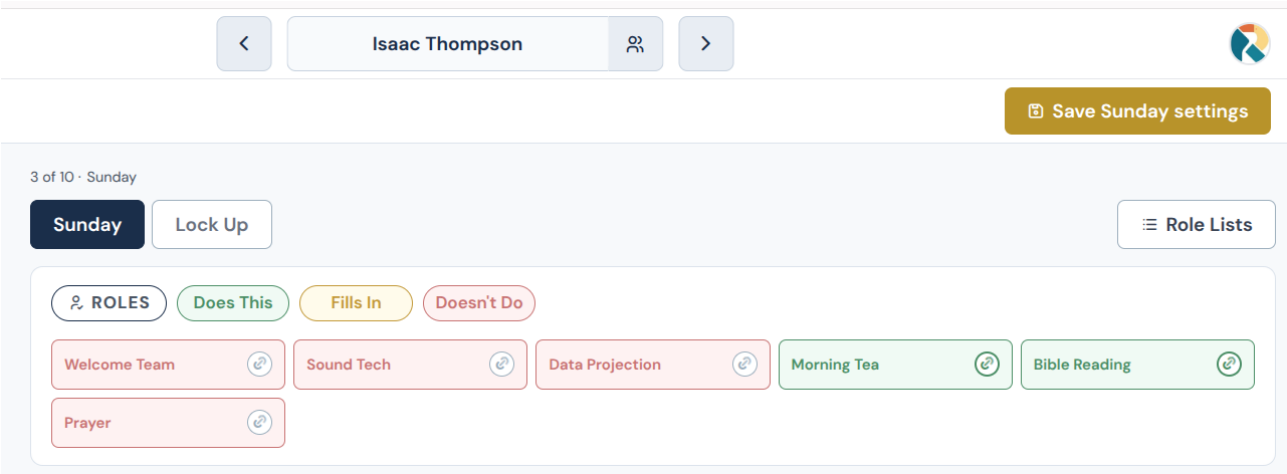
Linked roles are ringed on the profile so you can see the relationship at a glance.

A **gold drop-shadow** marks the dominant role, a **grey drop-shadow** its shadow pairing.



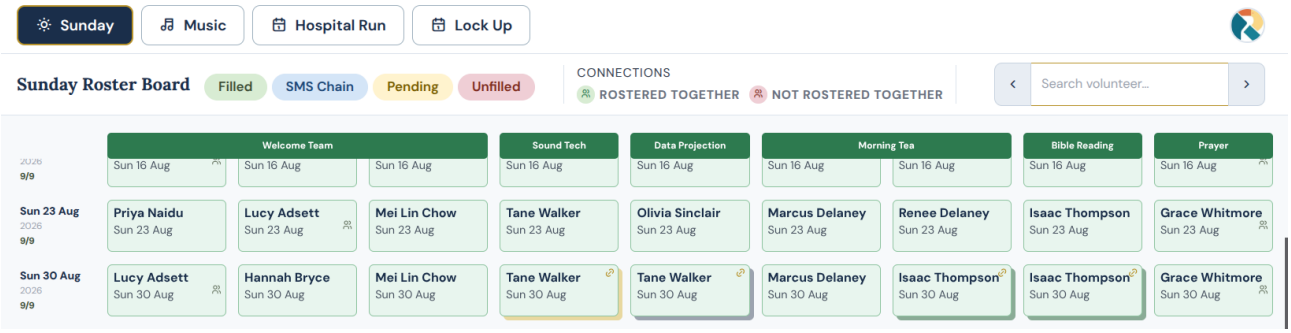
Gold drop-shadow and grey drop-shadow pairing

A highlighted g**reen circle border** marks paired roles in profile settings.



Paired roles are marked with a green border on the profile.

On the Board, the matching assignment cards carry the same colours.

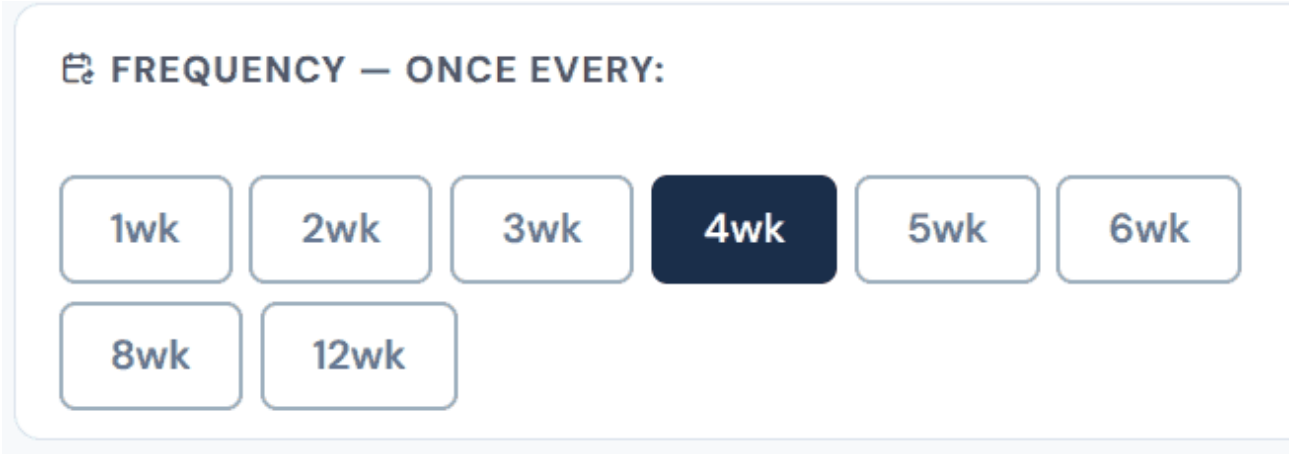


On the Board, a linked pair's cards share a colour — so a linked assignment is easy to spot.

> **To change or remove a link**, click the link icon on an already-linked role — the dropdown then shows the linked partner and an option to unlink.

Frequency — how often they serve

The Frequency control — labelled **ONCE EVERY** — caps how often this volunteer is rostered in this roster, so nobody is over-used even when they're always available. Tap a pill: once every **1wk**, **2wk**, and so on up to **12wk**. If none is set, Rostas uses once every 4 weeks.

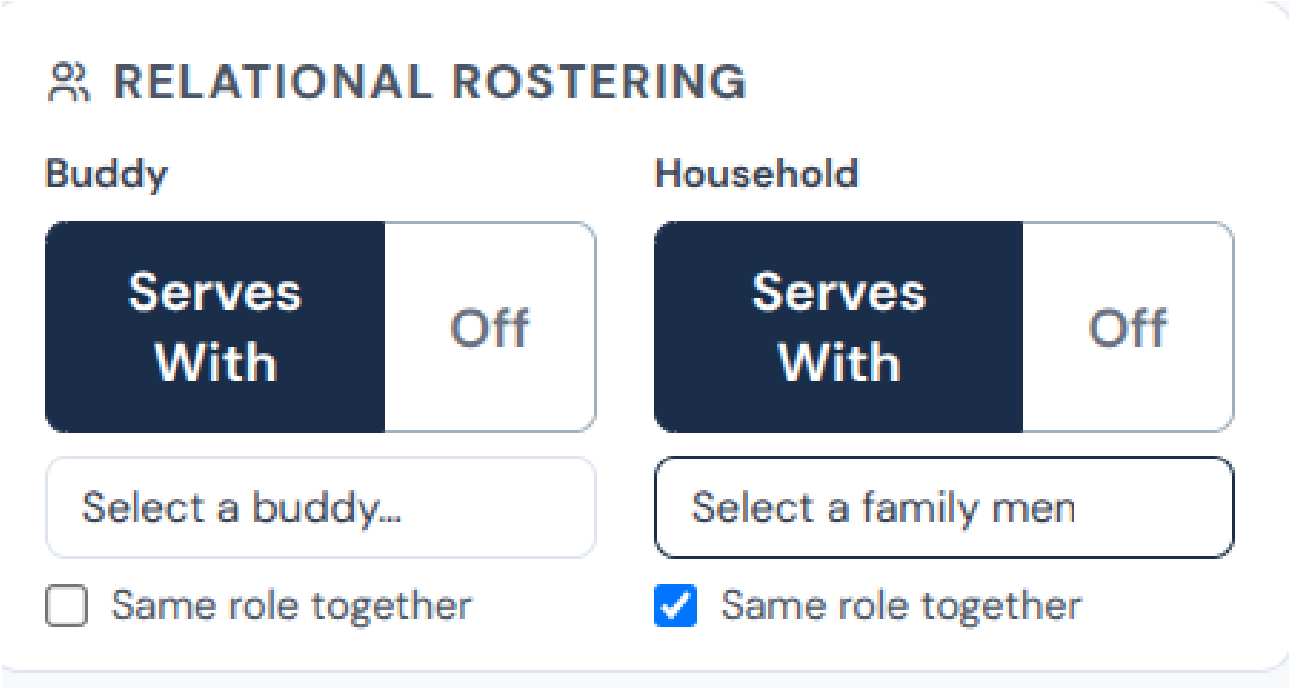


The Frequency control. "1wk" means they can be rostered every week; "4wk" means at most once every four weeks, and so on.

> **The cap counts distinct service dates, not roles.** A volunteer rostered to two roles on the same day counts as one service — so serving twice in one Sunday doesn't use up two of their allocation.

Relational rostering — serving together

Relational rostering asks Rostas to place people *together* on the same dates — a **Buddy** they like to serve alongside, or a **Household** so family members share the same rota. Turn on "Serves With" and pick who, then choose how closely they should be linked: the same date, or the same role too.



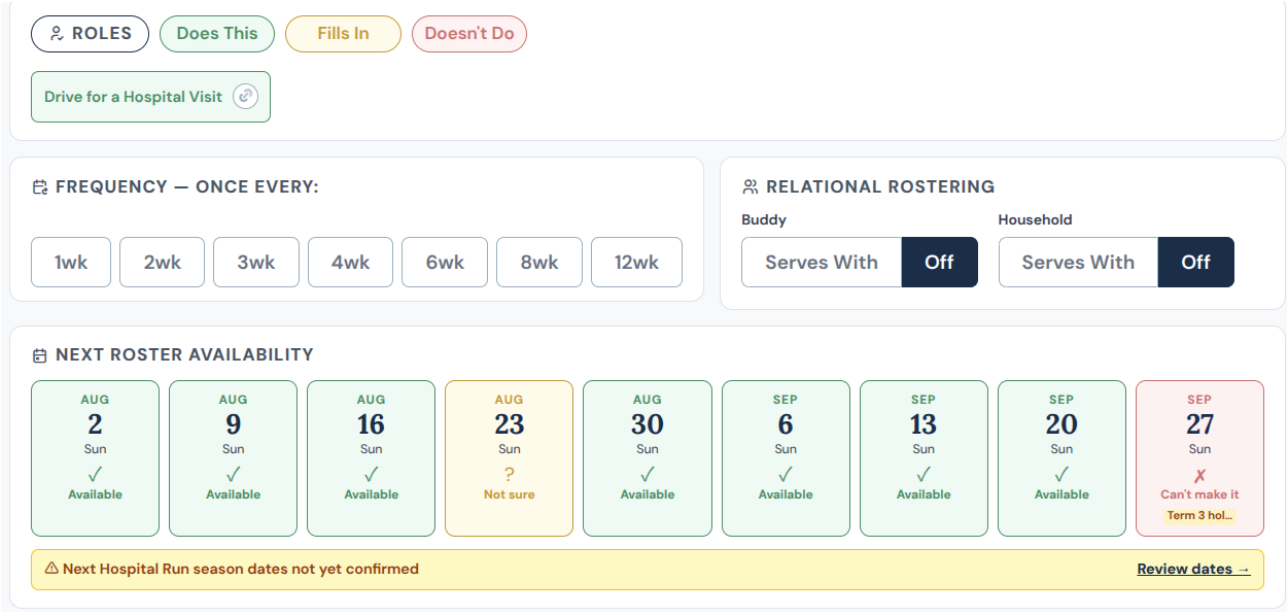
Relational rostering — Buddy and Household "Serves With" settings, each now carrying a "Same role together" checkbox. Household is ticked here, linking two family members to the identical role every time.

Two ways to serve together. Left unticked, a Buddy or Household pair just needs to be rostered on the *same date* — any role each of them is capable of is fine. This suits people who want to travel in together or simply be there on the same Sunday. Tick **"Same role together"** when one person is mentoring or training the other — this asks Rostas to put them on the *same role*, together, every time. Because that's a tighter constraint, a same-role pair is held back more often, and only placed once a slot exists that fits them both.

Relational rostering is not the same as role linking. Role linking ties two *roles* together for the same person; relational rostering places two *people* on the same dates. One is about jobs, the other about company.

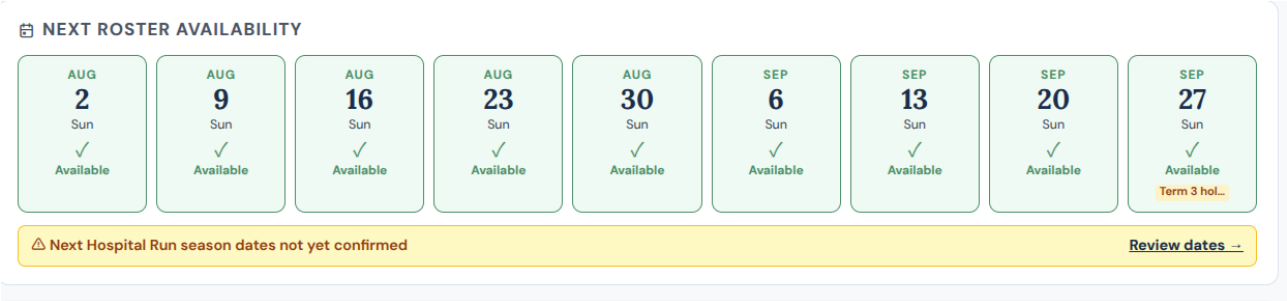
Next roster availability

The availability grid shows this volunteer's responses for the upcoming dates — the same three states they set on their own form:



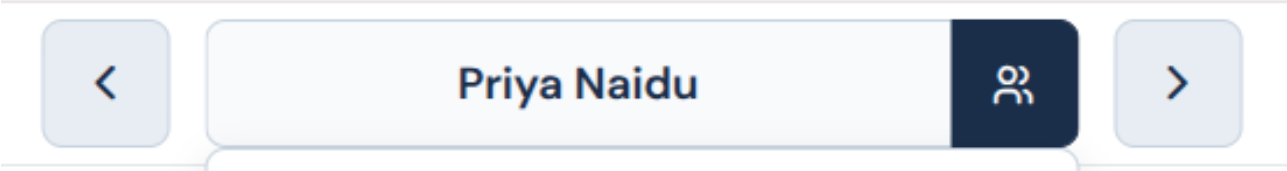
The Next Roster Availability grid. Holiday dates are tagged automatically so you can see at a glance which dates are affected.

If the season's dates aren't confirmed yet, a yellow banner appears at the bottom of this section — it's good to get season dates confirmed. Adding or deleting dates helps volunteers accurately know dates for the next roster.



The season-dates-unconfirmed banner — a reminder to confirm the season before availability can be gathered.

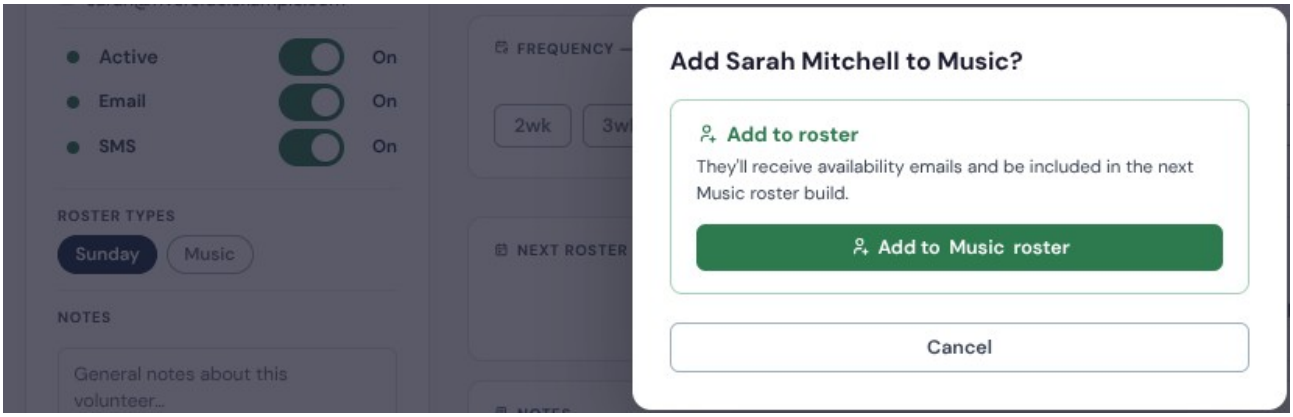
Searching across rosters. The prev/next arrows at the top of the profile step through volunteers. Next to them is a search-scope toggle (people icons) — switch it on to search across every roster rather than just the current one.



The profile top bar — step between volunteers with the arrows, and widen the search to all rosters with the scope toggle.

Adding a Volunteer to a New Roster

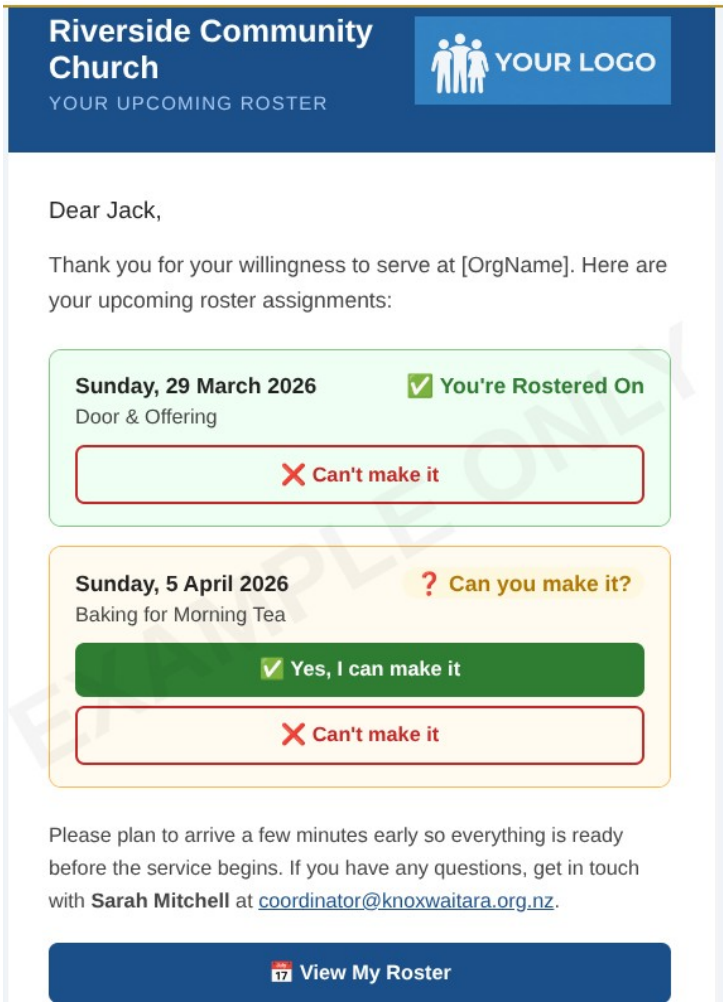
If a volunteer starts serving in an additional roster type, click the inactive roster tab on their detail page. A confirmation dialog appears — confirm to add them to that roster. Their settings for the new roster start fresh and can be configured from the right panel.



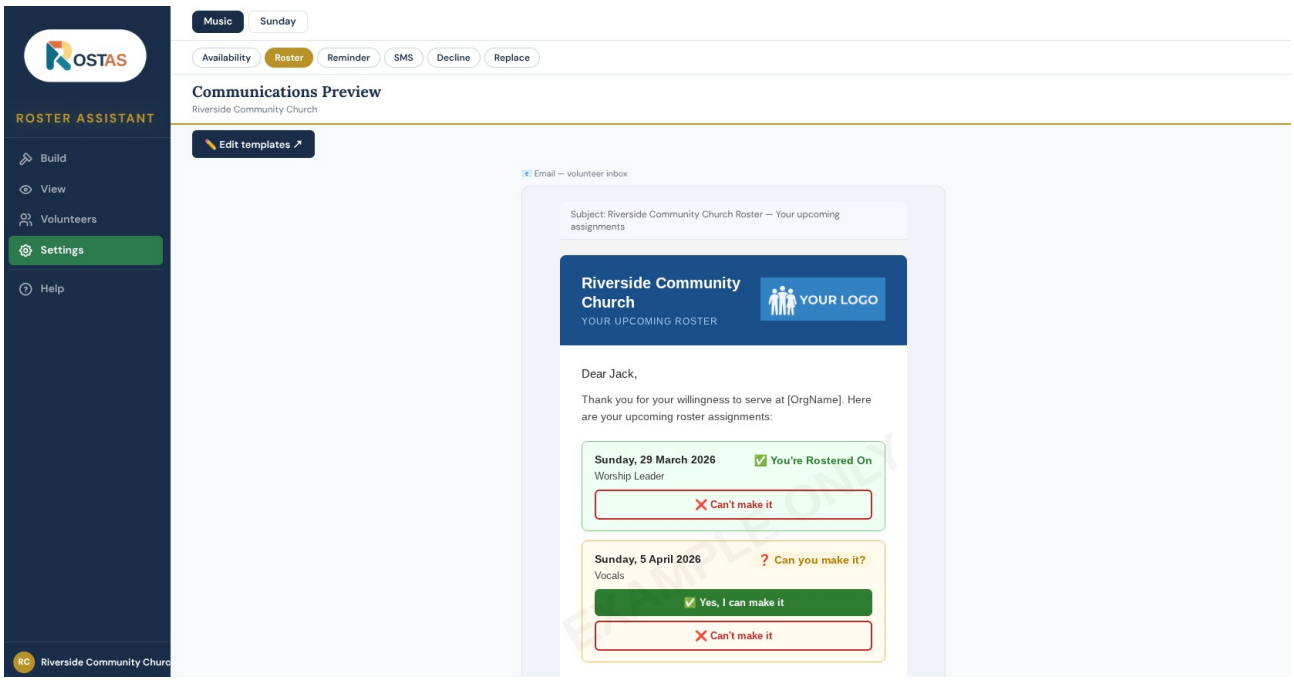
Clicking an inactive roster tab shows a confirmation before adding the volunteer. Once confirmed they appear in that roster's volunteer pool at the next build.

What Volunteers See

Volunteers interact with Rostas through personalised links, and — if they've installed it — the Rostas app. Installing is entirely optional: nothing is ever gated behind it, and a volunteer who never installs keeps using email and SMS links exactly as before. These are the main things volunteers are sent:



The volunteer roster view — shows upcoming assignments in a clean mobile-friendly layout. Volunteers access this via the link in their notification email.

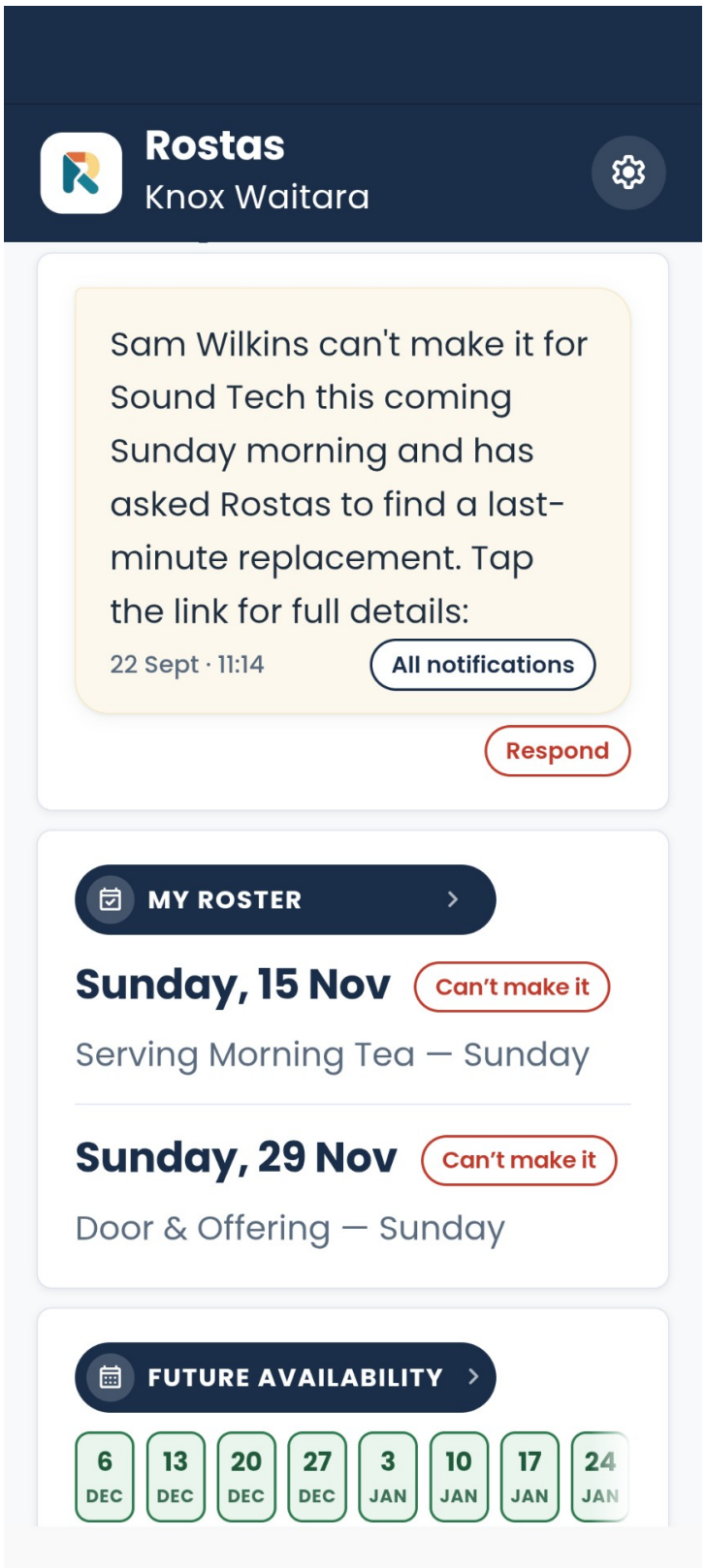


The roster notification email — every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments. The "Can't make it?" button at the bottom starts the replacement chain if tapped.

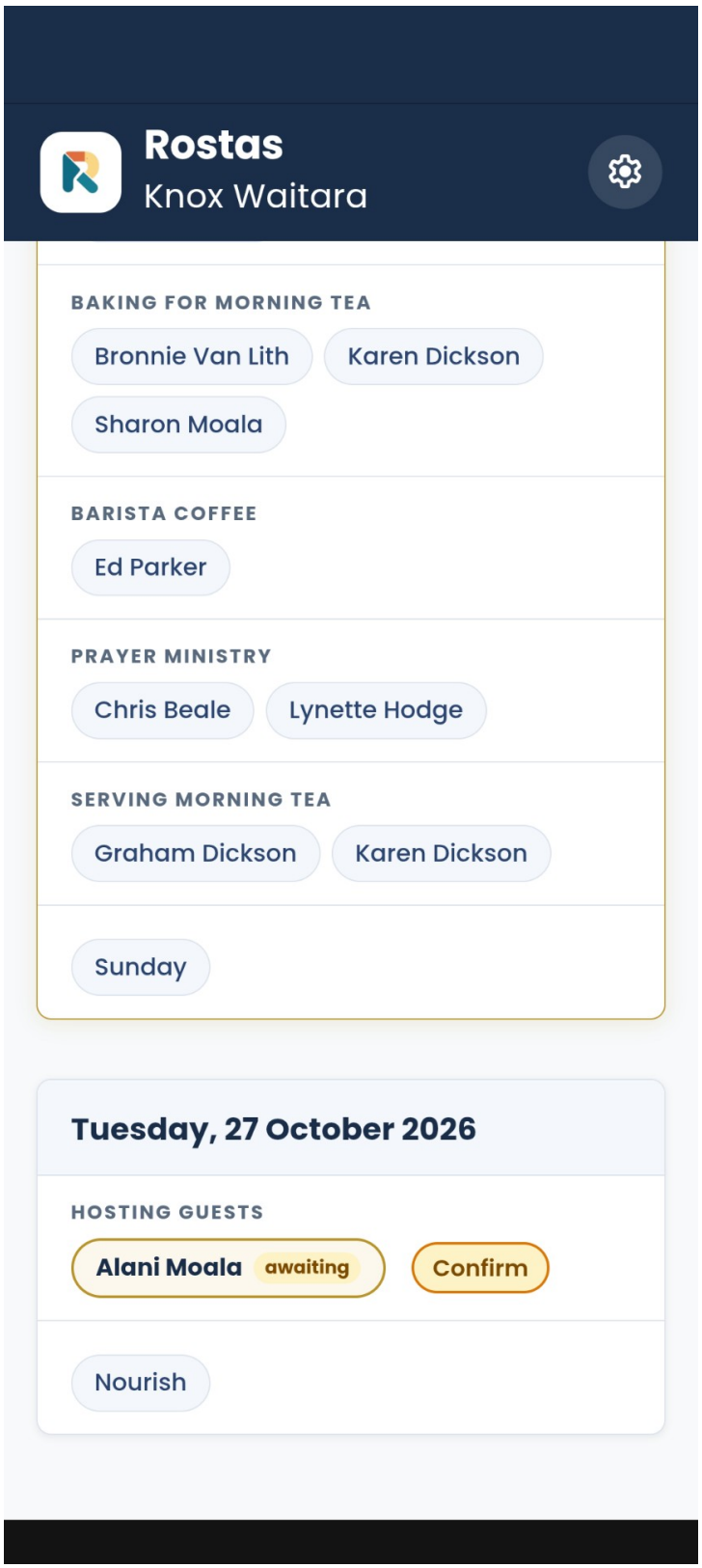
> **All volunteer pages are mobile-optimised.** Most volunteers will open them on their phone directly from an email or SMS, whether or not they've installed the app.

The Rostas App

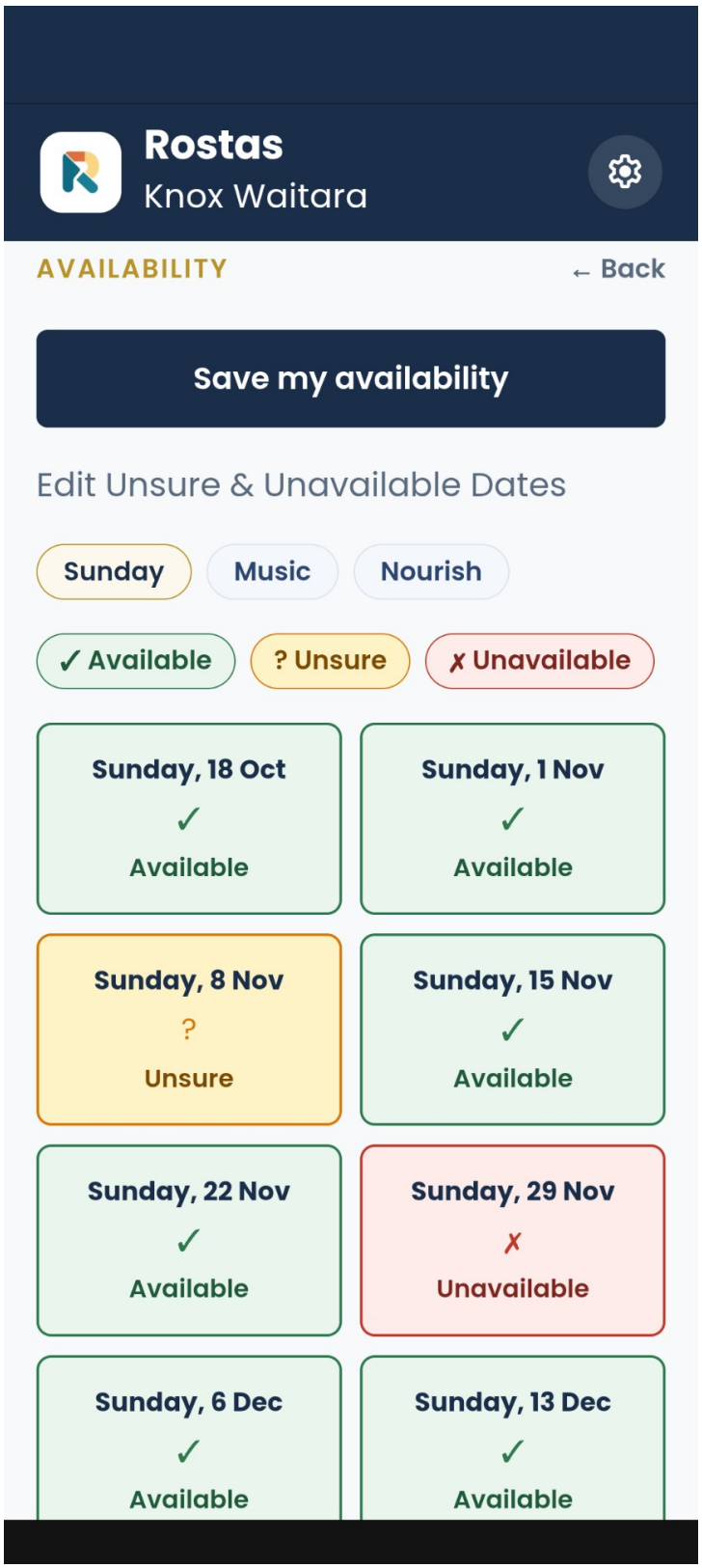
Rostas has an installable app — technically a "Progressive Web App", not something from an app store — at **mobile.rostas.app**. It's a front end for exactly the same data volunteers already see by link: nothing changes about what Rostas does, only how it's reached.



The app's Home screen — latest notification with a one-tap Respond, upcoming assignments under My Roster with a one-tap Can't make it, and a Future availability strip to scroll through.



Your Roster — the amber pill means the assignment is still pending confirmation; tapping it opens a Yes/No sheet.



A volunteer serving on both Sunday and Nourish sees a pill for each — availability is set independently per roster.

How volunteers install it

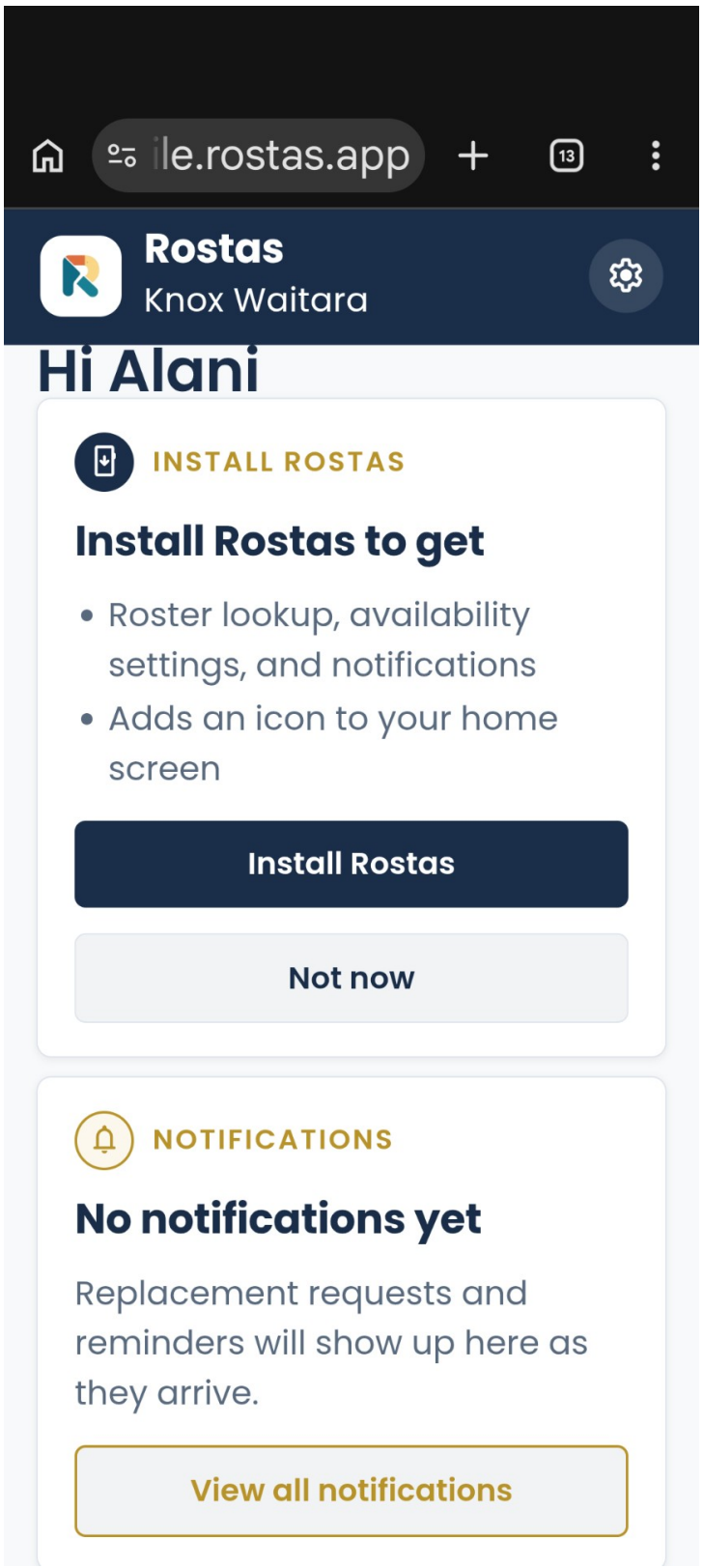
Every volunteer email carries a permanent "Get the app" card in the footer — automatic, not something you configure per email. To send someone their link straight away, see Sending a volunteer their app link. Installing looks different depending on the volunteer's phone:

The **Show me how** guide is also on the app's Home screen and in the app's **Settings** (the **App** row), so a volunteer can reopen it at any time. It ends on a **Your turn** list that stays at the top of the screen while they tap through Safari's menus.

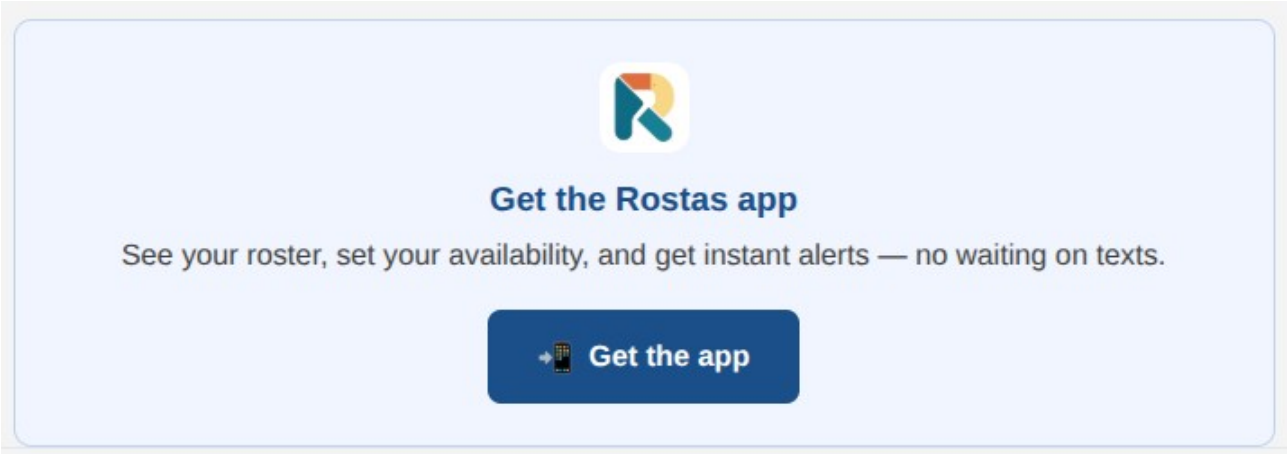
Helping someone set up an iPhone. Three things catch people out:

- **It must be Safari.** If the link opened in another browser or inside an app, the page says so. Open the link from their text message instead.
- **Leave "Open as Web App" switched on** (green) in the last step. If it's off, the icon just opens a Safari tab.
- **If the icon shows "Set up this device"**, it was added from the wrong page. Delete the icon, tap their link again, and add it from there.

"This link has already set up the app on 3 devices." Each volunteer's link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets. If they need another, or have changed phones more than twice, issue them a new link.



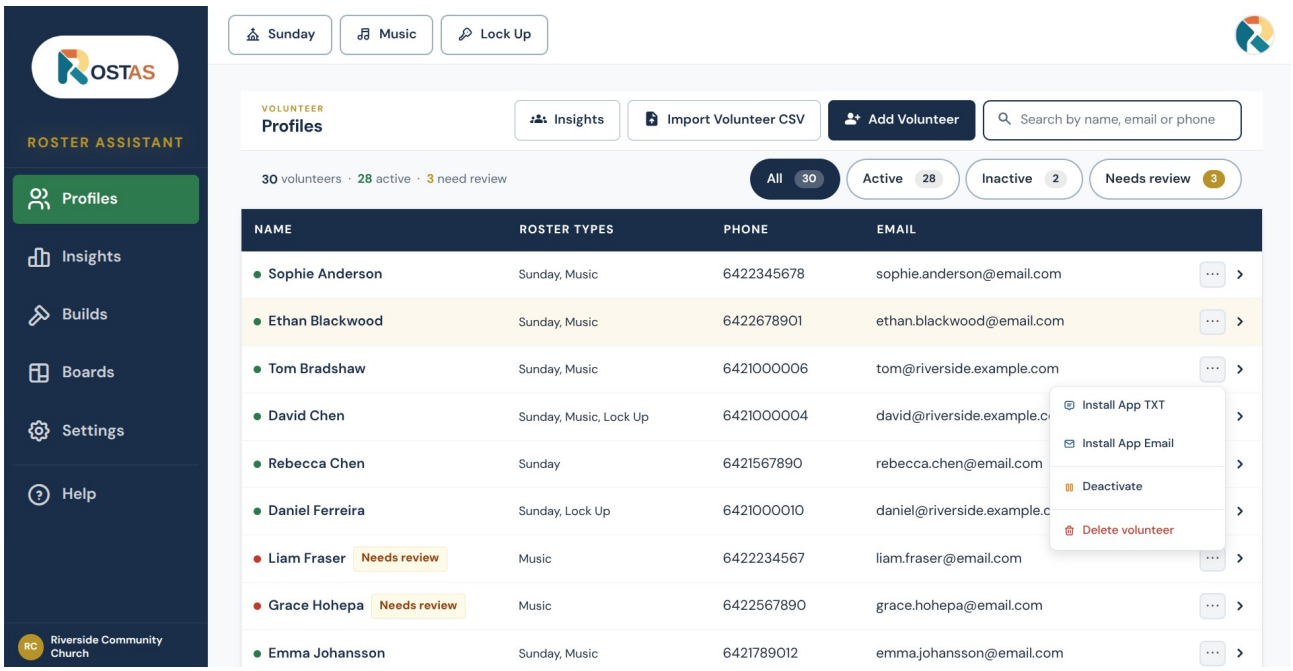
The Android install prompt — one tap installs the app, no app store involved.



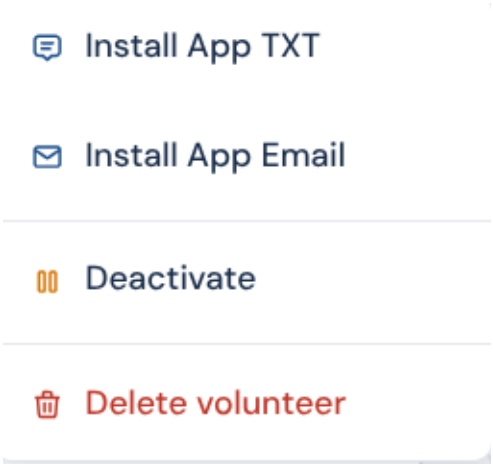
Every volunteer email carries this footer card automatically.

Sending a volunteer their app link

You don't have to wait for the next roster email. From the **Profiles** list you can send any volunteer their own app link straight away, by text or by email. Click the **⋯** button at the right-hand end of their row and choose one of the two **Install App** options.



The ⋯ button at the end of each row opens this menu. The two Install App options are at the top.



The menu close up.

Rostas confirms with a short message, such as *Text sent to Judy Aitkinson.* If it can't send, the message says why and suggests the other option. The usual reasons are:

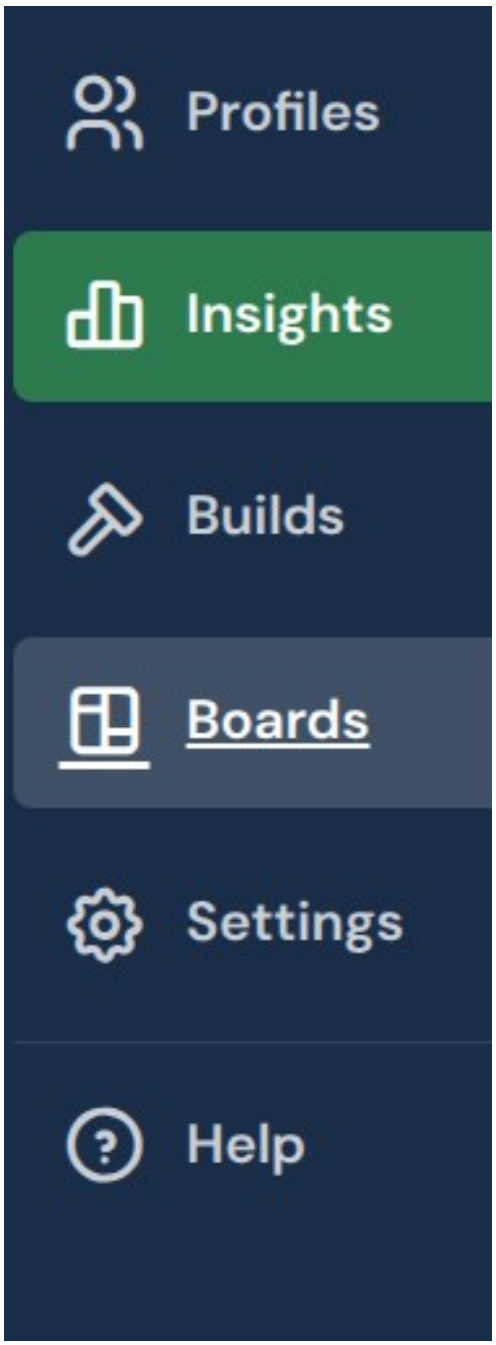
- The volunteer has **no mobile number** or **no email address** on file.
- The volunteer has **opted out** of texts or emails. You can check this with the toggles on their profile.
- Texts are **held during your SMS quiet hours** (see Settings). Use **Install App Email**, or try again later.

Both options send the volunteer's existing link, so it's fine to send it again if they lose it. Remember that each link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets. If someone needs more, issue them a new link.

Running an app table after a service. Some churches find it easiest to set up a table where volunteers who are comfortable with phones help others. Look the person up with the search box on the Profiles page, choose **Install App TXT**, and ask them to open the text on their own phone. The helper never needs a password, because there isn't one — the link does the work. For iPhones, see *Helping someone set up an iPhone* in the section above.

Cost and test mode. A text uses one text from your SMS allowance, like any other text Rostas sends. The email costs nothing. While SMS test mode is on in Settings, the text goes to the coordinator's phone instead of the volunteer's, and the confirmation says **TEST MODE**. Email test mode works the same way.

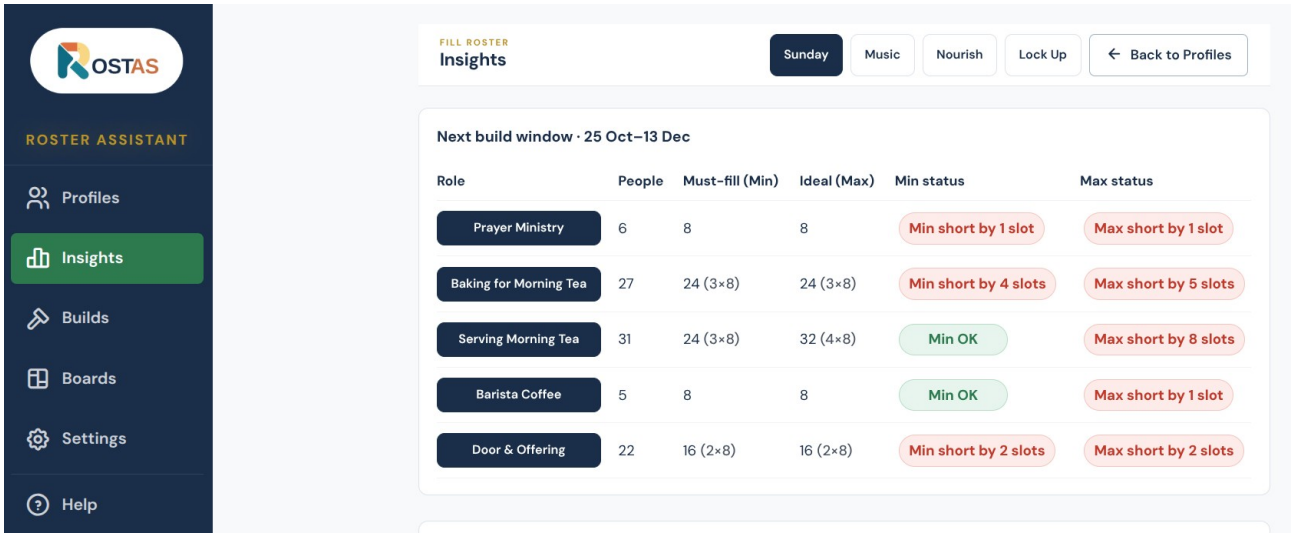
Insights is your at-a-glance health check for an upcoming roster — reachable any time from the **Insights** item in the side navigation (it sits right below Profiles), or via the "Insights" shortcut buttons on Profiles and a volunteer's own detail page. Insights refreshes whenever the roster, your volunteers or Settings change, so it always reflects your current forecast. It's worth a look between builds, not just when something's already gone wrong.



Insights lives in the side nav, right below Profiles.

The overview table

Pick a roster type along the top (Sunday, Music, Lock Up, and so on) and Insights shows every one of its roles against your next unbuilt window of dates. Two separate numbers matter for each role:

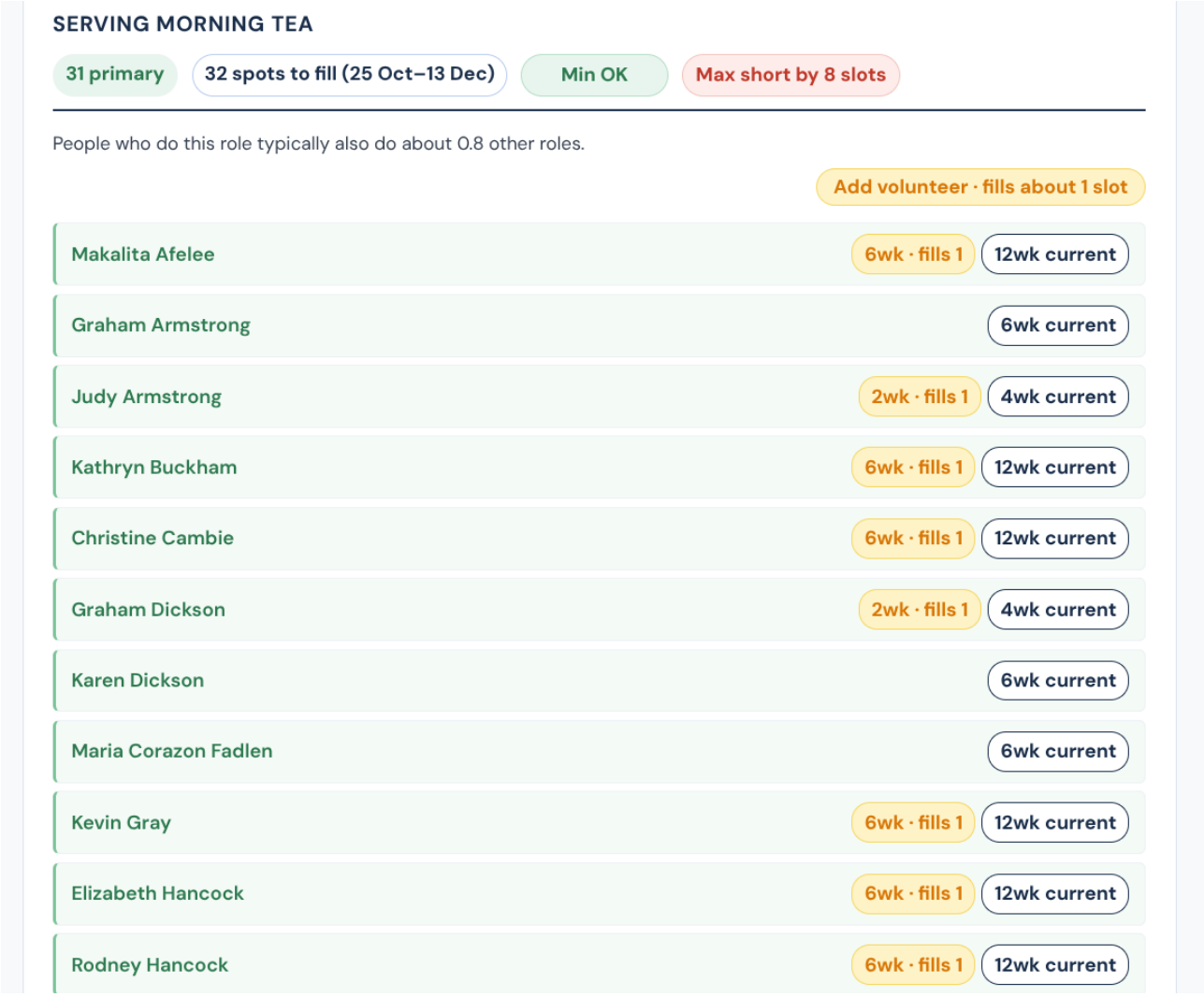


The overview table for Sunday's next build window. Baking for Morning Tea is short on both Min and Max; Serving Morning Tea meets its minimum but is short of the ideal.

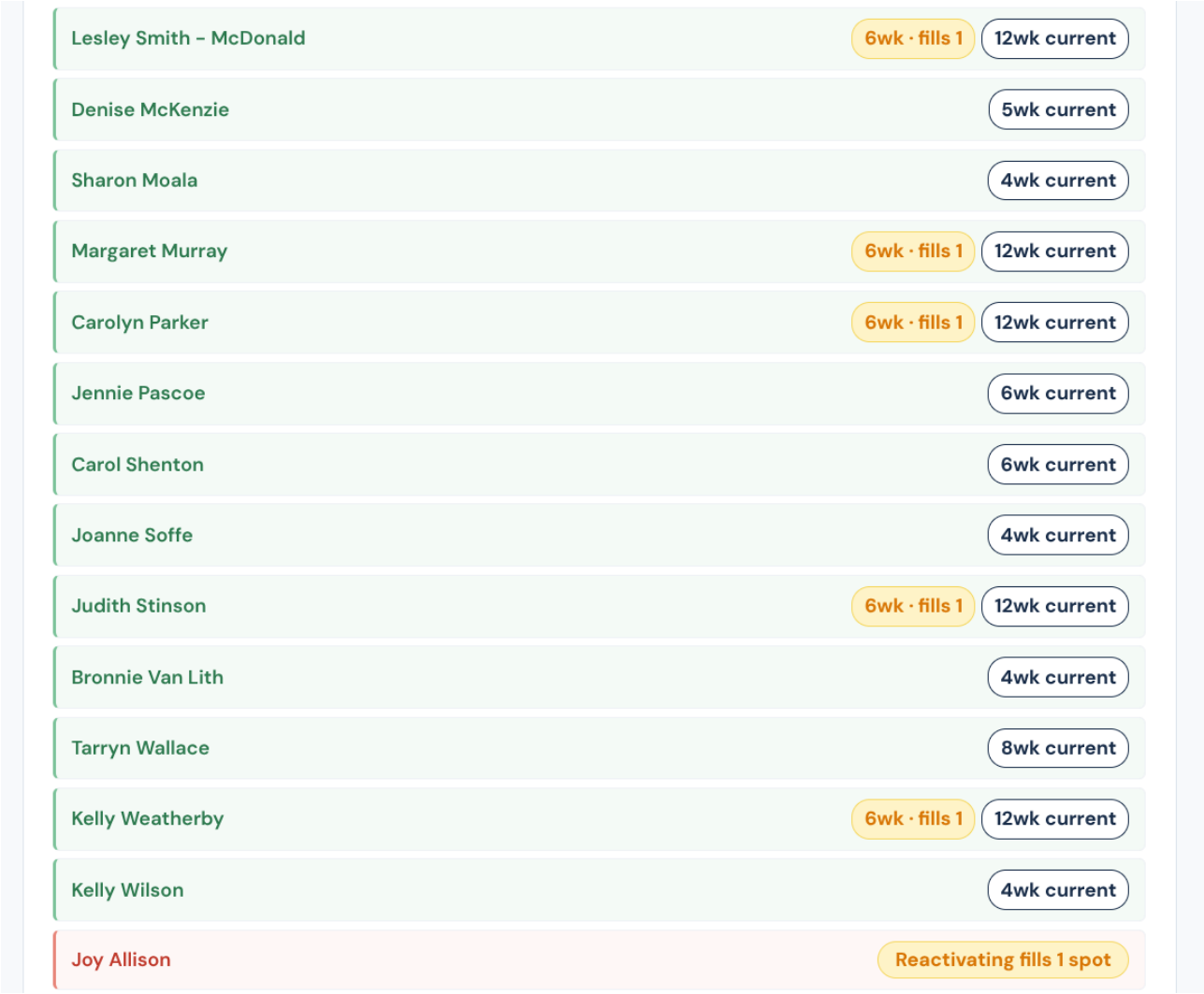
Min and Max are different questions. A role can be "Min OK" — enough people to function — while still short of "Ideal (Max)", the fuller complement you'd rather have. Watch Min status first; it's the number that actually stops a roster running short-handed.

Digging into a role

Click a role's name to jump to its detail card further down the page. Each card repeats that role's numbers, then lists every volunteer linked to it with a pill showing their current frequency cap — and, where it would genuinely help, a second pill suggesting a change.



A role's detail card — headcount pills at top, then a suggestion (here, recruiting a new volunteer) and the full volunteer list below.



Most volunteers just show their current cap. A few carry an amber suggestion too — loosening their cap would fill the number of slots shown.

You'll also see a line like "People who do this role typically also do about 0.8 other roles" — a reminder that many of your volunteers are shared across roles, which is exactly what the fill-order effect below is about.

Reordering roles

Some shortfalls aren't about headcount at all — they're about **fill order**. Rostas fills roles top-to-bottom in the order they're listed on Managing Roles: once a volunteer is placed in one role for a date, they're not considered for any role further down the list that same date. A role near the bottom can end up short simply because every volunteer who could have filled it was claimed by an earlier role first.

Where moving a short role earlier in that order would help, its card shows a distinct suggestion:

> **Example reorder suggestion:** "Moving this role to the 1st position would fill 2 of 3 slots. Cost: Serving Morning Tea loses 2 slot(s)." with an **Open Manage Roles** link.

> **Always a trade, never free capacity.** Moving a role earlier redistributes an existing shared volunteer — it doesn't create a new one. Whatever slots the short role gains, another role loses, and Insights always names which one and by how much before you act. If nothing else would get worse, it says so plainly ("No other role gets worse").

> **Insights tells you, it doesn't do it for you.** Every suggestion on this page is informational. Reactivating a volunteer, loosening a cap, recruiting someone new, or reordering roles are all things you choose to do yourself — from a Profile, or from Managing Roles. Insights just points you at what's worth trying.

There are two roster wizards in Rostas. The **New Roster Wizard** runs once when you set up a new roster type — it defines the name, roles, season dates, and volunteers. The **Roster Wizard** runs every few weeks to collect availability, build the roster, and send notifications to volunteers.

Both start from the **Builds dashboard**.

The Builds Dashboard

The Builds dashboard is your home base for all roster activity. Open it by clicking **Builds** in the sidebar. Every roster type appears as a full-width row — one per roster — so you can see the state of your whole operation at a glance and act on any roster without leaving the page.



The Builds dashboard — each roster type is a full-width row. On the left, a state button tells you where that roster is in its cycle and what clicking will do; along the row, a date-chip strip shows recent and upcoming service dates; on the right, the ··· menu holds per-roster actions.

The state button

The button on the left of each row is dynamic — its colour and label tell you exactly where that roster is in its cycle, and clicking it always picks up at the right next step. You never have to remember where you left off.

The date-chip strip

Each row shows a strip of small date chips — the roster's recent and upcoming service dates. The colours are deliberately simple: **blue means a date that has already passed**, and **green means an upcoming date**. It's an at-a-glance sense of where each roster sits in time.

> **These two colours aren't the same as the date bands in the wizard.** On the Builds dashboard, chip colour just means past (blue) or upcoming (green). Inside the Confirm Dates step of a build you'll see a richer set of coloured bands for last build, this build, next build, and excluded dates — that's a different view with a different job.

On the right of each row, the ··· menu holds the rest of what you can do with a roster — pausing, adjusting dates and roles, resetting, or deleting. See The Build Menu below for the full walkthrough.

> **Starting a brand-new roster type?** A **New Roster** option on the Builds dashboard sets one up from scratch. See the New Roster Wizard section below.

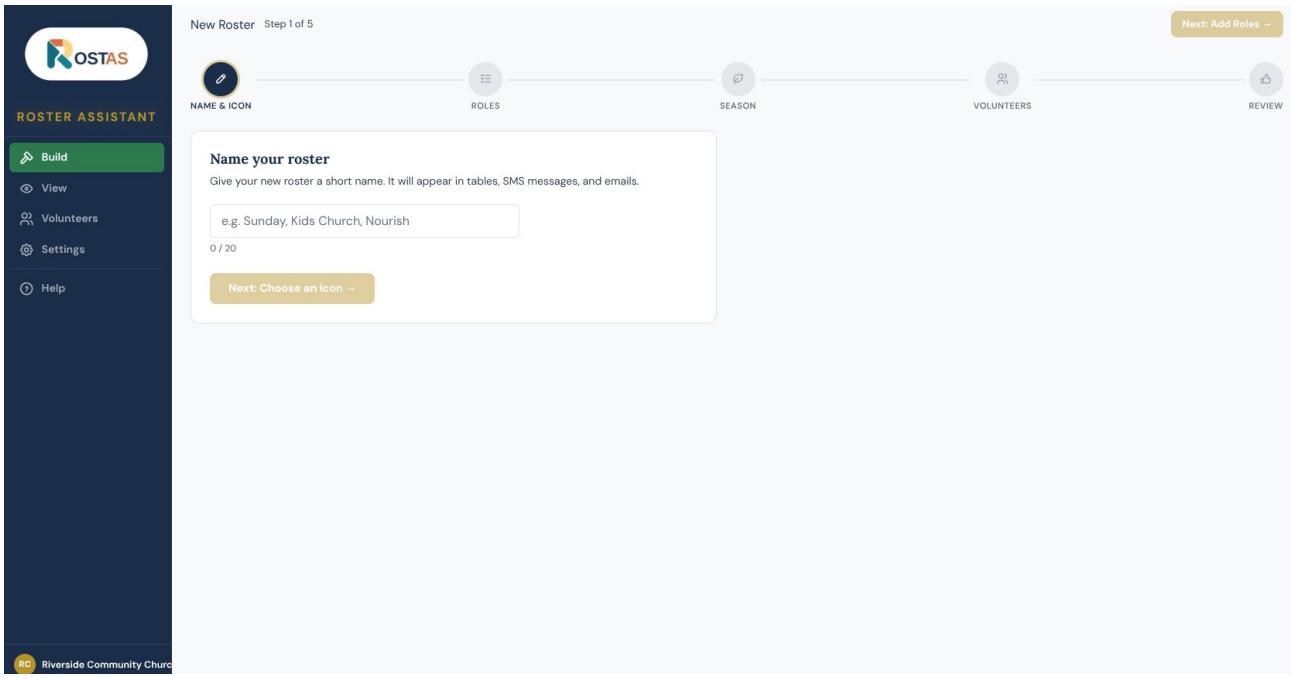
The New Roster Wizard

Run this wizard when you're setting up a roster type for the first time — for example, adding a Music roster or a Hospitality team. It takes about 10 minutes and walks you through five steps: Name & Icon, Roles, Season, Volunteers, and Review.

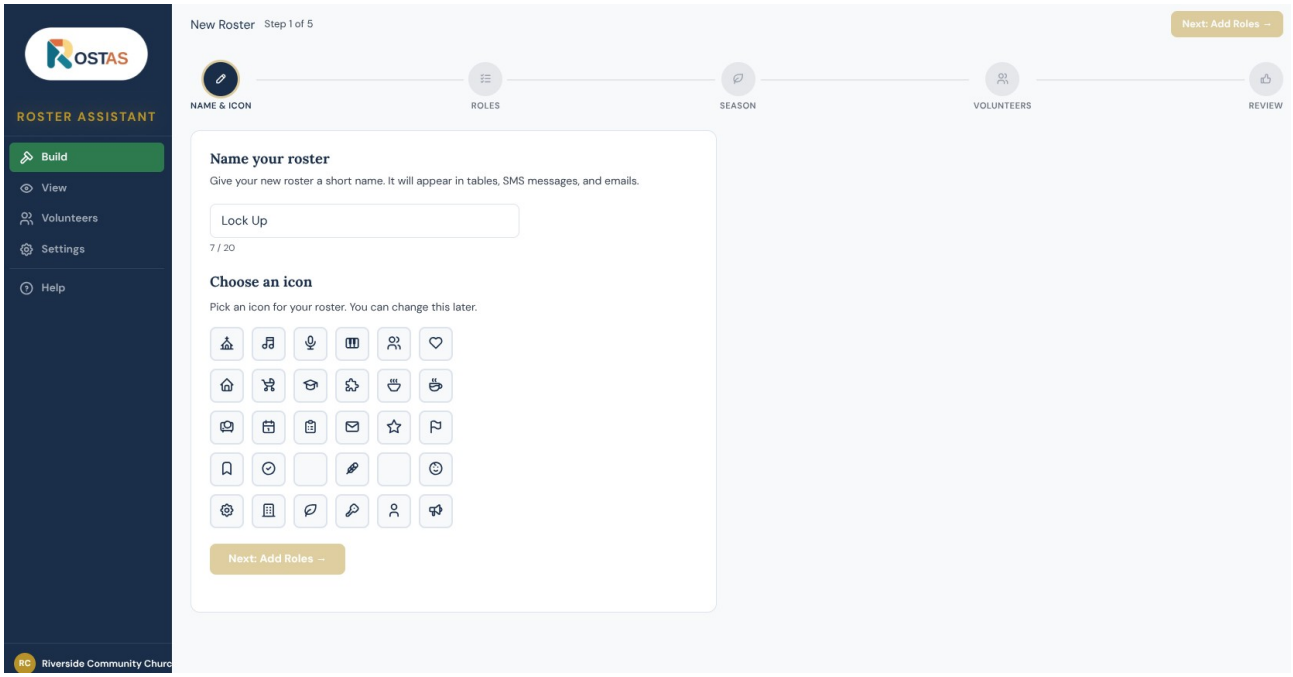
> **You only run the New Roster Wizard once per roster type.** After setup is complete, all future roster builds use the Roster Wizard instead.

Step 1 — Name & Icon

Give your roster a short name and choose an icon. The name appears in SMS messages, emails, and the coordinator app — so keep it brief and clear. A few words are kept for Rostas's own settings and can't be used as a roster name: Name, Email, Phone, ID, Key and Role.



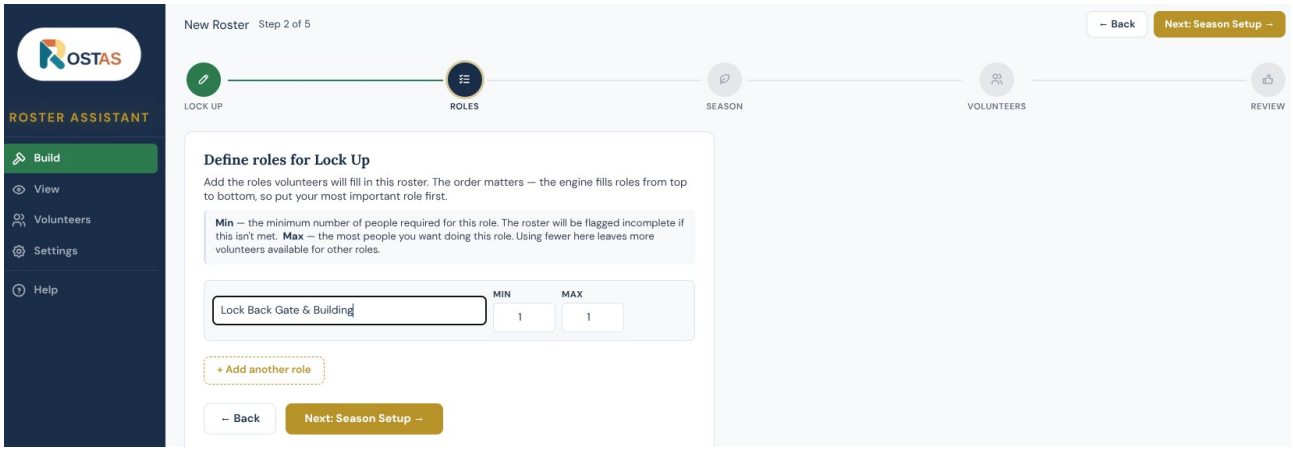
Step 1 — name your roster. This name appears in all volunteer communications, so keep it short and recognisable — e.g. "Sunday", "Music", "Hospitality".



After naming the roster, choose an icon that represents it. The icon appears on the roster's row on the Builds dashboard and beside its name in the app.

Step 2 — Roles

Define the roles that need to be filled each time this roster runs. For each role, set a minimum and maximum number of people required. You can add, rename, or retire roles later from Managing Roles.

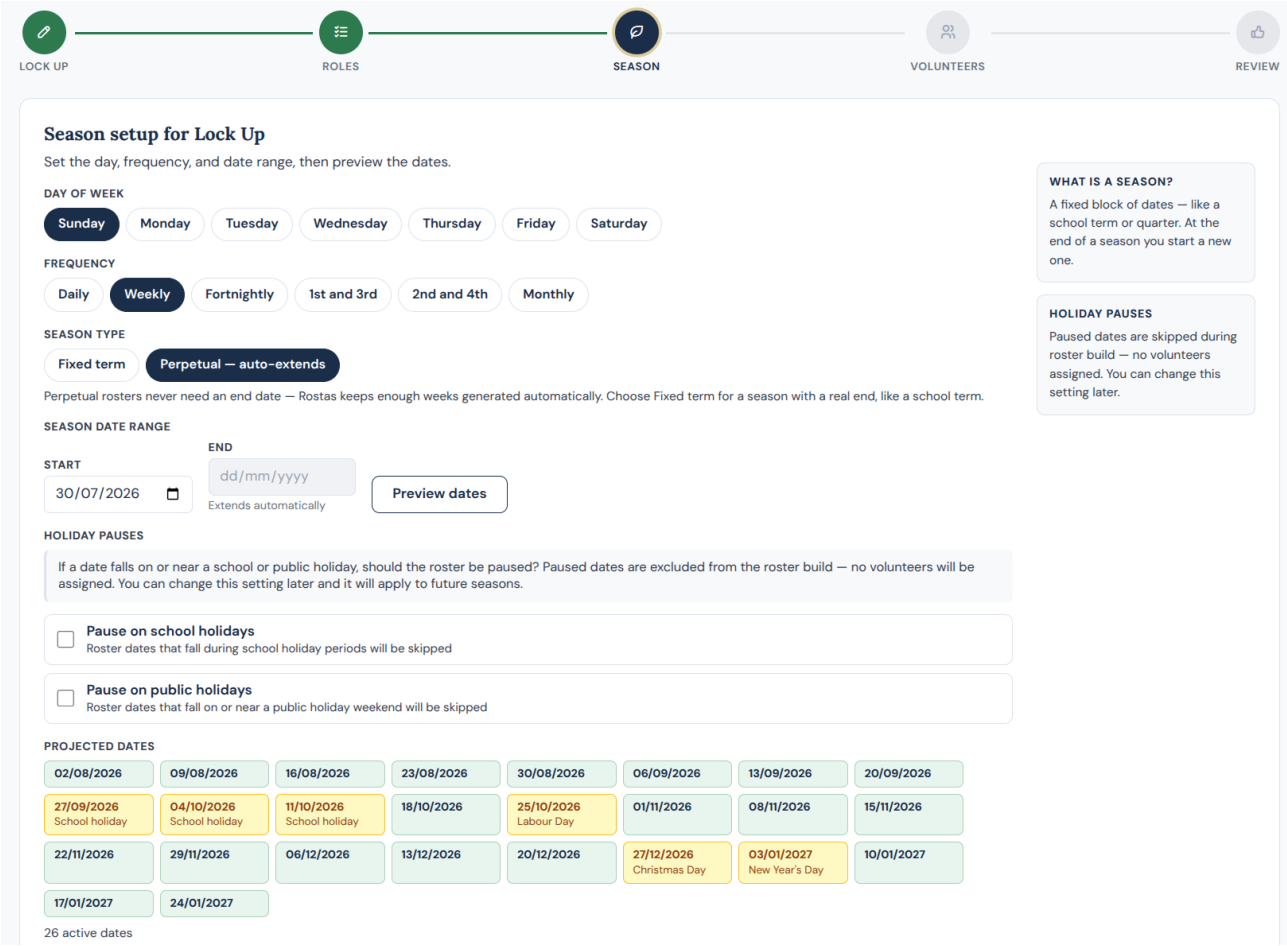


Step 2 — add the roles for this roster. Set minimum and maximum people for each role. The engine will always try to fill the minimum; it won't exceed the maximum.

> **Role names matter.** Use clear, specific names that volunteers will recognise — e.g. "Sound Desk", "Welcome Team", "Data Projection". These names appear in SMS messages and emails sent to volunteers.

Step 3 — Season

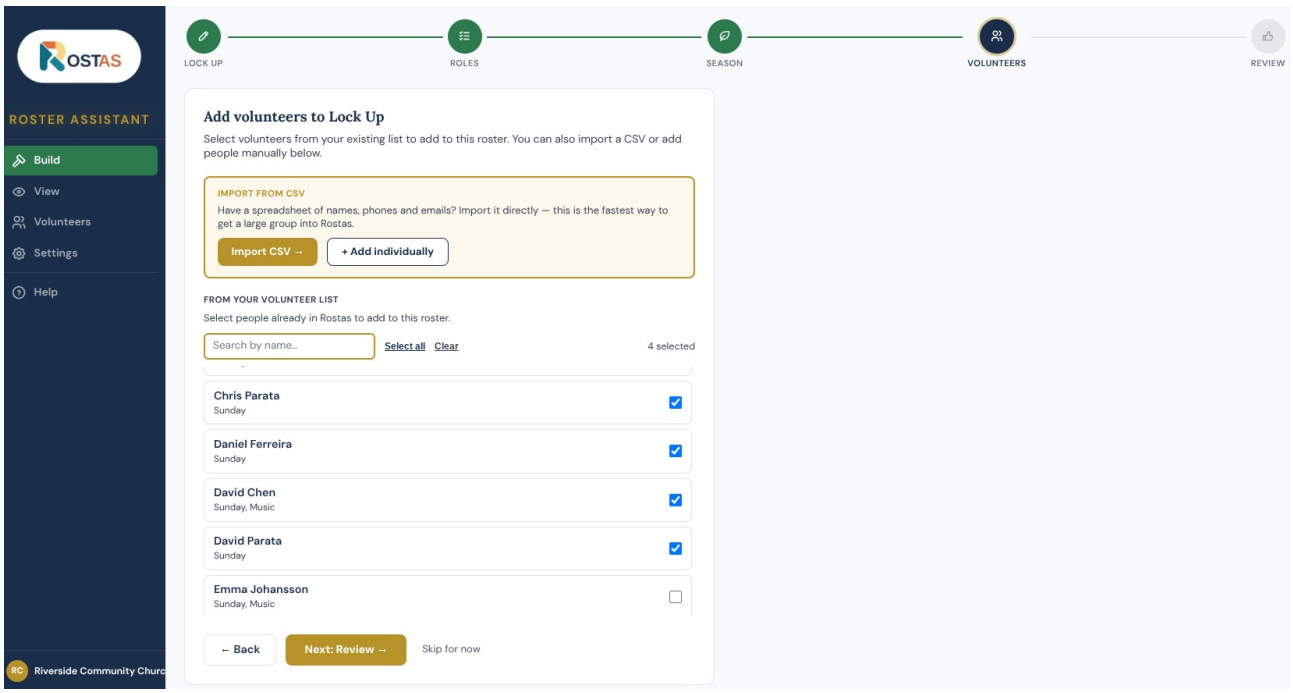
A season defines the date range, frequency, and day of week for this roster. Rostas uses seasons to calculate which dates to roster for, and to overlay public and school holidays automatically.



Step 3 — set up your first season. Choose day of week, frequency, and date range. Projected dates appear as pills below — school holidays are labelled automatically so you can see which dates will be paused.

Step 4 — Volunteers

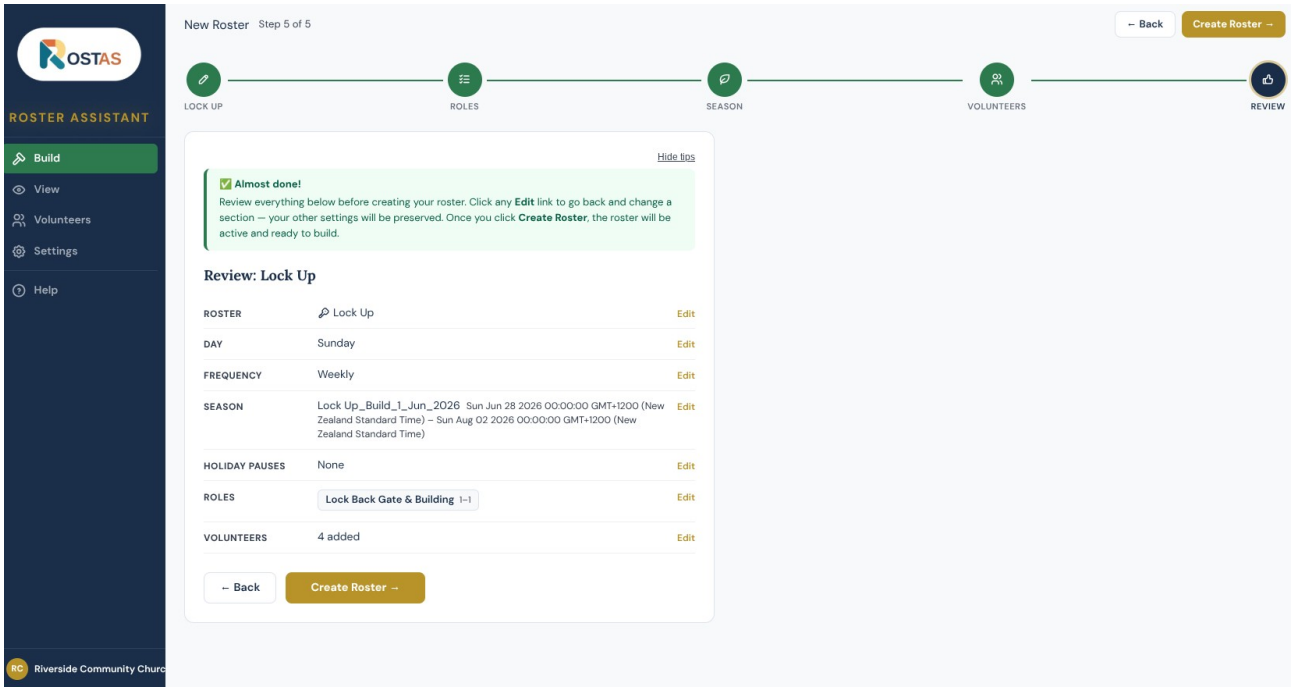
Select which volunteers from your list will serve on this roster. Tick each volunteer you want to include. Only volunteers already in Rostas appear here — if someone is missing, add them in Profiles first then return to this step.



Step 4 — tick each volunteer who serves in this roster. Use the search field to find someone quickly if you have a large list. You can also import additional volunteers via CSV from this step.

Step 5 — Review

The final step shows a summary of everything you've set up — roster name, icon, roles, season dates, and volunteer count. Review it carefully before confirming.



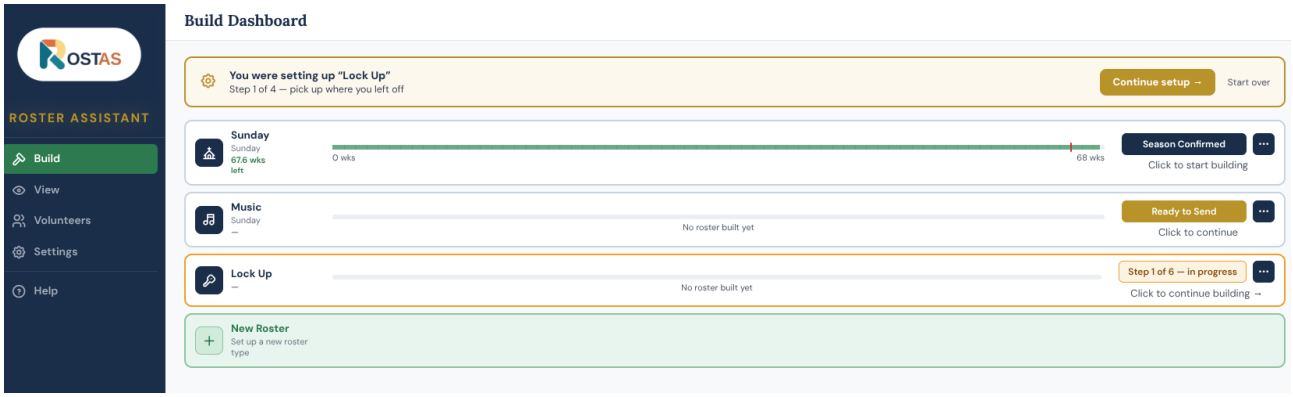
Step 5 — review your roster setup before confirming. You can go back to any previous step to make changes. Once confirmed, the roster appears on the Builds dashboard.

Click **Create Roster →** to finish. Your new roster type appears on the Builds dashboard immediately. You're now ready to run your first Roster Wizard for this roster.

The Roster Wizard

The Roster Wizard is the recurring roster cycle you run every few weeks. Each roster type has its own — the page is headed "[Your roster] Roster Wizard" — and it takes you through the same six named steps every time: Confirm Dates & Roles, Role Prefs, Availability, Build Roster, Check Roster, and Notify. A progress rail across the top shows where you are, marking each step Completed, Skipped, In progress, or still to come.

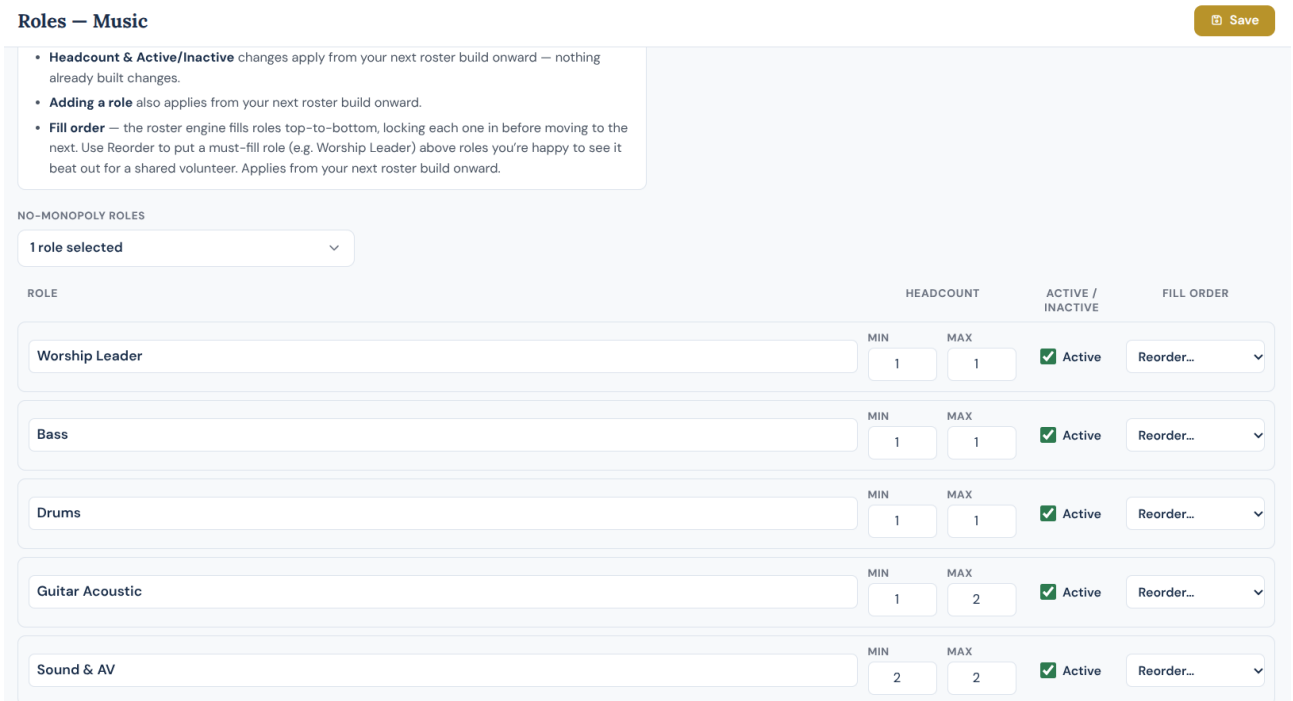
To start, open the **Builds** dashboard and click a roster's state button. If a build is already in progress, you're taken straight back to the step you left off at.



When a build is in progress, the roster's state button shows where it's up to and a resume banner appears at the top of the page. Click the state button to pick up where you left off.

Step 1 — Confirm Dates & Roles

This first step is where you confirm two things for the build: which **dates** it covers, and which **roles** (and how many people per role) are in play. Behind the scenes it also refreshes your seasons calendar and overlays public and school holidays, so the dates are correct before availability goes out.

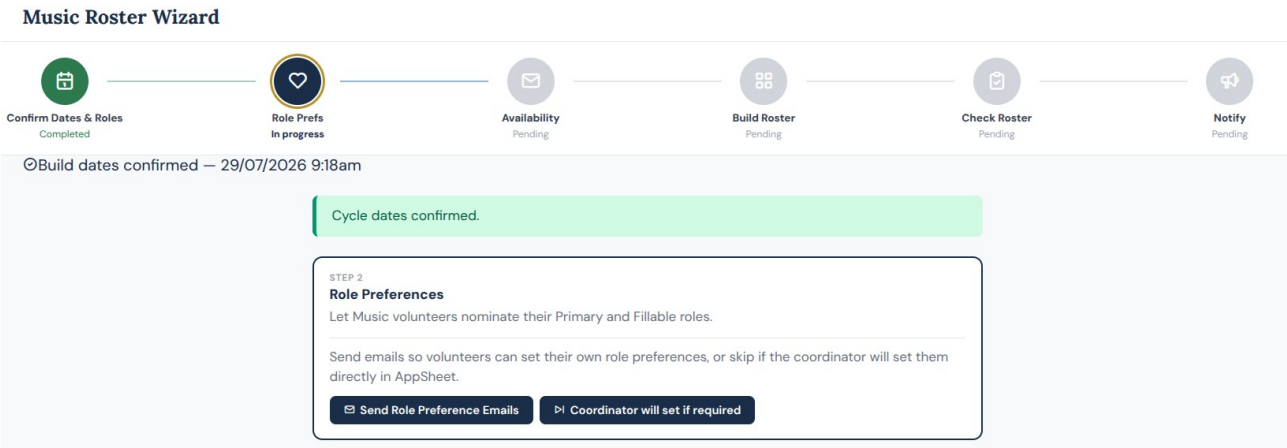


Step 1 — Confirm Dates & Roles. The date bands show which dates are in this build; below them, a "Roles for this Build" panel lets you set the headcount and turn roles on or off for this build.

"Refresh & Sync" is an action within this step, not a step of its own. You may see a Refresh & Sync button here — it re-pulls the calendar and holidays. It's part of confirming your dates, which is why the step is named Confirm Dates & Roles.

Step 2 — Role Prefs

This step lets volunteers update their role preferences — which roles they're willing to perform. You can send a role-preference email to all volunteers, or skip the step entirely.

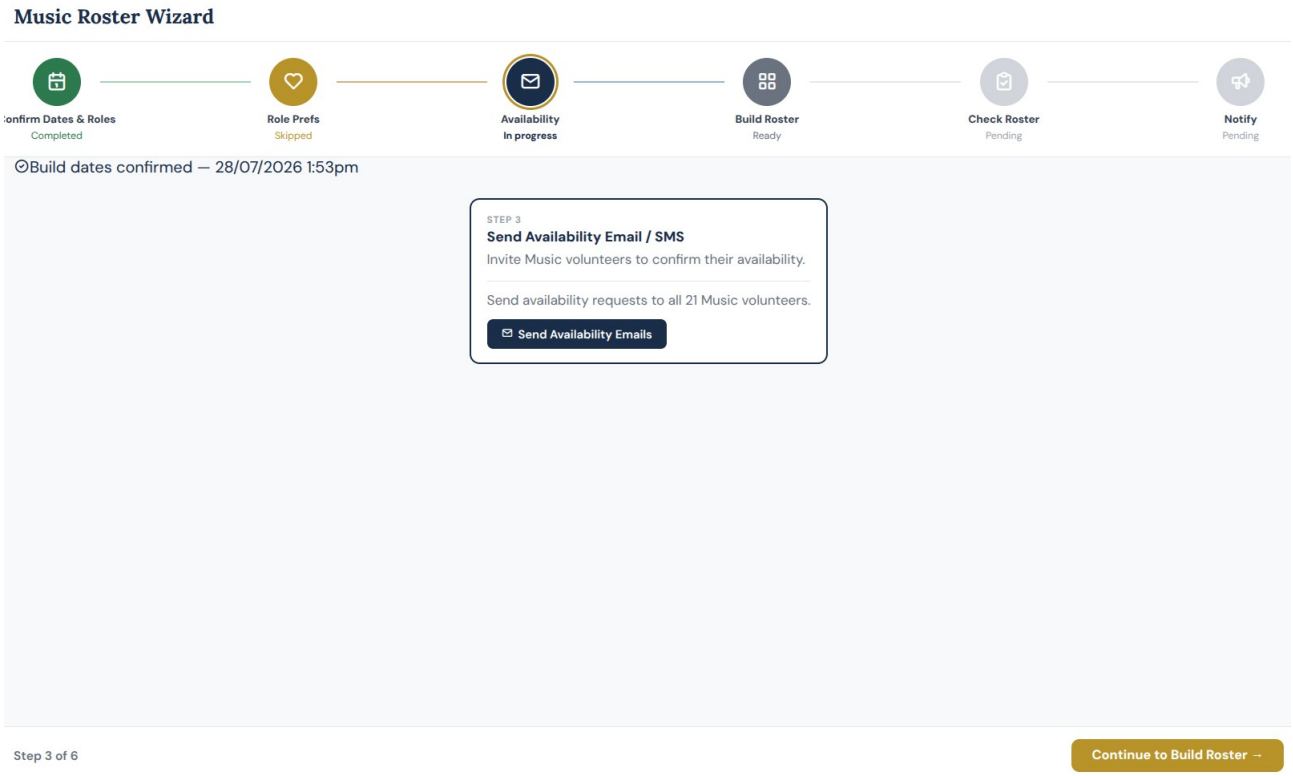


Step 2 — Role Prefs. Send emails so volunteers can set their own preferences, or use "Skip Role Preferences" if you manage them yourself.

This step is commonly skipped. Many coordinators set each volunteer's roles directly on the Profile page ahead of time, which makes this step unnecessary for that build — the rail simply marks it "Skipped" and you move on. Send the emails at the start of a new season or when new volunteers join; skip it for a routine rebuild.

Step 3 — Availability

Rostas emails every active volunteer on this roster, asking which upcoming dates they're available. Each volunteer receives a personalised link — no login required. They tap their dates, mark any they can't make, and save.

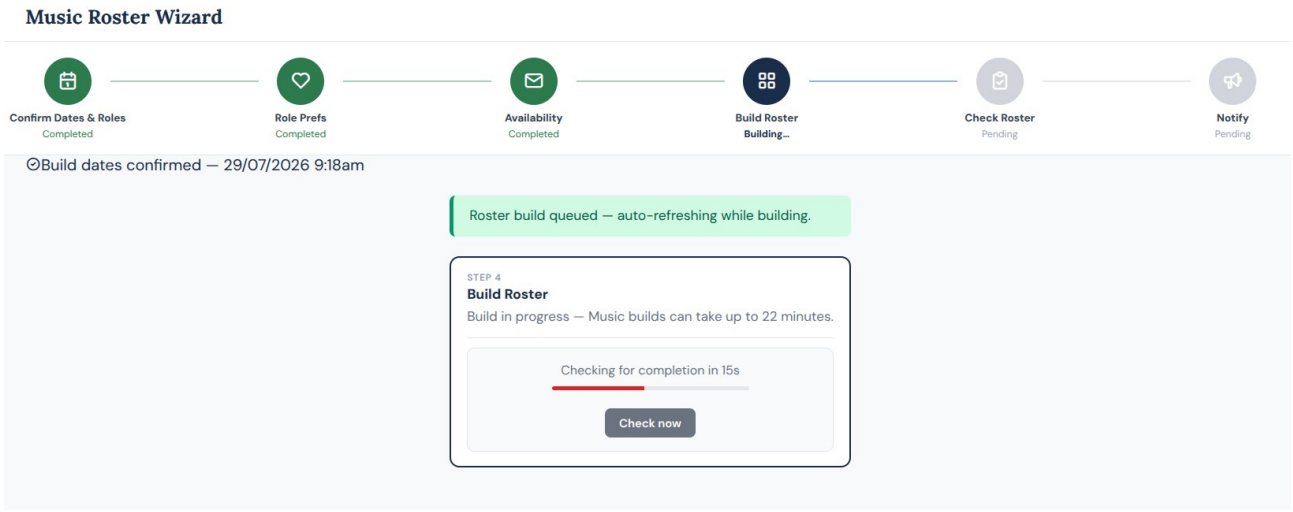


Step 3 — send the availability request, then watch the response stats update as volunteers reply over the following days.

> **Allow 5–7 days for responses** before moving to Step 4. Volunteers who don't respond within a configurable number of days automatically receive an SMS nudge.

Step 4 — Build Roster

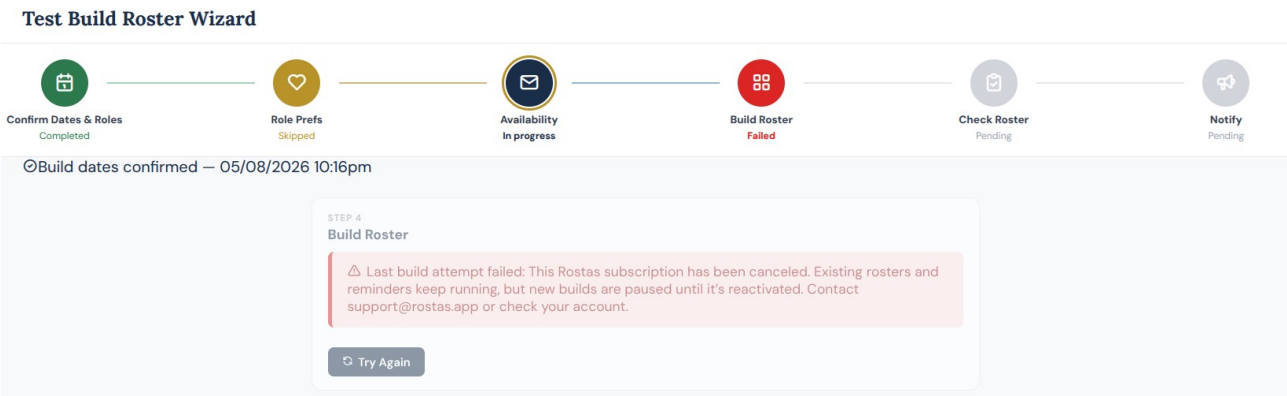
The roster engine analyses every volunteer — their availability, role preferences, how recently they've served, and their frequency cap — and fills every slot automatically. The build takes a few minutes for most rosters.



Step 4 — one click builds the whole roster. The engine works through every slot using the four-tier priority system.

The engine uses a four-tier priority system — see Part A, The Intelligent Matching Engine for full detail on how slots are filled.

If a build can't complete — for example if your Rostas subscription has lapsed, or a season/role setup issue blocks it — this step shows the reason plainly instead of leaving you guessing, with a **Try Again** button once the issue is resolved.

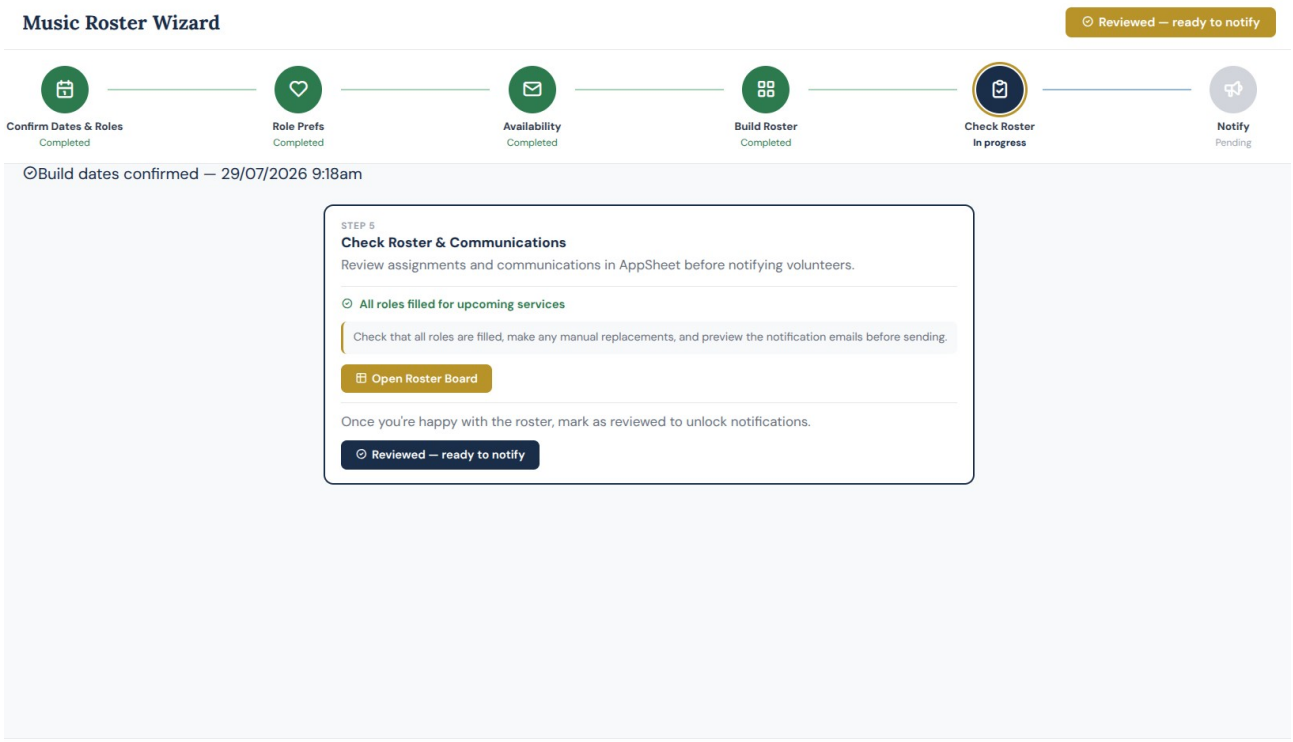


If a build fails, the step shows exactly why and lets you retry once it's fixed — rather than silently reverting.

Step 5 — Check Roster

Before anything is sent to volunteers, you review what Rostas has built. Clicking **Open Roster Board** opens the board in review mode — you can see every assignment, make any manual changes, and return to the wizard. The Communications Preview in Settings lets you see exactly what each volunteer will receive before you send.

Step 5 also has two ways to build again if you've made changes — for example after more availability replies come in, or after adjusting roles or dates:



Step 5 — open the board to review assignments, or use the Communications Preview to check what volunteers will receive. When you're happy, mark it reviewed to proceed.

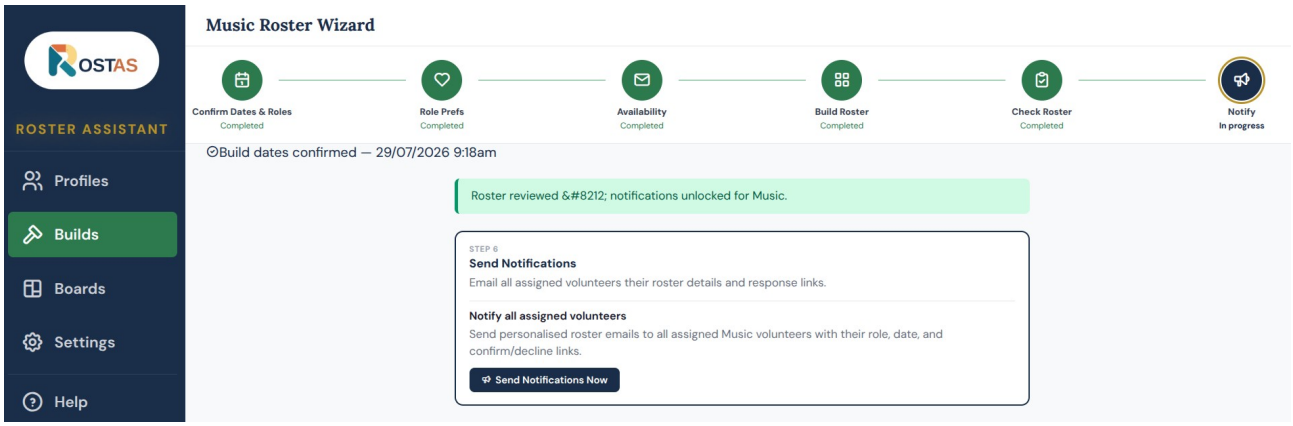


The board in review mode, opened from the wizard — click any cell to make a change, then return to the wizard when the roster looks right.

> **Don't skip this step.** It's your last chance to catch problems before volunteers are notified. Check for unfilled slots, confirm the message wording looks right, and make any manual swaps needed.

Step 6 — Notify

Once you're satisfied with the roster, click **Send Notifications Now**. Every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments and a "Can't make it?" link.

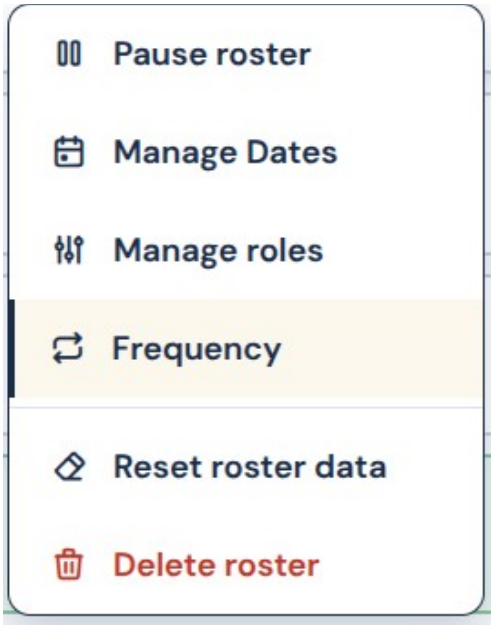


Step 6 — Notify. With notifications sent, all six steps show complete on the rail and automatic reminders are queued. Start the next cycle whenever you're ready.

- Reminder email sent 3 days before each service date (change this in Settings → Timing & behaviour → Reminder days before service)
- The day before, an app notification — or a text, depending on Settings → Timing & behaviour → Day-before reminder texts
- If a volunteer taps "Can't make it" — the SMS replacement chain starts automatically

The Build Menu

The ··· menu on the right of each row on the Builds dashboard holds everything you do with a roster between builds — pausing it, adjusting its dates or roles, changing how often it runs, clearing its data, or deleting it outright. Click it to open a pop-up of options.



The ··· menu open on a roster row. When a roster is paused, the top option reads "Resume roster" instead of "Pause roster".

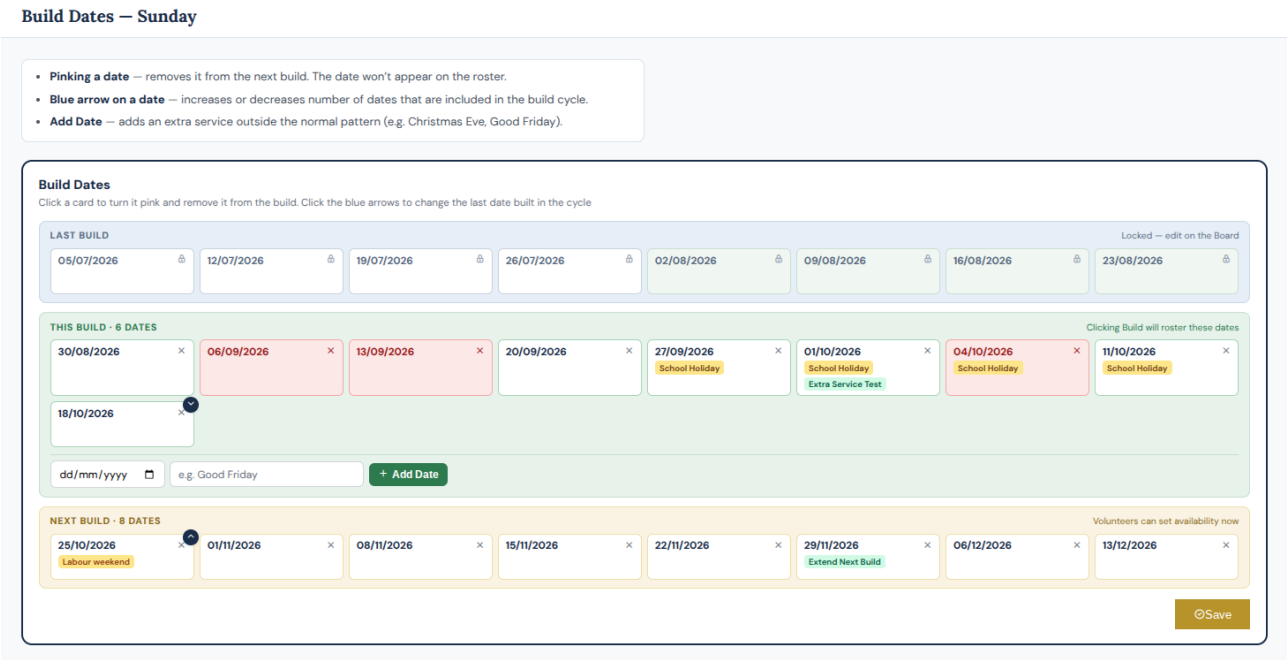
Pause / Resume roster

Pausing a roster stops all automatic activity for it straight away — no builds, no reminder emails or texts, no availability emails or nudges, and no replacement chains (a chain already running stops asking people) — without losing any history. Anything that falls due while it's paused is skipped, not saved up for later. The menu option and the row's state button both switch to **Resume roster** while paused; click either to pick back up exactly where you left off.

Confirming Build Dates

Before each build you confirm exactly which dates it covers, on the **Build Dates** screen. It lays out your roster's dates in three bands — what's already built, what this build will cover, and what's coming next — and lets you drop a date you don't want, shift the boundary between builds, or add a one-off extra date such as Christmas Day or Good Friday.

You reach it two ways: as the first step of a build (Confirm Dates & Roles), or on its own from the Builds dashboard — **⋯** — **Manage Dates**.



The Build Dates screen — each date is a card, grouped into three bands. Coloured tags on a card show anything Rostas has flagged about that date: a public holiday, a long weekend, or a label you've added yourself.

Removing a date

Click the **×** on any card in This Build or Next Build to exclude it — the card turns pink and drops out of the build. Click it again to bring the date back. Cards in Last Build can't be removed this way, since they're already built.

Shifting the boundary between builds

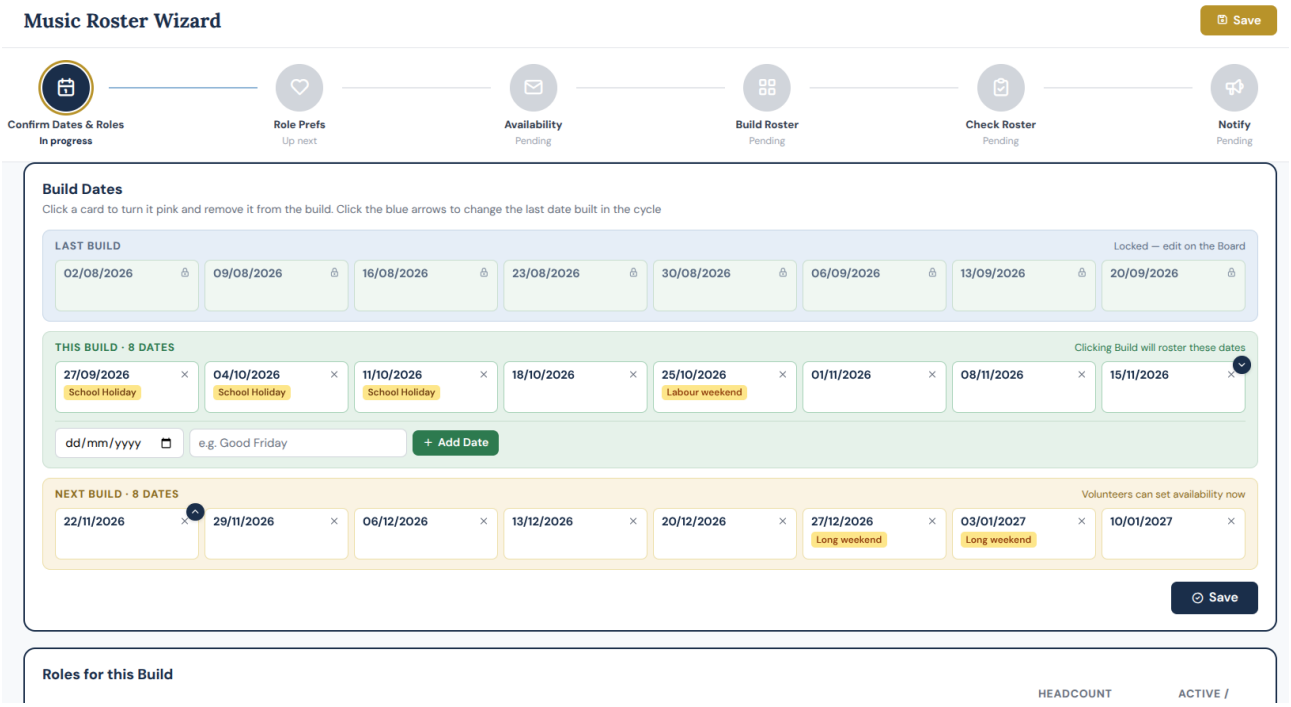
A small chevron sits on the date at the boundary between This Build and Next Build. Click it to move that date across the line — pulling the next upcoming date into This Build to extend how far this build reaches, or sending the last date of This Build back into Next Build to shorten it.

Adding an extra date

Use the date field and label box beneath This Build to add a one-off service outside the normal pattern — Christmas Eve, Good Friday, a special event. Pick the date, type a short label (e.g. "Good Friday"), and click **+ Add Date**. The new card appears in This Build with your label shown as a tag, and is included the next time you build.

> **Holidays are tagged automatically — but tagging and pausing aren't the same thing.** Dates that fall directly on a public holiday or a school holiday are labelled for you, and look distinct from dates you've excluded by

hand, so you can tell an automatic holiday from a deliberate choice. Long weekends (Labour Weekend, Anzac Weekend, and others) get their own distinct yellow tag too — but the tag alone doesn't pause anything. Only a **direct hit** on the public holiday or school holiday itself pauses the roster (and only if you've ticked **Pause public holidays** / **Pause school holidays** for this roster type). A long-weekend Sunday that isn't itself the public holiday still needs rostering as normal — exclude it by hand if you don't want it covered.



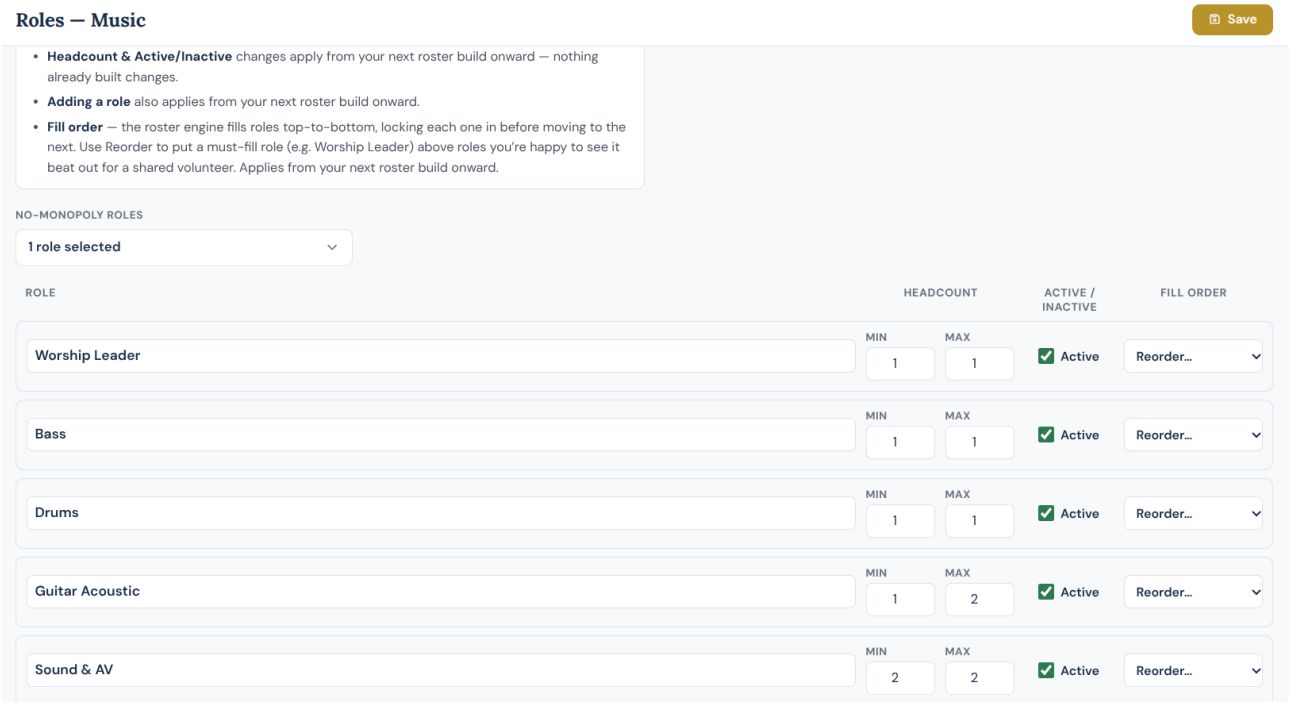
Excluding a date — a common example is the Sunday just after Christmas, when most people are away: click the × to turn it pink and it drops out of the build.

Confirm early. Ideally do this a few weeks before the dates arrive, so there's time to collect availability and build. A **perpetual** roster rolls forward on its own, so each cycle you're simply confirming the next stretch of dates; a **fixed-term** roster is confirmed up to its end date. (See Frequency & Season Type for the difference.)

Nothing changes until you click Save. Removing, shifting, or adding dates only takes effect once you click **Save** at the bottom of the screen — leaving without saving discards your changes. When you open this screen standalone via Manage Dates, saved changes apply from the next build onward; dates already built are never altered.

Managing Roles

Once a roster exists, you can add, rename, re-size, reorder or retire its roles at any time. Open the **Builds** dashboard, click the ⋯ menu on the roster's row, and choose **Manage roles**. The page lists every role for that roster with its headcount and an active switch.



The Manage roles page — each role shows its Headcount (the minimum and maximum people to roster) and an Active / Inactive switch. The engine always tries to fill the minimum and never exceeds the maximum.

Fill order — which role gets first pick

Rostas fills roles **top-to-bottom** in the order they're listed here — locking each one in fully before moving to the next. If a volunteer is capable of more than one role on a roster, whichever role sits higher in this list gets first claim on them for that date.

Use the **Fill Order** control on any role — **Move to top** / **Move up** / **Move down** / **Move to bottom** — to change where it sits. This matters most for a role with a thin, shared bench: putting it higher gives it first pick of your multi-capable volunteers instead of leftovers.

Reordering redistributes, it doesn't create capacity. Moving a role up can close its own shortfall, but only by taking a shared volunteer away from whatever role used to get them first. See Insights for exactly which role would carry that cost before you decide.

Changes apply from your next build onward. Renaming a role, changing its headcount, switching it active or inactive, or adding a new role all take effect at the next build — dates you've already built keep their original roles and wording. Nothing changes underneath the volunteers you've already notified.

Deactivate rather than delete. Deactivating a role keeps the full history of who served in it; it just stops appearing in new builds. Reach for deactivate unless you're correcting a genuine setup mistake.

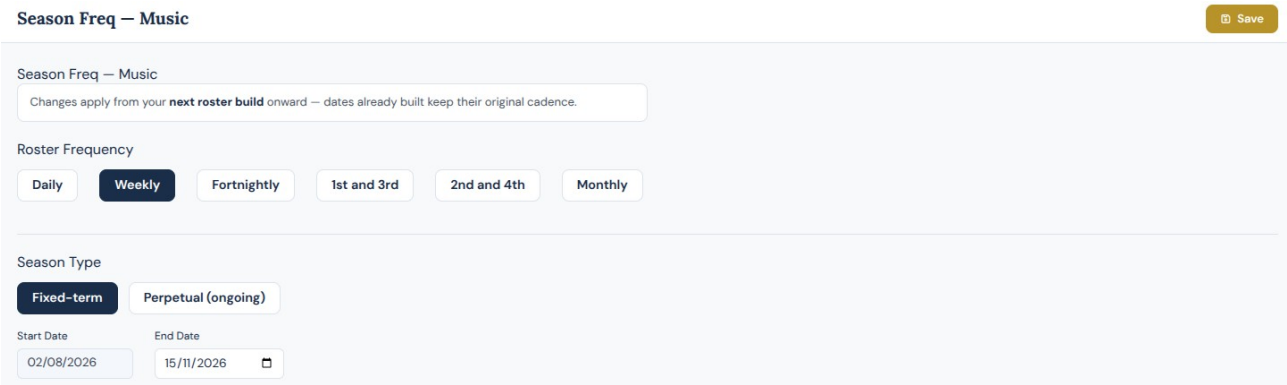
Mind the timing when renaming mid-cycle. Because a rename only affects messages sent after it, volunteers already notified will have the old name in their earlier email or text. If you rename partway through a cycle, expect a brief mismatch until the next build.

Frequency & Season Type

There are two separate frequency ideas in Rostas: how often the *roster* runs, and how often each *volunteer* serves. This section covers the roster side — its cadence and whether the season is fixed or ongoing. The per-volunteer cap is set on each person's profile (see Frequency on the Profile detail page); the two are explained together at the end.

Roster cadence — how often the roster runs

Not every roster runs weekly. A community meal might run fortnightly, a kids' ministry only on the 1st and 3rd Sunday, a review team monthly. The **Frequency** page sets this cadence per roster type — it decides which dates appear in the season, and therefore which dates Rostas builds for. You reach it two ways: when you first create a roster (the Season step of the New Roster Wizard), or any time afterwards from the Builds dashboard — ⋯ — Frequency.



The Frequency page — cadence pills across the top, and the Season Type control below. Changes apply from your next roster build onward; dates already built keep their original cadence.

> **Cadence is set once per roster type** and applies to everyone in it. If two groups run on different weeks, set them up as separate roster types.

Season type — fixed-term or perpetual

Below the cadence pills, the **Season Type** control decides whether this roster has an end or simply keeps going:

> **Perpetual seasons roll forward on their own** — the end date is maintained by Rostas, so you never have to extend them. Most ongoing church rosters (Sunday service, welcome team) suit Perpetual. If you later need a perpetual roster to stop on a set date, switch it to Fixed-term and give it an end date.

Volunteer frequency cap — how often a person serves

Separate from the roster's cadence, each volunteer has their own cap — how often *they* personally get rostered — so nobody is used every week just because they're always free. You set it on each person's profile (Frequency on the Profile detail page), independently for each roster they serve in. The two settings work together:

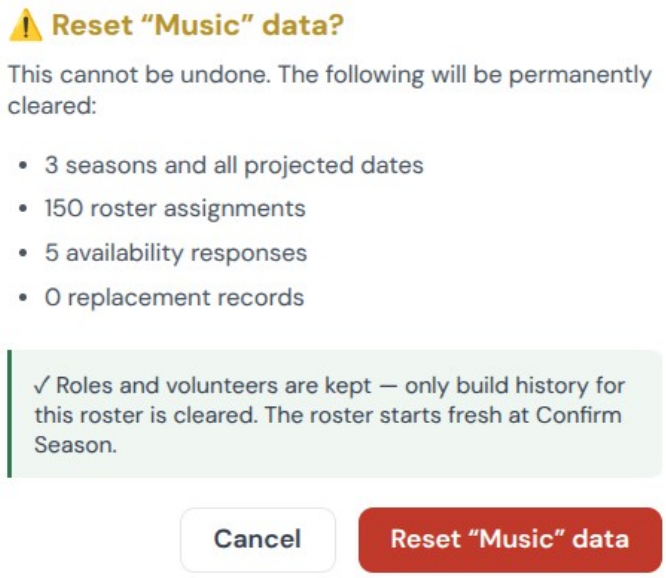
The cap counts distinct service dates, not individual roles. A volunteer in two roles on the same date counts as one service — so serving twice on one Sunday doesn't use two of their allocation.

Resetting Roster Data

Reset roster data clears a roster type's operational history — built assignments, availability responses, replacement chains — without touching the roster's setup: its roles, volunteers, and season stay exactly as they are. It's a pick → preview → confirm flow: choose the roster type, review what will be cleared, then confirm.

> **Built for getting started.** This is the tool for wiping sample or test data before a roster goes live — clear out anything built while you were setting up, then start rostering for real without deleting and re-creating the whole roster type.

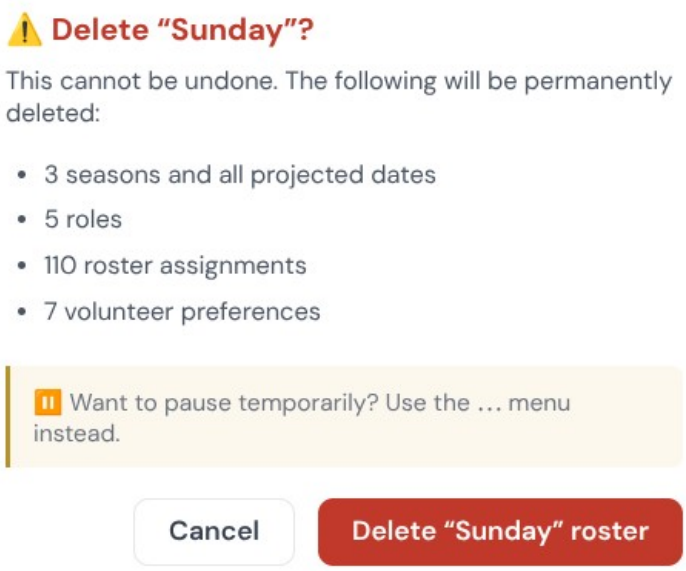
> **Reset vs Delete.** Reset clears history but keeps the roster type itself — its roles and volunteer assignments to it survive. Delete removes the roster type entirely — see Deleting a Roster below. If you're clearing out test data before going live, Reset is almost always what you want.



The Reset roster data confirmation — preview what will be cleared before you commit.

Deleting a Roster

Delete roster permanently removes the roster type — its shell, roles, seasons, build history, and every assignment tied to it. Unlike Reset, there's no going back.



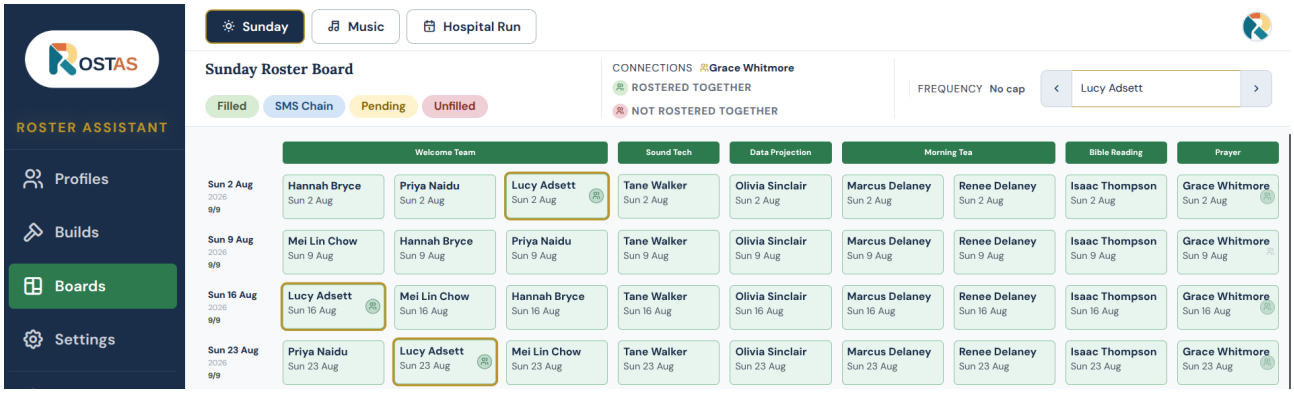
Deleting a roster asks you to confirm, and lists exactly what will be removed — seasons, roles, assignments, and preferences, with real counts. It also nudges you toward pausing instead if you only need a temporary break.

> **Deleting is permanent.** If you only need to stop a roster for a while — over summer, say — use **Pause** from the ⋯ menu instead. Pausing keeps all the roster's history and settings; deleting removes them for good.

The Roster Board is where you manage the roster between builds. You'll come here to check on replacement progress, make manual swaps, confirm pending assignments, or search for a specific volunteer. Access it by clicking **Boards** in the sidebar.

Reading the Board

The Board shows every roster date as a row, with roles as columns. Each cell shows the assigned volunteer's name and date. Colour coding tells you the status of each assignment at a glance.



The Roster Board — dates run down the left, role columns across the top with green headers. Use the roster type tabs at the very top to switch between rosters. The legend and frequency search are in the header row above the grid.

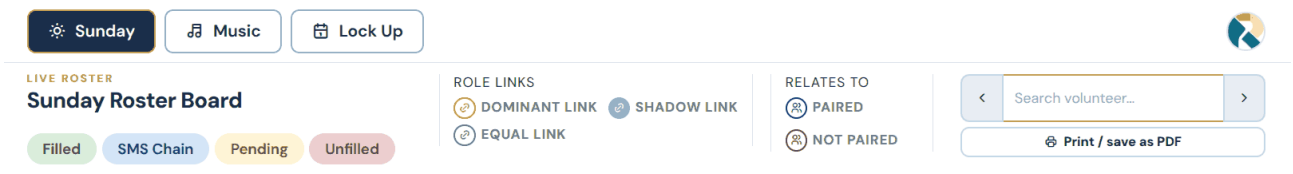
> **White isn't the same as Red.** A red cell is an unfilled slot that needs a volunteer. A white row is a date you deliberately excluded — usually in the Confirm Dates & Roles step, turning a chip pink there. The Board just carries that decision through: the row stays blank on purpose, so it doesn't get mistaken for a gap. White rows aren't clickable — there's no assignment to act on.

Legend and Frequency

The legend row at the top of the board shows the four colours (white excluded dates have no chip of their own). To the right, the **volunteer search** (with ◀ ▶ navigation arrows) lets you find a specific person and step through volunteers one by one. The **Frequency** panel shows how often the currently searched volunteer is rostered and when they were last assigned.

Printing the roster

Under the search box is a **Print / save as PDF** button. It opens the roster you're looking at in a new tab: every date on the board as a row and every role as a column, with everyone's names — ready to print for a noticeboard or hand out. Weeks with no service say so, and people who declined are left out.

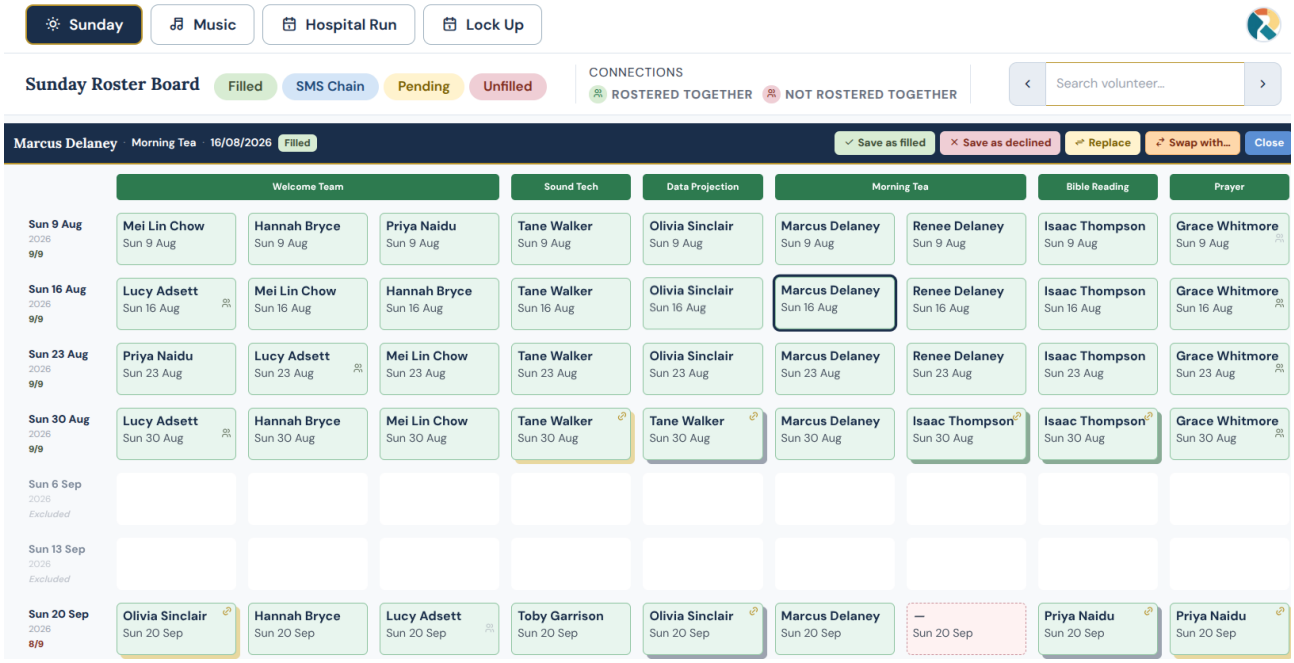


The top of the Roster Board: the legend on the left (Filled, SMS Chain, Pending, Unfilled), and Print / save as PDF under the volunteer search.

Click **Print / save as PDF** at the top of that page. It prints on A4 landscape, and the column headings repeat on every page. To make a PDF instead, choose **Save as PDF** as the printer.

Taking Action on a Cell

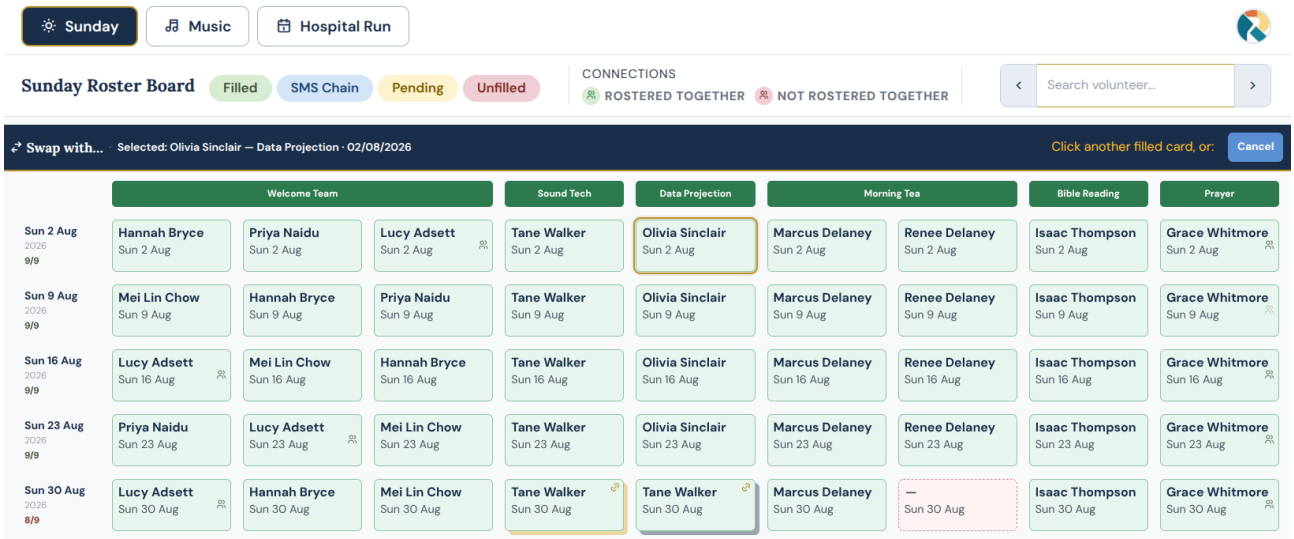
Click any cell on the board to select it. The selected cell gets a navy border and a sticky action bar appears above the green roles headings — showing the volunteer's name, role, date, and current status, with action buttons on the right.



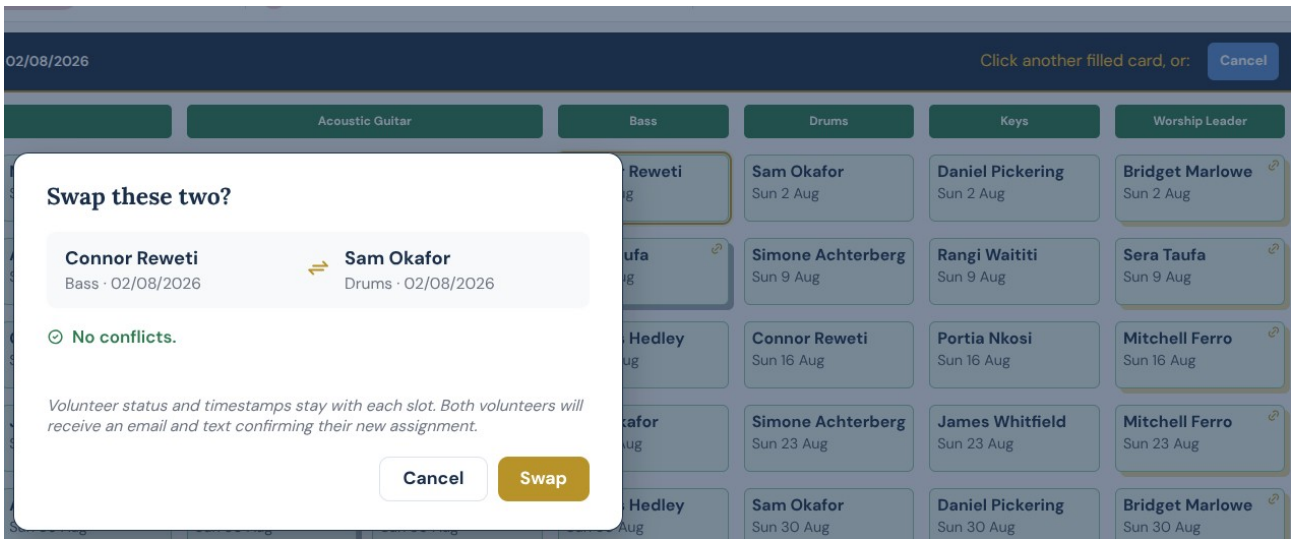
Clicking a cell opens the sticky action bar across the top, showing who is assigned, their role, date, and status.

Swapping two volunteers

When two rostered volunteers want to trade dates, use **Swap with…** from the action menu. Click the first volunteer's cell, choose Swap with…, and that card is "armed" — it takes a gold border. Then click the cell you want to swap it with.

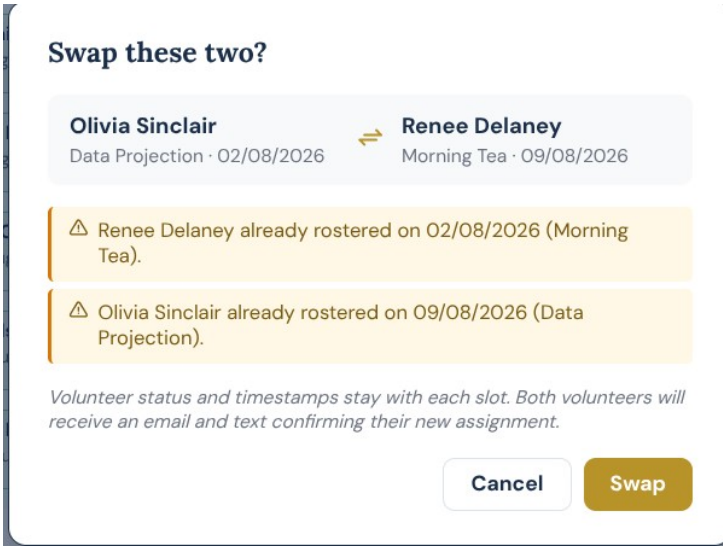


A card armed for swap — its gold border means Rostas is waiting for you to pick the card to swap it with.



A confirmation shows both volunteers, their roles and dates, so you can check the trade before committing.

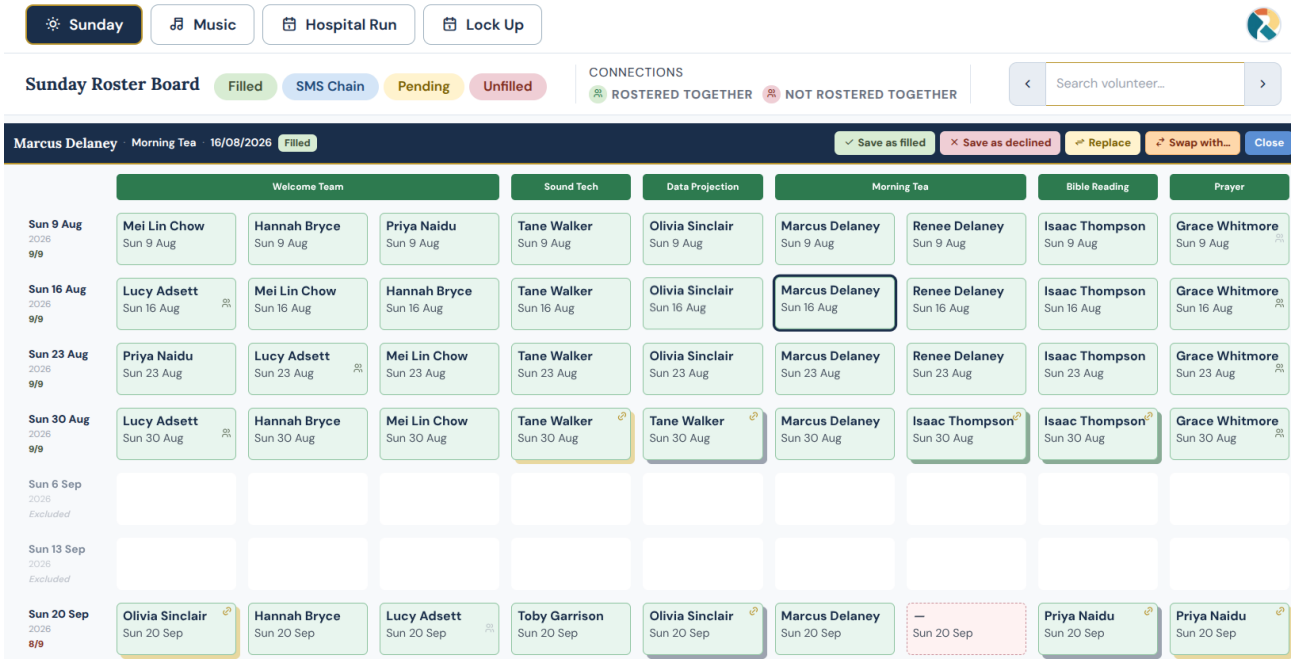
Conflict warnings are advisory, not blocking. If a swap would clash — say a volunteer is already rostered elsewhere that day — Rostas shows amber warnings on the confirmation, but you can still go ahead. It flags the risk and leaves the decision to you.



A swap with conflicts — the amber warnings inform you, but the swap button stays available.

Manual Replacement

When you click **Replace**, the replacement panel appears below the action bar showing all available volunteers for that role and date, sorted by priority tier. Each volunteer shows their availability status and how recently they've been rostered.



The replacement panel — volunteers are grouped by tier. Click Select next to any volunteer to assign them immediately. The original volunteer is released. The new one is told automatically once this roster's notifications have gone out.

The tiers match the engine. Tier 1 volunteers are available and have this as a primary role — the ideal replacement. Lower tiers are less ideal but still valid options. Pick the best fit for the situation.

The replacement volunteer is notified automatically. If this roster's notifications have already gone out, Rostas tells them straight away — an app notification if they have the app, otherwise a text and an email. If you haven't sent notifications yet, they're simply included when you do (Step 6). Either way, you don't need to contact them separately.

Asking a volunteer from another roster

If nobody suitable turns up in the replacement panel's usual tiers, look for a collapsible **"From another roster — contact first"** section near the bottom of the list. It surfaces volunteers who serve on a different roster type but aren't part of this one — a Nourish volunteer showing up as an option for a Sunday gap, for example.

This is a one-off ask, not an addition to the roster. Selecting someone here sends them a one-off request for this single date — the same tiered

app/SMS/email delivery as everywhere else — but doesn't add them to the roster type permanently. Use it for genuine gap-filling, and it's worth a heads-up to the volunteer's usual coordinator since it crosses roster boundaries.

Assigning a Second Role on the Same Date

Occasionally a volunteer may need to cover two roles on the same date — for example, stepping in for a missing team member while also serving in their usual role. Rostas supports this but flags it clearly so you're making a deliberate choice rather than an accidental double-booking.



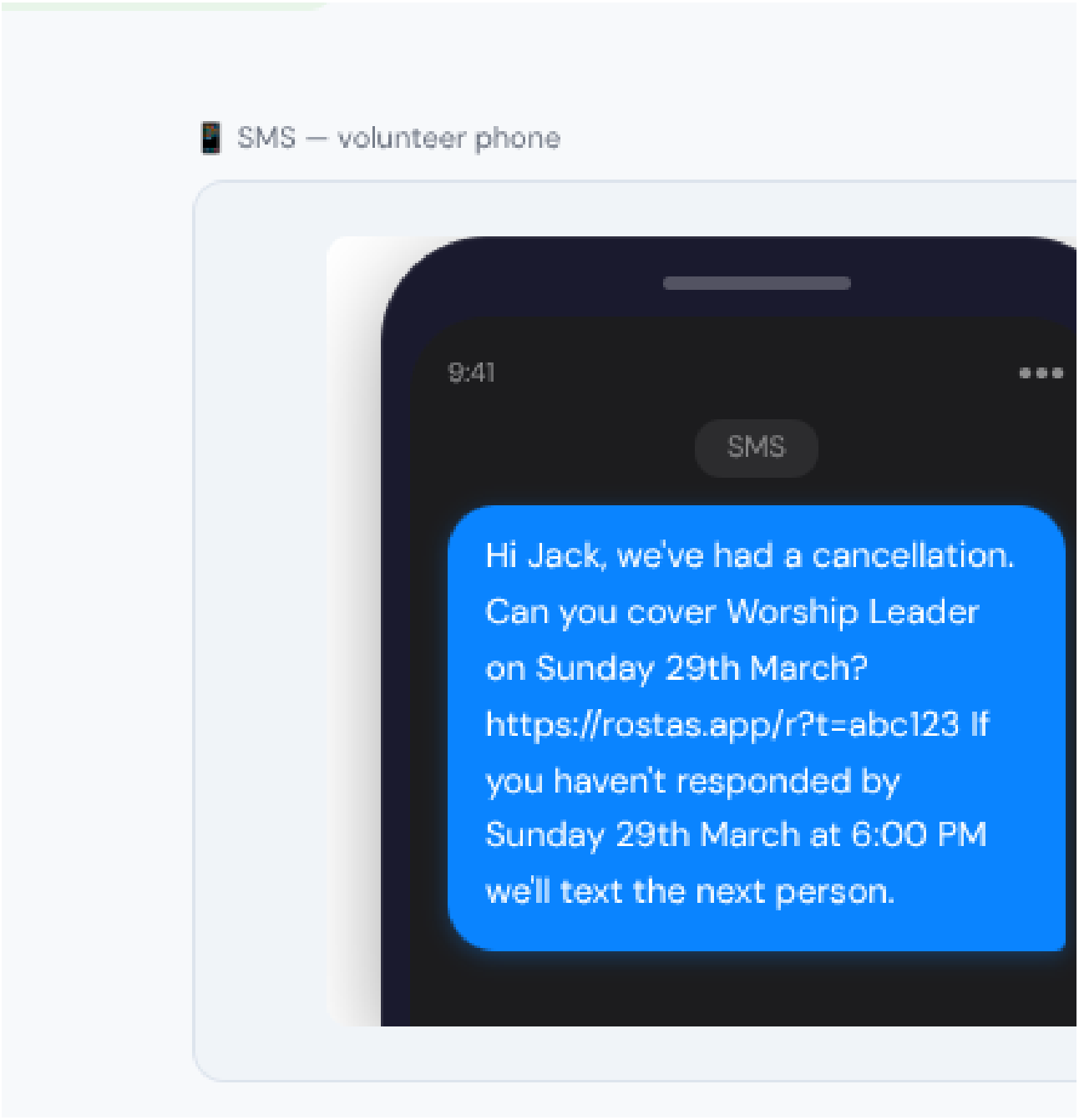
A volunteer holding two roles on one date — Rostas shows both assignments clearly so it reads as a deliberate choice.

> Use this sparingly. Volunteers serving in multiple roles in one service can feel stretched. Always confirm with the volunteer before assigning a second role.

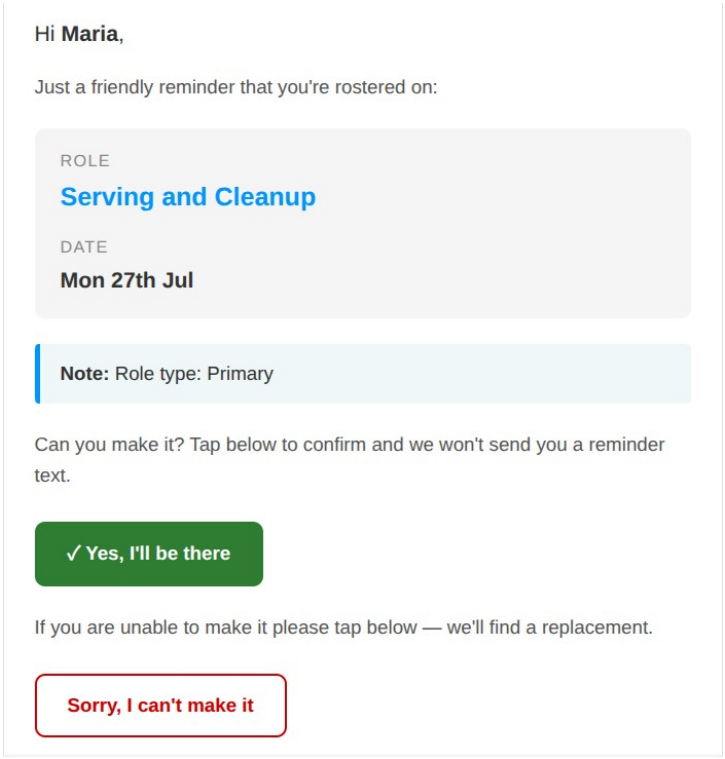
The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" in their notification email — or when you click **Save as declined** on the board — Rostas starts the automated SMS replacement chain. It works through available volunteers one at a time until someone accepts.

The request text carries a **direct personalised link** straight to the accept / decline page — see Part A for the full explanation.



The replacement request SMS — it carries a direct link to the accept / decline page.



The page a volunteer reaches after tapping "Can't make it" — two clear options. If they changed their mind they can reinstate themselves on the spot.

Quiet hours apply to the SMS chain. Messages are never sent during your quiet hours (set in Settings → Timing & behaviour, default 9pm–8am). If the chain reaches a volunteer inside that window it pauses automatically and resumes once quiet hours end. You can monitor progress on the board — cells in the SMS chain state show in blue.

Searching for a Volunteer

Use the search field at the top right of the board to find a specific volunteer. As you type, their assignments are highlighted across the entire board — making it easy to see all their upcoming dates at once. Use the ◀ ▶ arrows to step through volunteers alphabetically. The Frequency panel shows how often the current volunteer is rostered and when they last served.



Searching a volunteer highlights every one of their assignments across the board, so you can see their whole schedule at a glance.

> **Use volunteer search before making a manual replacement.** Search for the volunteer you're thinking of replacing them with first — check they're not already heavily rostered that period before adding another date.

The Settings view is where you configure how Rostas behaves — your organisation's identity, SMS credentials, message wording, timing rules, and more. Open it by clicking **Settings** in the left sidebar.

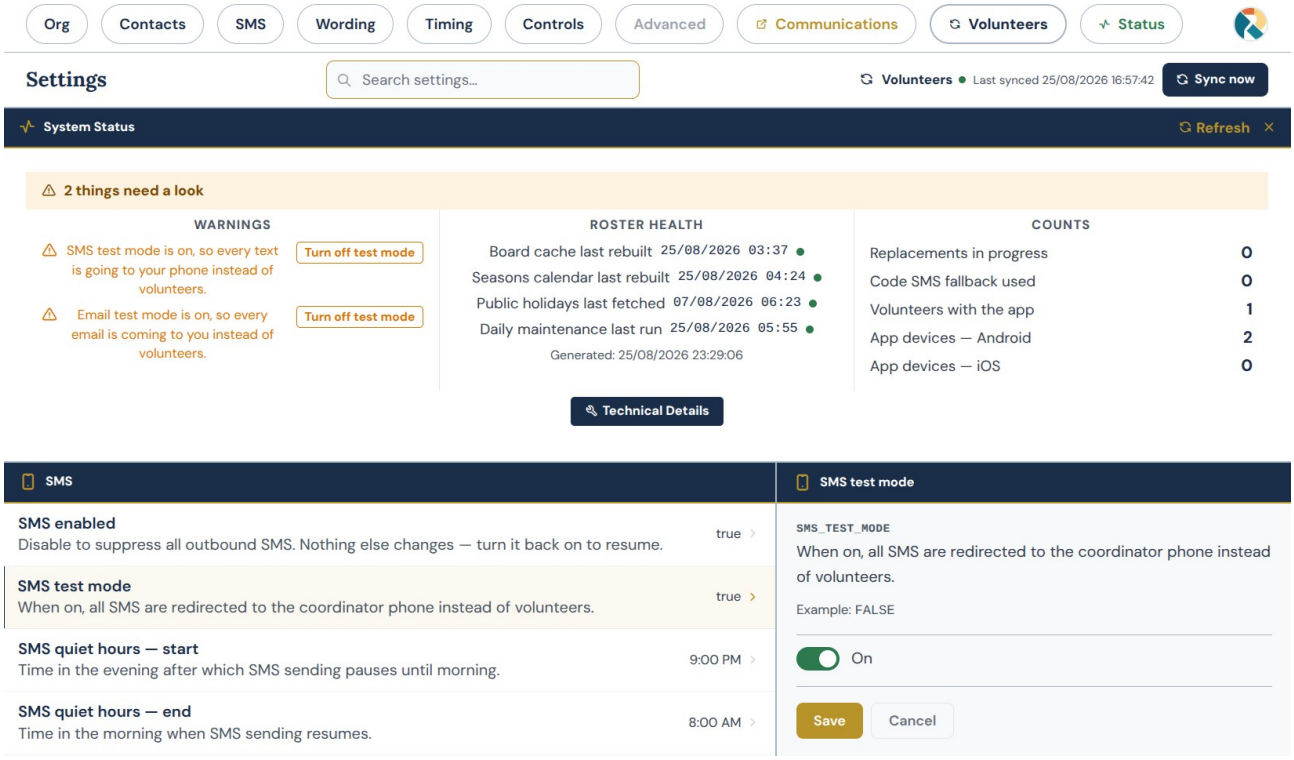
The Settings View

Finding your way around

The Settings view has two parts that work together.

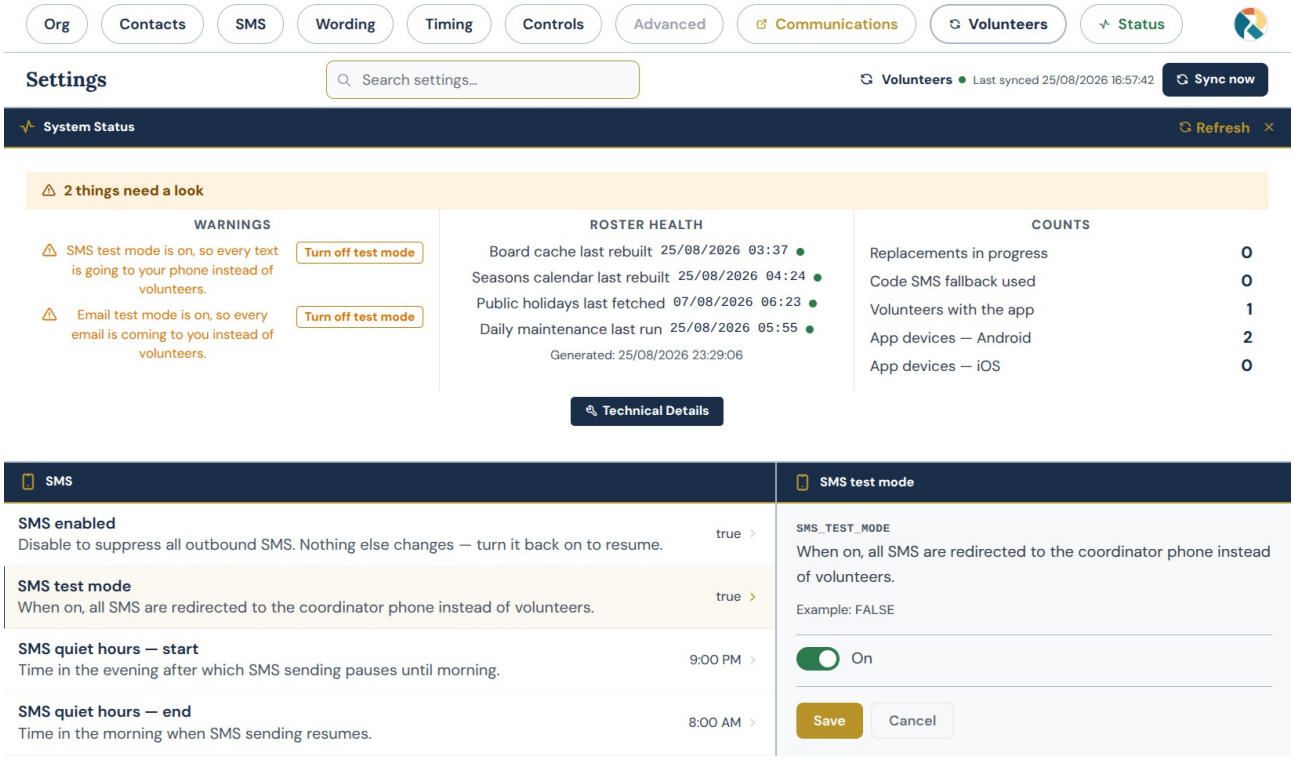
The **chip strip** runs across the top and lets you jump directly to any category — Org, Contacts, SMS, App, Email, Timing, Controls, Advanced and Status. Clicking a chip scrolls the left panel to that section instantly. The gold **Comms** chip (with an arrow) opens the Communications Preview in place of Settings — use it to see how your message templates look before sending.

The **search bar** (top right, "Search settings...") filters the left panel live as you type. It searches across setting names and descriptions simultaneously — so typing "SMS" shows not just the SMS category but any setting whose description mentions SMS, across all categories. Non-matching rows disappear; categories with no matches collapse. Clear the search to restore the full list.



The chip strip across the top of Settings — click any category pill to jump straight to that section. The gold Communications chip opens the message preview. The System Status panel is visible at the top of the left panel.

The two-column layout

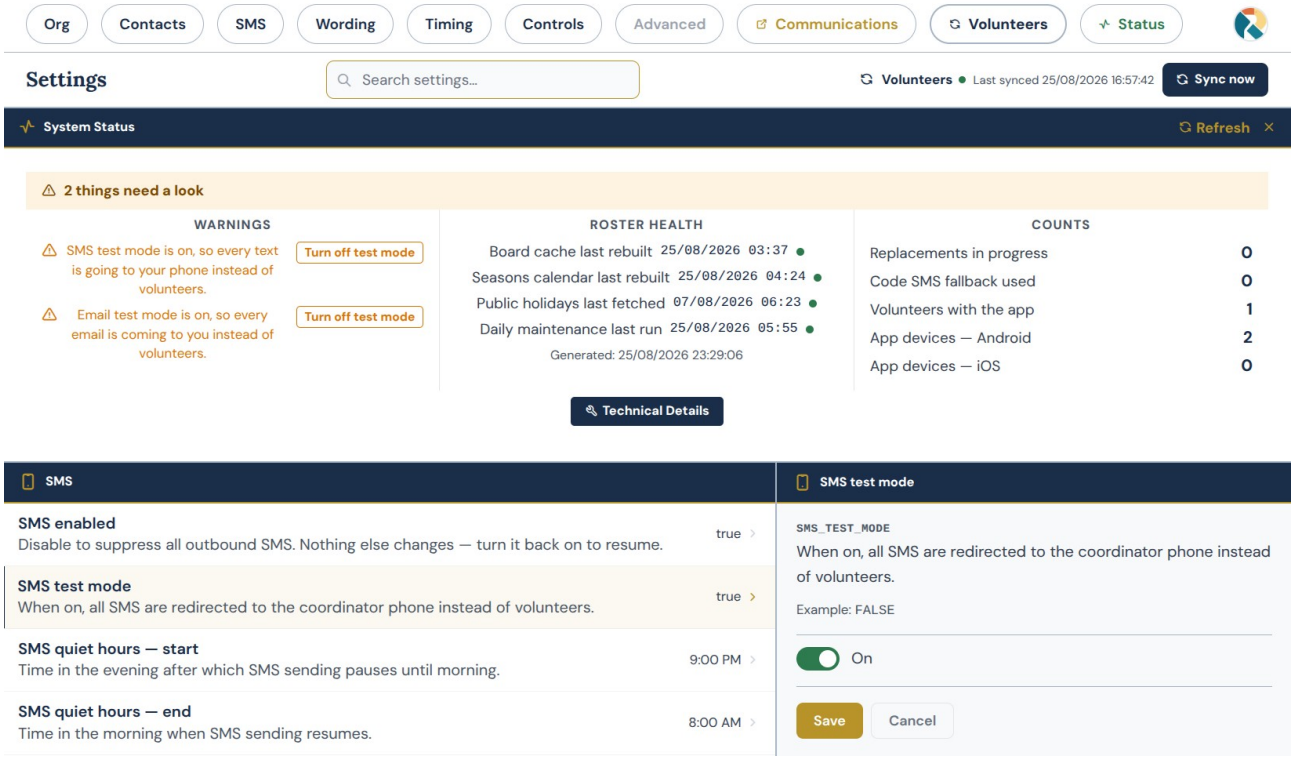


The two-column layout — categories and settings in the scrollable left panel, the selected setting's detail and edit field in the sticky right panel.

- **Left panel** — the scrollable list of all settings, grouped by category. Each row shows the setting name, a one-line description, and its current value on the right. Click any row to open it for editing.
- **Right panel** — appears when you click a row. Shows the full description, an example value, the input field, and Save/Cancel buttons. The panel stays fixed while you scroll the left panel, so you can read and compare other settings without losing your place.

To close the right panel without saving, click Cancel or click a different row.

Editing a setting



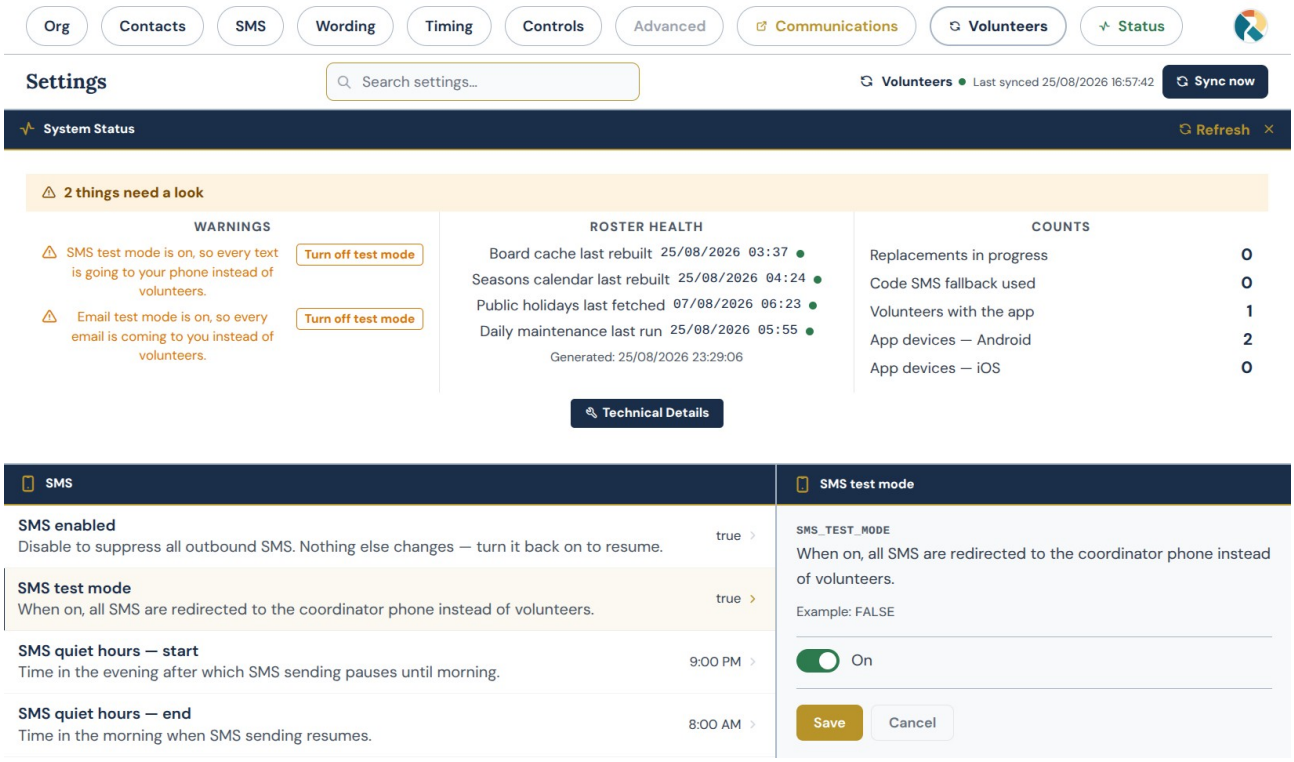
The right panel — key name at top, friendly label, full description, example value, and the input field. Validation runs as you type. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.

10. Click the row in the left panel. The right panel opens showing the setting name, description, and current value pre-filled in the input.
11. Make your change. The input type matches the setting — dropdowns for timezone and country code, toggles for on/off settings, text fields for everything else.
12. Validation runs as you type or on blur. If the value is invalid (wrong format, missing required content) the field turns red with an explanation. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.
13. Click **Save**. The left panel updates immediately to show the new value — no page reload needed.

Using System Status

The System Status card and the settings list below it are designed to work together. The card tells you what's wrong; the settings list is where you fix it.

Treat System Status as your starting point every time you open the Settings page. Before searching for a specific setting or making a planned change, glance at the Warnings column first. If it says "No warnings", you can proceed. If it shows amber or red, deal with those first, because some warnings mean volunteers aren't receiving messages right now.



The System Status panel — three columns showing current warnings, roster health indicators, and message counts. Check this panel if volunteers aren't receiving messages or something seems off.

Following a warning to its fix

Each warning in the System Status card says in plain words what's wrong, and most carry their own button that takes you straight to the setting that fixes it:

The typical workflow is: read the warning → click its button → save the setting that opens. If a warning has no button, the search bar above the settings list finds the setting by name.

After making a change, check the card again

The System Status card doesn't update automatically when you save a setting — it loaded when you opened Settings and reflects that moment in time. After fixing a warning, click **Refresh** in the System Status card header to reload it and confirm the warning has cleared.

Understanding your roster's rhythm

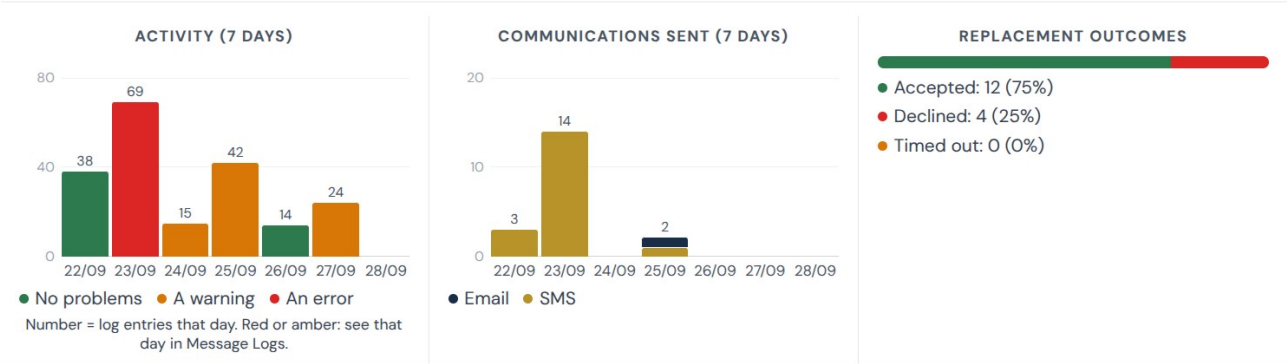
Once warnings are clear, the lower sections of the card give you a different kind of visibility — not problems to fix, but patterns to understand. Two of them are worth checking regularly.

- **Message Logs** — a table of what Rostas did today, oldest first: every reminder, replacement ask, swap and roster message, with who it went to, how it was

sent and how they answered. Use the date picker to look at an earlier day, and tick **Show system events too** to include behind-the-scenes events such as volunteer syncs and roster builds. Click **Key: what the colours and labels mean** above the table for a full explanation. In short: a pale red row means something failed and a pale yellow row is a warning (both always shown); in the Response column, green means the volunteer said yes, gold means still waiting, amber means no reply in time, and red means declined or not sent. This is your first-stop diagnostic: if a volunteer says they didn't get a message, pick that day and look for them.

- **Communication Failures** — the most direct troubleshooting tool, shown in the Warnings column. When all is well it reads "No comms failures"; otherwise it lists recent send errors and warnings. If a volunteer tells you they never received a replacement SMS, check here for an entry on the date in question. If you see nothing at all for that date, the message may have been suppressed before sending — check SMS enabled, test mode, and quiet hours.

Below Message Logs are three charts:



The System Status charts. Each has a key of coloured dots underneath.

- **Activity (7 days)** — one bar per day. The number is how many log entries Rostas wrote that day. The colour is the worst thing that happened: green for no problems, amber for at least one warning, red for at least one error. For a red or amber day, pick that day in Message Logs to see what went wrong.
- **Communications Sent (7 days)** — how many emails (navy) and texts (gold) went to volunteers each day.
- **Replacement Outcomes** — of the volunteers asked to cover a slot, how many accepted (green), declined (red) or didn't reply in time (amber). A high timed-out share can mean your replacement timers are too short for how quickly your volunteers reply, or that quiet hours are limiting the available sending window.

> A coordinator who builds this habit — open Settings, check System Status, fix any warnings, then do what you came to do — will catch problems before volunteers notice them rather than after.

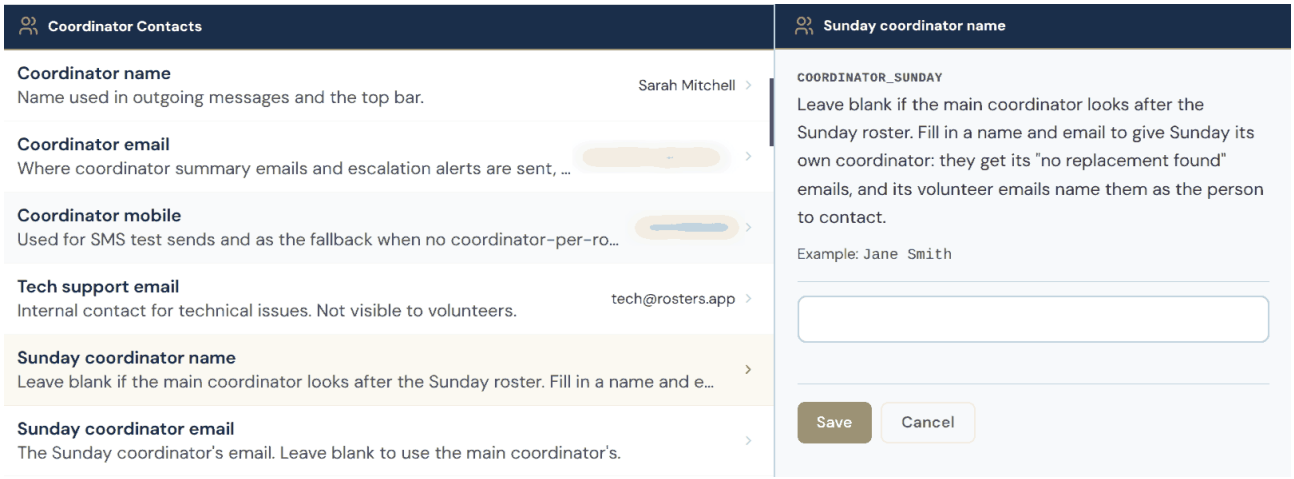
Settings Categories

- **Organisation** — your organisation's name, tagline, timezone, country calling code, contact email, website, volunteer-facing logo, and the logo shown at the top of reminder emails (Email logo URL). The organisation name is the most important field: it appears in every SMS and email sent to volunteers as [OrgName]. Every email Rostas sends also comes from this name. Get this right first.
- **Coordinator Contacts** — your name, email and mobile, plus an optional coordinator for each roster (see A different coordinator for one roster). The “no replacement found” email goes to the **Organisation email** under Organisation, unless the roster has its own coordinator.
- **SMS** — the wording of every text Rostas sends (replacement request, manual replacement, cross-roster ask, swap, availability nudge, reminder). Each has a live character counter and a placeholder check. See Message wording below.
- **App** — the wording of the app notifications that stand in for those texts when a volunteer has the app.
- **Email wording** — the text blocks in roster, reminder and swap emails (intro, arrival note, sign-offs).
- **Timing & Behaviour** — each roster's service start time, how many weeks ahead to build rosters, freeze weeks, availability form deadline, reminder timing and day-before reminder texts, SMS quiet hours, replacement timers, and public holiday region. The **Public holidays region** field includes a dropdown of supported countries and a "Fetch holidays now" button — use this to pull the latest public holidays for your country whenever you update this setting.
- **Quick Controls** — the on/off switches: SMS enabled, the three test modes (SMS, Email, App push), and a switch to show or hide each roster type on the Builds dashboard and the Board. Hiding a roster doesn't stop its reminders; to stop everything for a while, use **Pause roster** (Builds → ⋯).
- **Advanced** — settings that affect system internals (web app URL, licence key, roster type list, Infoodle and AWS SMS keys). These are locked by default. Click Unlock to edit in the right panel and read the warning carefully before changing anything here. Incorrect values can stop roster builds or break SMS links. Contact tech support if unsure.

A different coordinator for one roster

You (the main coordinator) look after every roster unless you say otherwise. If one roster is run by someone else — say your music director runs the Music roster — give that roster its own coordinator:

14. Go to **Settings → Coordinator Contacts**.
15. Find that roster's tiles, e.g. **Music coordinator name**, **Music coordinator email** and **Music coordinator mobile**.
16. Fill in at least the name and email. Anything left blank uses your details.



Settings → Coordinator Contacts. Your own details come first; each roster's tiles follow. Leave a roster's tiles blank and you look after it.

From then on, for that roster only:

- the **“no replacement found”** email goes to them;
- volunteer emails for that roster (roster, reminder, availability, role preference and swap emails) say “get in touch with” them and are signed off with their name.

Everything else stays with you: emails that cover more than one roster, your coordinator link, and the test modes. Give each roster its own coordinator, or just the one or two that need it. To hand a roster back to yourself, clear its name and email.

SMS Settings in Detail

Three settings here are worth understanding before you go live.

> **SMS enabled** (Quick Controls) — the master kill switch. When this is false, no SMS leaves Rostas at all — not replacements, not reminders, not test sends. The System Status card shows a red warning when this is off. Only disable it deliberately (e.g. during a migration or if you need to pause sending temporarily).

> **SMS test mode** (Quick Controls) — when true, every SMS that would go to a volunteer is redirected to the coordinator mobile instead. The message is prefixed with [TEST - would go to candidate]. Use this while setting up or testing replacement chains. Turn it off before your first real roster cycle. The System Status card shows an amber warning when test mode is on.

Quiet hours — SMS quiet hours start and end (Settings → Timing & behaviour) are set as times of day, e.g. 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM. Rostas will not send any SMS outside this window, including replacement chain advances. If a replacement request hits quiet hours, it waits until the quiet period ends before texting the next candidate. The default is 9pm–8am.

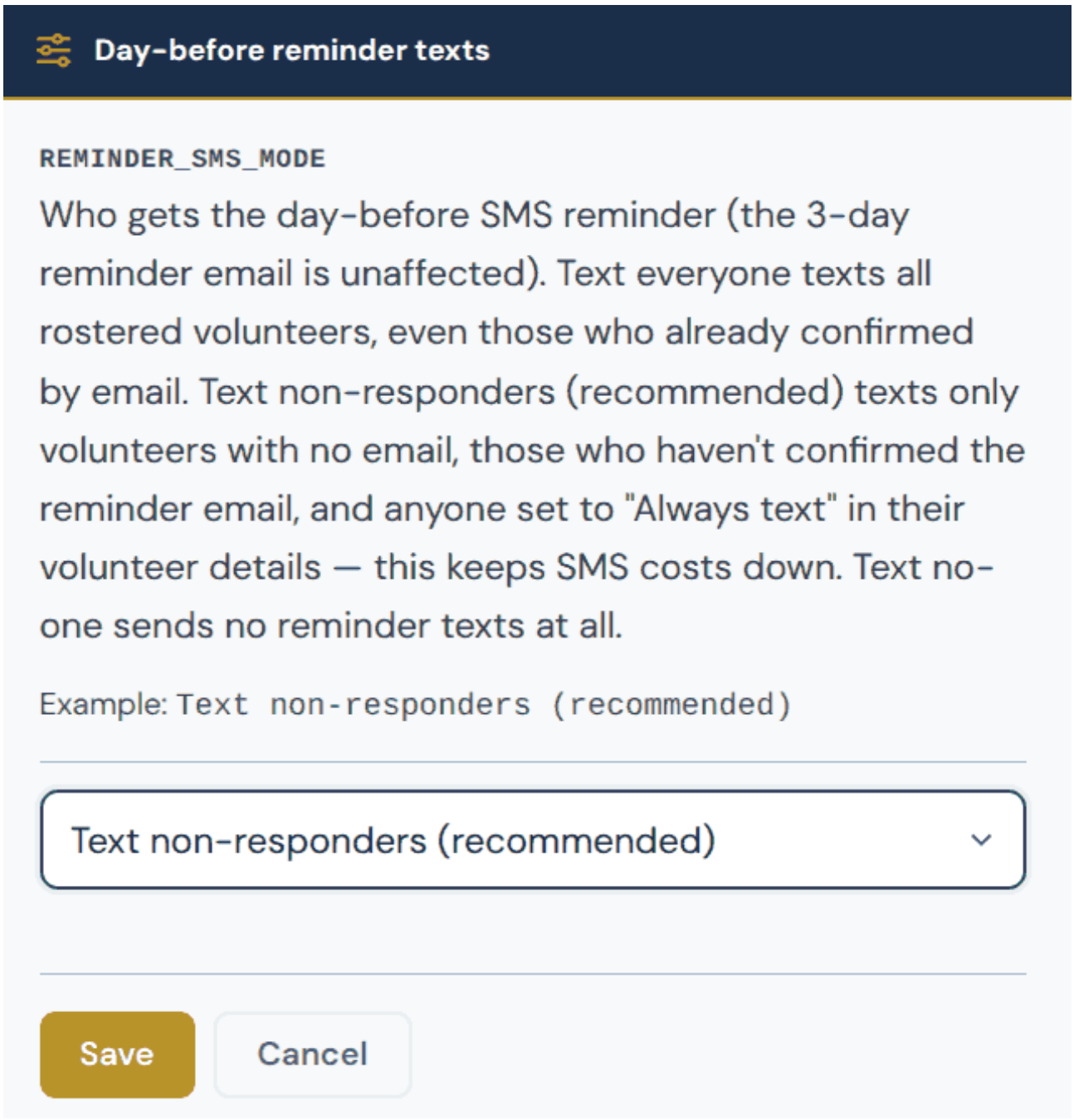
Replacement timers (Settings → Timing & behaviour) — three escalation speeds:

- **Normal** (default 120 min) — used when the service is more than 24 hours away
- **Urgent** (default 30 min) — used when the service is within 24 hours
- **Panic** (default 10 min) — used when the service is within 2 hours

If volunteers are frequently timing out before responding, consider increasing the normal timer. If you're often scrambling at short notice, reducing the urgent or panic timers gets through the candidate list faster.

Reminder SMS mode — controlling reminder texts

The day-before reminder text is the single biggest driver of SMS cost — one text per rostered volunteer, every service. The **Day-before reminder texts** setting (Settings → Timing & behaviour) decides who actually receives it. (The 3-day reminder *email* is unaffected and still goes to everyone with an email address.)

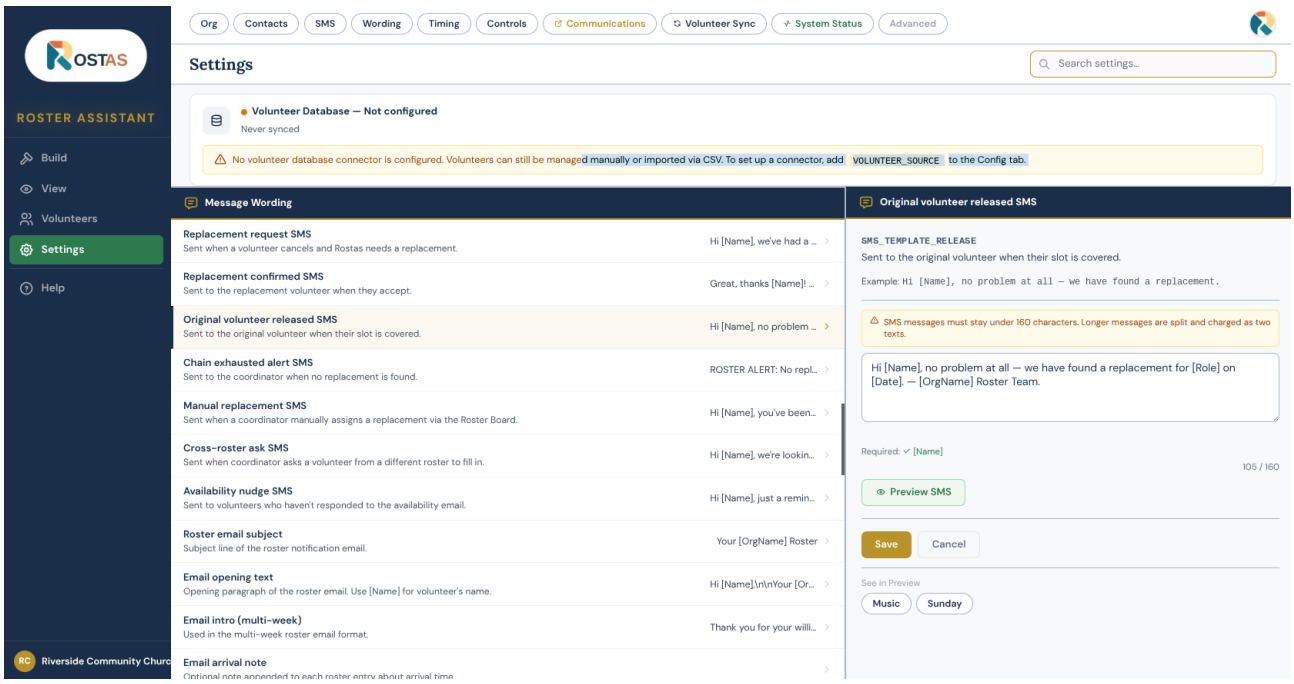


Reminder SMS mode — choose who gets the day-before text.

Text non-responders is the default, and the best value for most churches. It leans on free email and only spends a text where it'll actually help — someone with no email, or who hasn't confirmed. For the few volunteers who reliably miss email, turn on "Always text" on their profile so they still get a text under Text non-responders.

Message wording

Every SMS template has three protections built in to prevent accidental breakage.

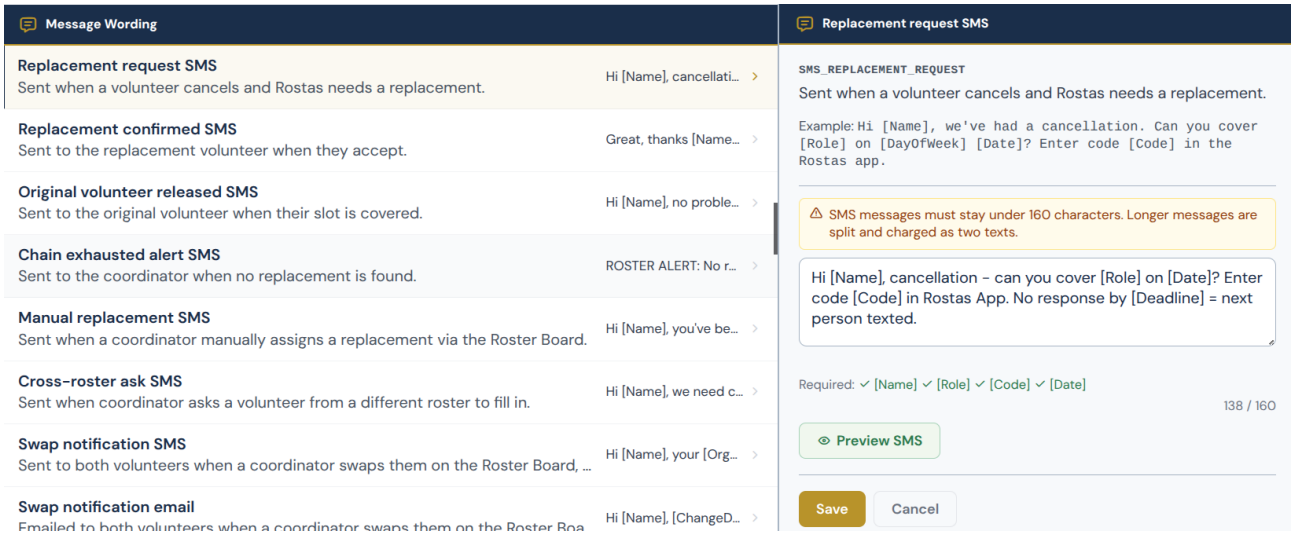


SMS template fields show a live character counter (105/160 in this example), the required placeholder list, and a Preview SMS button. The Save button is disabled if the message exceeds 160 characters or is missing a required placeholder.

- **Character counter** — SMS messages over 160 characters are split into two by carriers and charged as two texts. The counter below the textarea turns amber at 140 characters and red at 161+. The Save button is disabled when the count is red. The SMS templates are deliberately terse for this reason — when you edit one, the counter is protecting your church's SMS costs, not just formatting. One thing the counter can't see: curly quotes, em dashes and other characters outside standard GSM-7 text count double towards that 160-character limit, so a message that looks short can still split into two texts. Stick to plain straight quotes and hyphens when editing SMS wording.
- **Required placeholders** — each template has a set of placeholders that must be present for it to work correctly. For example, the replacement request SMS must include [Link] — without it, the volunteer has nothing to tap. Missing placeholders are shown in red below the textarea. Save is blocked until all required placeholders are present.
- **Preview SMS** — click this button to see the template rendered with realistic sample values substituted in ([Name] → Sarah, [Role] → Welcome Team, [Date] → today's date, [Link] → a sample link). This shows you exactly what a volunteer will read, at the correct character count. It does not send a real SMS.

> All placeholder names use square brackets: [Name], [Role], [Date], [Link], [OrgName], [Deadline]. Never use curly braces — {name} will not be substituted.

Message wording lives in three categories: **SMS** (replacement request, manual replacement, cross-roster ask, swap, availability nudge, reminder), **App** (the matching app notifications), and **Email wording** (roster email intro, arrival note and sign-off; reminder email opening, can't-make-it text and sign-off; swap email). The protections above apply to every text template.



The message-wording templates — each opens to an editor with its own character counter and required placeholders.

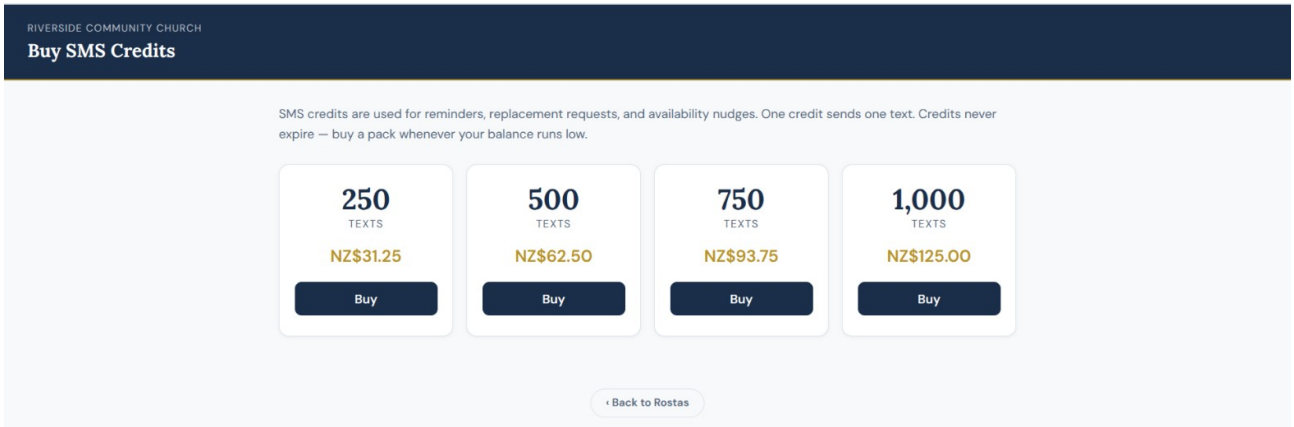
Template Placeholders

SMS and email templates use placeholders in square brackets that Rostas replaces with real values when sending. Never remove a required placeholder — if a required one is missing, the Save button is blocked.

SMS Credits

Sending SMS costs money — unlike email, every text has a real per-message cost from the mobile networks. Rostas covers this with a simple prepaid credit system: **one credit sends one text.** Every text uses them — reminders, replacement requests (automatic, manual and cross-roster), roster-change texts and availability nudges — and they never expire — you top up whenever your balance runs low.

Your first 20 SMS credits are free. Every new Rostas subscription starts with 20 credits so you can try texts straight away. After that, texts use prepaid credits: buy a pack from the Buy SMS Credits page whenever your balance runs low.

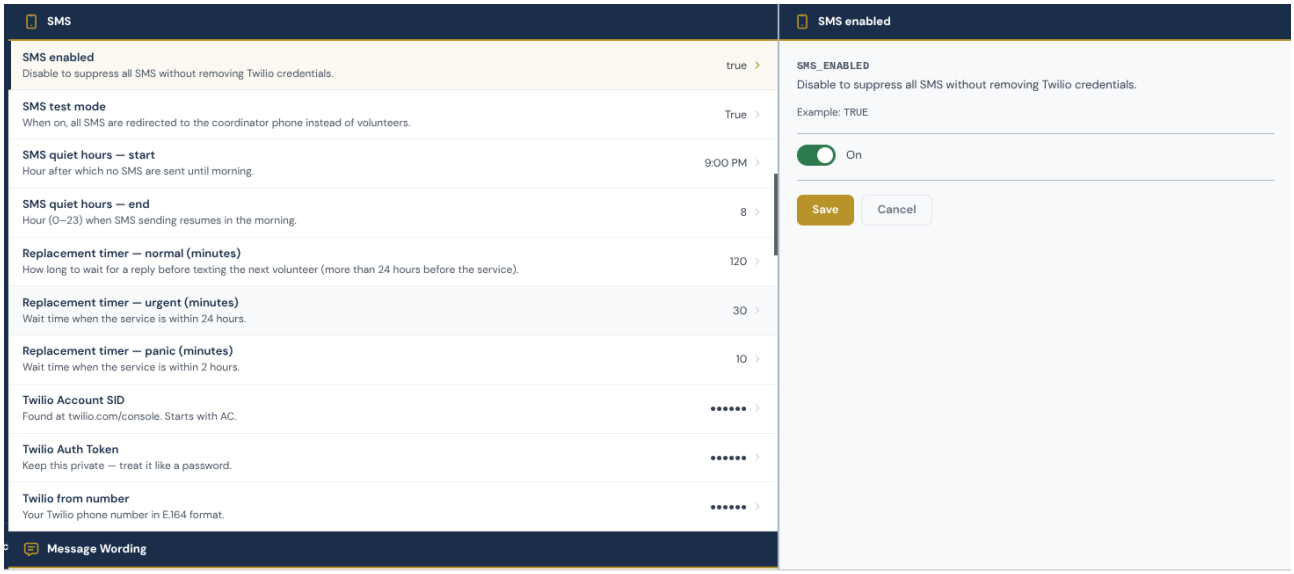


The Buy SMS Credits page — four prepaid packs. The large number is how many texts the pack buys; the price is below it. Credits never expire.

Keeping SMS costs down. Reminders are the biggest driver of SMS use — one text per rostered volunteer before every service. If you'd like to stretch your credits further, email reminders cost nothing, and you can rely on SMS mainly for the time-sensitive replacement chain. Your Rostas contact can help you tune this.

Quick Controls

Quick Controls contains the most commonly needed on/off switches. Check these if something isn't behaving as expected.



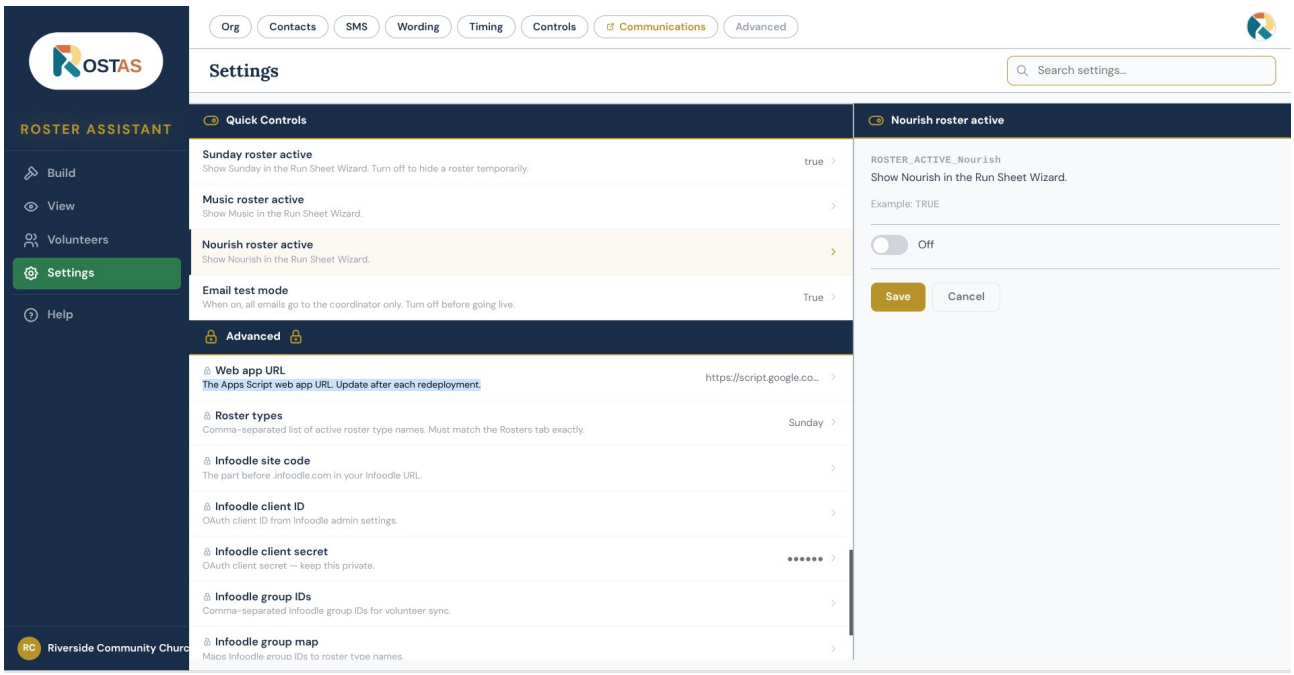
Toggle fields in the right panel — a single switch with immediate visual feedback. The current state is always visible in the left panel list before you even click the row.

> **Always check test modes are OFF before sending a real roster.**
> While a test mode is on, that channel's messages come to you instead of volunteers: SMS test mode redirects texts, Email test mode redirects emails, and App push test mode redirects app notifications.

Advanced Settings

The Advanced section is collapsed by default and greyed out. It contains settings that the system needs to function but that coordinators rarely need to touch. Changing them incorrectly can cause roster builds to fail or SMS links to break.

To edit an advanced setting: click the row, read the amber warning in the right panel, then click **Unlock to edit**. The field becomes editable. Save as normal.



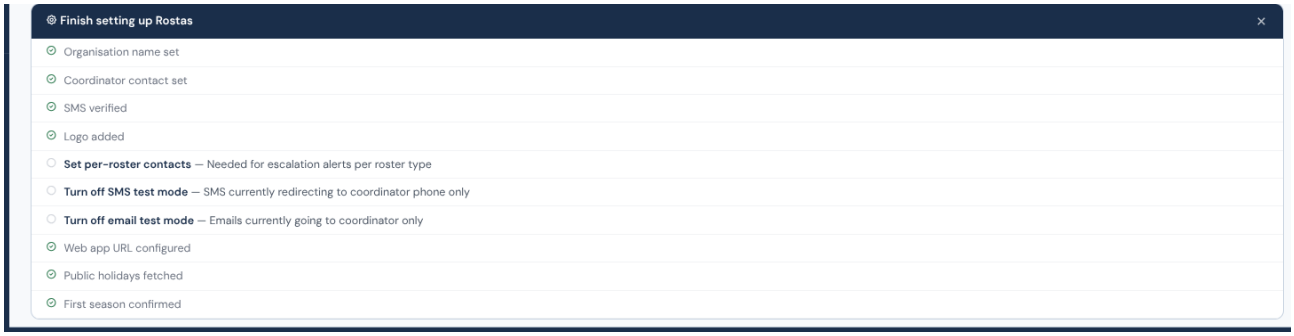
Advanced settings are collapsed by default and each row shows a lock icon. Click "Unlock to edit" in the right panel to make changes — only do this if you're confident about what you're changing.

You'll rarely need the Advanced section. Only change the **Web app URL** if Rostas support asks you to — if it's wrong, the links in texts and emails stop working.

> Advanced settings can break things if changed incorrectly. If you're unsure, leave them as they are or contact your tech support person before making changes.

Setup Checklist

After the initial setup wizard completes, a checklist card appears at the top of the Settings view. It shows which setup tasks are done and which still need attention before going live. The checklist covers ten items — click any incomplete item to jump straight to the relevant setting.



The setup checklist — ticked items are confirmed complete by reading the current Config values, open circles need attention. Click any item to open the relevant setting. The card disappears by itself once every item is ticked.

The checklist goes away by itself once every item is ticked. To hide it sooner, click Dismiss; it won't appear again. If you dismiss it with items still incomplete, you can still fix them through the normal settings list — the checklist is a guide, not a gate.

Troubleshooting

Most issues in Rostas fall into a small number of categories. Work through this list before contacting tech support.

Volunteers aren't receiving SMS messages

- Check **Settings → Quick Controls → SMS enabled** is on
- Check **SMS test mode** is off — while it's on, every text goes to the coordinator instead
- Check the volunteer's SMS toggle is On in their detail page
- Check quiet hours — no texts go out during your quiet hours (Settings → Timing & behaviour; 9pm–8am unless you've changed it)
- Check the volunteer's mobile number is in correct international format (+64…)
- Check the System Status communication failures table for error messages on the relevant date

Volunteers aren't receiving emails

- Check **Email test mode** is off in Quick Controls
- Check the volunteer's Email toggle is On in their detail page
- Ask the volunteer to check their spam/junk folder
- Confirm their email address is correct in their volunteer detail page

Roster has unfilled slots after building

- Check that enough volunteers have responded to the availability email
- Check that volunteers have role preferences set — without preferences set, the engine can't assign them to specific roles
- Check frequency caps — volunteers who've reached their frequency cap (once every N weeks) won't be assigned again until it allows
- Consider rebuilding after more availability responses come in
- Use manual replacement on the Board to fill remaining slots

SMS replacement chain isn't progressing

- Check quiet hours — the chain waits during your quiet hours and carries on automatically when they end
- Check **SMS enabled** is on, and that the roster isn't paused (Builds → ⋯)
- Check there are eligible volunteers left on the backup list — if the list is exhausted, Rostas emails that roster's own coordinator if it has one, otherwise your Organisation email (set it in Settings → Organisation)
- Use manual replacement on the Board to assign someone directly

"Sorry, unable to open the file at this time"

This Google message almost always means your browser is signed in to **more than one Google account**. Google can't tell which account should open Rostas, and you may see `u/1/` in the address bar. Rostas itself is fine.

- **Every day:** open Rostas from its icon in your Church profile (see Put Rostas on your desktop). That profile has only the church account in it, so the problem can't happen.
- **Right now, as a one-off:** open the link in a private window (Chrome: **Ctrl+Shift+N** on Windows, **⌘+Shift+N** on a Mac) and paste the address there.
- Deleting `u/1/` from the address doesn't help: Chrome puts it straight back. Signing in to the church account first doesn't help either.

When to contact tech support

Contact your tech support person if:

- SMS messages are failing with error messages in the System Status communication failures table
- Volunteer links have stopped working (they open an error or a sign-in page)
- You need to change SMS provider or other API credentials
- Something is producing repeated errors that don't resolve on their own
- Anything requiring access to the Google Apps Script editor

> **When contacting tech support**, include a description of what you were doing, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. A screenshot of any error message or the System Status panel is very helpful.

Connectors

Most organisations get their volunteers into Rostas by importing a CSV — it works for everyone and needs nothing more than a spreadsheet. But if your church or organisation already keeps its people in another system, a **connector** can sync them into Rostas automatically, so you don't maintain two lists by hand.

> **Connectors sync identity only.** A connector brings across each person's *name, mobile, and email* — nothing more. Everything about *how* they serve — which rosters they're in, the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with — is set up and lives entirely inside Rostas. Your other system stays the source of truth for contact details; Rostas stays the source of truth for rostering.

Infoodle

Infoodle is the first connector available in Rostas. Once it's connected, new and updated contacts flow in on their own — a volunteer added in Infoodle appears in your Profiles list without a re-import, and a changed phone number or email updates itself.

When someone is removed in Infoodle, Rostas doesn't delete them out from under you. Instead it flags them with a **"Deleted in Infoodle"** marker in the Profiles list, so you can confirm they should go and remove them here deliberately — protecting you from losing a volunteer's history by accident.

> **Setting up the Infoodle connector is done with Rostas, not self-serve.** The connection uses credentials that are provisioned for your church rather than entered by a coordinator — so if you'd like Infoodle sync switched on, contact support@rostas.app and it'll be set up for you.

Other connectors

Infoodle is the first of a growing family of connectors. Support for other church and volunteer platforms — such as Planning Center and Elvanto — is planned, so more organisations can sync rather than import over time.

> **Not on the list yet?** These connectors are on the roadmap rather than available today, and CSV import works with every system in the meantime — most spreadsheets and databases can export a CSV. If a connector for your platform would help, let your Rostas contact know; it helps prioritise what's built next.

Rostas Coordinator Guide · September 2026